Take Me Home

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26904532.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), everyone is mentioned basically, so i don't want to tag them all :')

Additional Tags:
homesteader!catra, Farmhand!Adora, former soccer star adora, based off art!, friends to lovers to exes to... employee?, then maybe more!, catra is motivated by spite, POV Catra (She-Ra), mentions of minor character death, Adora has anxiety, But you already knew that, Aspec Adora, Demi Adora, Domestic Lesbian Fantasy, I've never had a beta reader in my life and I don't intend to start now

Language:
English

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Part 1 of Take Me Home

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by feistypants

Summary

Catra didn't realize how much she was actually taking on by buying this homestead out from under Weaver, but it didn't take too long for her to figure out that she needed some help. Luckily, someone 'buff, blonde, and absolutely oblivious' has just moved back to town. Is it too much for Catra to take? Or can she handle watching her ex-girlfriend work up a sweat every single day?

Notes

This fic is inspired by this lovely art by the ever so talented bananabluff who was kind enough to give me permission to write a fic about it!

... it got way out of hand and that scene isn't even in the first four chapters but.... it's there!! eventually!! I promise!!! c:

Chapter 1

Catra kept a forced smile on her face just long enough for the scrawny kid from down the road to leave her home before pressing a frustrated nail against her forehead and sighing "come on, Kyle."

She could lift more than he could. Why on *earth* would he apply to be her farmhand? She knew he didn't much like working at his parent's apiary, but Catra needed someone built for this job, someone who could do some heavy lifting for hours on end. Someone like --

Nope. She wasn't going there. It had been years. No sense in opening *that* box.

A heavy sigh fell on her shoulders as she crumpled up Kyle's application before turning on her heel to see if anyone else had emailed her. She knew it was unlikely but *damn it* , she bit off more than she could chew when she took over this homestead. There had been something appealing about going off the grid, and she *had* always loved living here as a kid, so when her shit foster mother passed away, it felt *right* to buy this place out from under her.

Maybe she should have considered more than her spite, though.

Catra felt her ear twitch at the soft sound of dirt drive crunching under tires and frowned. She wasn't expecting anyone else, and the drive was long enough that no one who didn't know what was up here would venture off the main road like this. With a huff, she stepped back out over the threshold onto her porch and crossed her arms, ready to greet - or *maybe* threaten - whoever was encroaching on her property.

The gray pickup truck was old as hell, but Catra could tell whoever the owner was took great care of it by how gently the engine purred and how the paint shone under the sunlight. She took another tentative step forward, toes curling over the edge of her porch. The

truck came to a stop right beside her little prius, and Catra found herself stretching to try and make out *anything* about the stranger.

The engine was cut, a door popped open, and then a very familiar head of blonde hair hopped down from the lifted cab. Catra saw a flash of her white and gray flannel, dark jeans stretched over thick thighs, and felt her breath catch in her throat as the heavy timbs stopped walking towards her. She snapped her gaze back up to the face in front of her.

Their eyes met as the other woman leaned on the hood of her truck and smirked. "Hey , Catra."

Well, she supposed that box was open now.

"What." Catra swallowed and felt her entire body tense. "What the hell are *you* doing here?"

Adora blinked at her a couple times before jumping up. "Oh!" She reached into her back pocket and clumsily unfolded a piece of paper. "Saw your ad up at Raz s. You need help?" She smiled again and jabbed a thumb into her chest, mumbling an almost inaudible *ow* before straightening back up. "As it turns out, *I* need a job!"

When Catra's only answer was a narrowing of her eyes, Adora chuckled a little nervously, just as she always did, and dropped her hands to her hips. "You know I always loved working here in the summers. Though, honestly," she shrugged, frowning, "I'm surprised you took over? I thought you would have left the second Weaver --"

"What are you even doing in town, Adora?" Catra could feel irritation boiling up in the back of her throat. As far as she knew, Adora would never have come back here on her own volition. "Thought you were a *big city gal* now?" Fuck, she could *taste* the venom on her tongue.

"Oh, ah." Adora shrugged and dug her toes into the dirt, locking her gaze on the clouds of dust kicking up. "Finished my degree, played a couple years semi-pro and." She let out a sigh. "Just.wasn't for

me, in the end.”A soft smile played at her lips as she turned her head out to the fields. “And I missed it out here.”

The sun hit her face in this stupidly perfect way that Catra loathed at this exact moment.

“Why would I hire you?”Catra leaned against the post next to the steps in an attempt to feel more nonchalant. “Maybe I’ve already hired someone.”

Adora’s head snapped up to face her. “... Have you?”A pause, and a smug little smirk. “And because you already know how hard I work here.”

She scoffed and rolled her eyes. “I know how hard you *goof off* here.”A soft flush rose to her cheeks in remembrance before she chanced another glance at Adora, whose face at softened in the same fucking way it used to when they were hidden away in the dark -- *fuck* . “Don’t look at me like that.”

“What?”Adora clapped a hand against her own shoulder as if brushing off dirt that clearly wasn’t there and shot her gaze back to the fields. “I wasn’t looking at you like anything.”

Catra rolled her eyes again and groaned. “Ugh, just leave your application and write down your number -”

“It’s still the same -”

“All right, then I’ll unblock it -”she could almost hear the frown in Adora’s small *okay* . “And I’ll give you a call and let you know in a couple of days.”

“Is there anyone else you’re thinking of?”Adora’s eyes had widened just a bit, her brows turned up with that sickening hopeful expression Catra was so used to and had never hated quite as much as she did seven years ago.

She pressed her lips together, fighting back a smirk. "Well considering my only other applicants are some drunk and Kyle --"

"Oh, *Kyle*."

"-- No...no one else is looking promising."

Adora's face stretched into a smirk, and one eyebrow lowered in a conspiratory way. "Then why not just give me the job?"

She had to calm herself down. "I don't partake in nepotism, Adora." But Catra couldn't help the teasing smile that pulled at the corner of her lips.

Adora snorted and braced her hands on her hips again. "Does this even count?"

Catra's ear twitched and she tugged at a loose strand of hair that had escaped her ponytail in order to maintain *some* semblance of not panicking. "Well I guess we're not friends, so not really."

"*Ouch*." Catra tried to ignore the fondness practically radiating off of Adora as she clasped a hand against her chest in mock pain. "Finger."

This was a bad idea. This was a *very* bad idea. But Catra couldn't stop her traitorous mouth. "I'll call you."

Adora just smiled, her whole face softening. "Can't wait."

And then with just a short wave and a grunt as she hopped back into her truck, Adora was driving back down towards the main road.

--

Within moments of Adora's truck disappearing behind the trees that lined the drive, Catra found herself worked into a tizzy. She couldn't stop pacing the porch, tugging at her hair as her tail whipped

frantically behind her. This was such a dumb idea. She should just not call Adora and hire Kyle and call it a day, right?

But no, she knew Adora. She knew that within a week she would see that damn truck come rolling over the horizon again and Catra would see those slate colored eyes fill with pleading gentleness and Adora would probably reach over and touch her shoulder and say something so fucking *kind* that Catra would scream at her to get the fuck away from her and *God* she didn't *want* Adora to walk away from her and --

Fuck.

Swinging the door open with all of her might, Catra practically threw herself to where her phone had been abandoned by the kitchen sink. She had changed *her* number in the last few years, but she had never forgotten Adora's.

In fact, she had to program it in her phone with the name DO NOT CONTACT UNDER ANY CIRCUMSTANCES after the one time she dialed it from memory while not completely sober at three in the morning and almost hissed into the receiver when Adora groggily answered. Luckily it seemed like Adora had brushed it off as a weird prank or telemarketer or *something* because she never attempted to call back.

Well, at least not before Catra had blocked the number *again*.

She fell backwards into her kitchen chair and scrolled down her contacts list, thumb hovering over contact First Name: DO NOT CONTACT Last Name: UNDER ANY CIRCUMSTANCES. (She had figured it being all the way under U would *also* help.) With a sigh she tapped into the details and changed the name back to Adora Gay, and hesitantly unblocked the number.

Okay. Step one done. But maybe she should call and tell Adora she didn't need help after all. Maybe she should just cut this off at the bud and not let herself get any deeper. Maybe she should just…

With a sigh, Catra scrolled back up and called someone *else* .

"Hey Wildcat!"

"Hey , Scorpia."

"... Y ou okay?"

Ugh, she was terrible at keeping her emotions out of her voice. Or Scorpia had just gotten really good at reading her over the years. Or. Both, probably both.

"I'm f--" No, she was more *open* these days. She sighed. "Actually , no. I. Adora showed up today ."

"Whoa, what? *Adora* Adora? The one you grew up with?" Her voice was rising with every question and Catra could feel the hairs on her neck standing on edge. "The one who got the scholarship? The one who left and broke your--"

" *Yes* ," she hissed, running a hand down her face. "The *only* Adora I know."

"Oh, wow ." There was a heavy pause and Catra took a moment to catch her breath. "Didn't she move away like five years ago?"

"Seven."

"And now she' s back?"

"I guess."

"Is she just visiting?"

"She came by to apply for the farmhand job."

"Oh, *wow* ."

Catra leaned over to rest her head in her hand against the table. "Yeah." She really hoped that Scorpia would say *something* that would make Catra realize how bad an idea this was immediately. But she didn't. "I think I might give her the job?"

A small hum crossed the line. "Is... Is that going to be good for *you*?"

"Honestly? I don't know." Pressing two fingers into her temple, Catra let out a heavy breath. "I mean, I really could use the help, and she already knows the place..." *and she's definitely gotten stronger*. "She seemed to be acting like nothing happened, though? And I'm not sure if I should bring it up or..."

"I mean," Scorpia started, and Catra could hear the faint whistling of Scorpia's fiancé in the background. She hated interrupting them. "Ultimately you gotta do what's best for you, Catra. You were in a really bad place after she left, right?"

Catra made a soft grunt of agreement.

"Buuut you've also been in therapy for a while now and are doing a lot better. And I think you've said that you realized how little it really had to do with *her*, right?"

A (regrettable) hum of approval.

"So I guess if you feel okay with her being around? You wouldn't *really* have to talk to her much more than when you're giving her some instruction?" She could envision Scorpia's bouncing knees, indicating how much she was unwilling to give a direct answer. "And I do think you could use some help out there. But it's all about your wellbeing first, okay Wildcat?"

Catra felt her shoulders relax. "Yeah, okay." It wasn't much, but just talking to Scorpia helped her calm down and think more clearly. "Thanks, Scorp."

“Anytime, bestie.”

A laugh bubbled up from her chest as they hung up, and Catra dropped the phone back down to the table. Okay, this was going to be *fine* . She could figure this out. She needed the help and it’s not exactly like applications were flying in. She could handle time around Adora. This would be *fine* .

--

After a long shower to calm her nerves and a warm dinner to make sure she wasn’t making any rash decisions out of hunger-driven-mania, Catra sat in bed, staring at Adora’s number in her phone. Deep breath in, and out…

She dialed.

“Hello?”

Another deep breath.

“Hey , Adora.”

A small laugh across the line. “Haven’t heard that in a while.” Then, she could hear Adora pull the phone away from her ear before speaking again. “Y ou changed your number.”

Catra bit her lip before responding. “A lot about me has changed.” Fuck. That was too flirty.

“Are you.” Hesitation. “I.I’d like to get to know you again.” Catra felt her grip on the phone tighten. “If you’ll let me.”

Catra drew her knees up under her chin and wiped at her cheek with a sweaty palm. “I don’t know yet.”

A beat, and then “all right.”

“Are you free tomorrow night?” She swallowed the lump in her throat. “Meet at Raz s? We can talk about your contract.” She crossed her arm across her knees before pressing her forehead against them.

“You’re hiring me?”

“On a trial basis.”

“I’ll take it.”

“Six?”

“Usual booth?”

“See you there, Adora.”

“I wouldn’t miss it.”

Catra hung up.

Everything about Adora blossomed warmth in her chest. Her voice had grown a little deeper over the years, but it was still so kind and gentle and so damn *Adora* that Catra felt a familiar glow burning inside of her - one that she had missed so much more than she had even realized.

She wiped at the tear on her cheek.

Her heart felt lighter than it had in years.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Thanks so much for all the positive feedback on chapter 1!! I'm going to try to stick to an update a week, but I am bad at keeping with schedules so we'll see how long that lasts haha!

> I've made a playlist for this fic now! Feel free to check it out :)

Of course she was running late. Of *course* . She had started getting nervous and then started doing some extra work that could *definitely* wait until tomorrow to try and keep her mind off of the nerves, and then the next thing she knew, she had about fifteen minutes until she had to leave and she was sweaty and covered in dirt and absolutely needed a shower. So she had hopped in, slipped a little, banged her elbow, scurried out, and threw her sopping wet hair up into some sort of messy bun because there was absolutely *not* enough time to blow dry her curls and make them look even slightly presentable.

So she left about five minutes after she meant to, and Raż s was a twenty minute drive, and she got held up by some freaking cows on the road, and now it was ten after six and she was practically running for the door.

And then she realiz ed that she needed to take a fucking *breath* .

Skidding to a halt, Catra stepped aside by the doorway to hold it open for the familiar faces of Spinerella and Netossa, who greeted her with big smiles.

“Hey , K ty ,” Netossa grinned, throwing an arm around her neck. “Y ou look flustered. And we just saw a blast from the past sitting at your usual booth in there. Oh, this *is* interesting!”

The blush burned brighter against her skin as she squirmed out of the older woman's grip. "I--"

"Oh leave her , Darling."

When she was finally free, Catra let out a groan as she squeezed her fluffed up tail between her hands. "I have no idea what you're talking about."

The couple looked at her, taking in the actually coordinated outfit, and nodded. "Mhmm," Netossa hummed, turning away and continuing her exit. "Whatever you say!"

Catra glared behind them before taking in a deep breath and straightening her shoulders. This was going to be *fine* . It was just Adora and it was *just* a business meeting. She pushed open the door with a slight huff of effort and directed her gaze immediately to the back corner booth that she was overly familiar with.

Adora didn't notice her at first, and Catra did her best to look at this as an advantage. It probably meant Adora hadn't seen her running to the diner, and it definitely meant she had some time to make a much more cool entrance. But it only took two steps before Adora looked up at her as if she had felt Catra staring, and a bright smile stretched across her cheeks. She lifted a hand to wave, and smacked over her glass of water, and Catra found herself snorting once before striding the rest of the way across the room.

"Ooh, I do love seeing that pro athlete coordination in action."

Adora had jumped up and was doing her best to mop up the water that was pooling on the table. "What can I say?" she grinned, a blush burning on her cheeks. "Soccer . No hands."

With a quirked eyebrow , Catra crossed her arms over her chest. "You were a goalie."

A pause, and then a bashful "you got me!" before Adora bent down to gather the shards of glass on the ground, and Catra found her eyes lingering a little south of where they should be. Fuck, the years of training had made her even more fit and the cut of that denim was only *enhancing* things.

"Let me go bring these to Perfuelstar." Adora got up with a groan and hesitated for just a moment when Catra's eyes snapped back up to her face. "Um." She took a deep breath before tilting her head to the side. "Usual?"

"Coffee with some cream is fine."

Adora faltered, and then nodded with a half smile before heading up to the counter. Catra couldn't stop her stare from following after her.

With a sigh and roll of her eyes, Catra moved to sit at the booth, picking up the pile of wet napkins between two fingers with a sound of disgust before dropping them down into the now empty glass. The surface was still damp, but it seemed Adora had used up every absorbent item that was on the table in an attempt to clean it up. At least it was just water.

By the time Adora came back, some young server that Catra didn't recognize had come up to finish trying the table off, and left them with some fresh glasses of water. "Oh, good," Adora mumbled, sliding into her side of the booth and grimacing. "Ah, seats still wet. Oh well."

Catra had propped her cheek up on her fist, and was slowly dragging her pinkie nail back and forth over her bottom lip, eyes narrowed as Adora fidgeted in front of her. There was something enticing about how she squirmed under Catra's gaze, and she *maybe* found herself wondering just how much she could make Adora sweat.

"So," Adora blew out a breath after a moment, tugging at the collar of her button down. "Is this like a formal interview or"…

Oh, she had to have *some* sympathy. "What?" Catra let out a laugh and pushed some loose curls back off of her forehead. "No, dummy. You have the job, I just wanted to go over details."

"Ohthankgod," came out all in one breath before Adora reached up to unbutton the top three closures of her shirt. "I was dying in this thing."

Catra made a poor attempt to swallow through the sudden dryness in her mouth, and pulled her mug of coffee up to her lips, dragging out one slow sip. "I was wondering why you were dressed like that."

Adora shrugged before lifting her own mug up to her mouth, visibly relaxing. "Wanted to make a good second first-impression."

"Well you spilled water all over the table and broke a glass so I'm not sure how well that's going for you." When Adora let out a snort and a big laugh, Catra couldn't help the smirk that quirked up at the corner of her lips. Shit, she did always love that laugh. "All right, super star," she leaned over to her bag to pull out the contract. "Here's the deal."

--

Ultimately going over the specifics of the job didn't take long at all. It was all very familiar for Adora, and she was more than willing to work the hours Catra had laid out for her. Monday through Thursday for standard work was six to four, and then on Sunday they would go down to the farmers market from ten until two. Catra offered a more than fair wage which Adora accepted with enthusiasm, and suddenly the contract was signed, and their food was just arriving.

"So," Catra hummed, slipping the papers back into her bag. "What brought you back to town anyway? I didn't really get to properly ask, yesterday."

She didn't miss the way Adora practically choked on her sandwich.

"Ah, I...um." Adora clapped a hand against her chest and took a heavy gulp of her coffee which had been practically drowned in cream and sugar. "Yeah, you know, just uh, city life wasn't for me in the end! I loved university and playing there, and got my degree and everything but uh," she hummed again, and Catra could feel Adora's knees bouncing under the table. She wasn't telling the whole truth. "When I joined the semi-pro league I just...I had to leave my friends, and it just wasn't what I was expecting. Figured I could use some time away, regroup and..." Adora rubbed at the back of her neck, smiling. "Get back to my roots."

Catra nodded and tapped her fork against her plate. "How long have you been back for?"

There was hesitation and then an almost shameful chuckle. "... Maybe forty-ish hours?"

She couldn't help the disbelieving burst of a laugh that tore from her chest. "Oh, leave it to you to try and find a job within a day of coming back here. You can't sit still, can you?"

"Nah," Adora said with a shrug. "When could I ever?"

Catra's laugh softened slightly. "Even in the summers when you'd stay over, you kept working until I physically dragged you back in to take a damn shower and go to bed." Adora looked sheepish as she took another bite of her food. "You really were Weavers favorite employee. I'm surprised you didn't work in your sleep."

Adora grinned and swallowed her bite. "I might have, you don't know."

"You *have* punched me a couple times," Catra mused, lifting her fork to her mouth.

"Honestly I'm surprised you didn't scratch me up more than you did."

"I should have. You were the worst to share a bed with." Catra scoffed and pointed her fork towards Adora's face. "Besides, you'd be *way* more badass with some scars."

She hated the way Adora's eyes filled with mischief. "Oh, I've got some scars."

But she couldn't stop the way her tongue darted out to the corner of her mouth as her eyes trailed down what parts of Adora's chest she could see. Catra knew every inch of her body and couldn't recall many permanent blemishes on Adora's skin. She couldn't deny that her interest had been piqued.

Wait. *Fuck* .

Catra snapped her gaze back down to her food and shook her head. "Well don't be clumsy enough to get caught in my equipment and hopefully you won't get any more here."

"Aye, aye, boss."

They sat in silence for a few minutes, Catra feeling the tension settling again where there was momentarily a familiar easiness. She felt it in her gut that they'd have to talk about everything *eventually* , but she wasn't ready for it. Not yet. Definitely not now. She could feel her ears flattening against her head in frustration, trying to figure out how exactly to move this forward when Adora let out a light cough and broke the silence.

"So why'd you take over Weaver's place again?"

Ugh . She didn't want it to go like *that* .

"She kicked the bucket and I bought it." Catra risked one look up at Adora and almost felt her frown like a punch in the stomach. "I didn't like her, but I really loved the homestead." Her shoulders relaxed just a little as Adora slid her hand across the table, offering it up like she used to. Catra wasn't ready to take it yet, but she appreciated the

effort. "Plus, I think she'd hate knowing I had it...and I'm nothing if not spiteful, right?"

Adora's barking laugh cut through the noise of the diner again, and Catra cursed the fucking flush on her cheeks. "It was always one of my favorite things about you. Not the --" Adora fumbled, leaning forward to place both palms flat on the table. "Not that I think you're like, spiteful but." An awkward chuckle. "I mean, the whole." She waved her hands in front of her face for a moment, as if trying to find the right words. "I-I think it motivates you. You may start out with spite but it always blooms into something incredible."

Oh, Catra could *not* resist. "Awww," she purred, leaning forward and propping her chin up in her hand, elbow against the table. "You think I'm incredible? I mean, I guess I can't blame you."

"Yeah, I do," Adora started, her fingers brushing lightly against Catra's forearm. "It's pretty embarrassing."

Fuck. Fuck shit goddamnit fuck.

Catra watched with delight as Adora's eyes immediately dropped to her mouth, where she had gently caught her bottom lip between her teeth before soothing it over with a pass of her tongue. It was only a moment before their eyes met again, and Catra swore to whatever higher being may or may not exist that if something didn't stop her right now, she might break every rule she had ever made in regards to Adora.

That higher being sent Raz

"Dearies!" her voice broke through their haze as she slapped a dish down between them, forcing them both to sit back in their respective benches. "I made you a special pie!" She pulled a large knife out of her apron and Adora met Catra's eyes with the same concerned amusement she felt on her own face. "Made fresh with some berries from sweet little Casta. Oh she has grown so quick!"

Adora ran a frustrated hand against her cheek before smiling over at the old woman. "Thanks, Raz! I can't wait to try it." There was a sweet familiarity between Adora and Raz, one so distinctly of a grandmother and their only grandchild, and Catra couldn't help but smile at them as Raz leaned up to wipe a smudge from the side of Adora's mouth.

"Mixed berries!" Raz exclaimed while cutting them each a hefty slice. "I have ice cream in the back if you want it!"

Before they could even answer, she was scurrying off and practically chucking forks at them from a few feet away. Adora's laugh softened Catra's nerves, and she scrunched up her nose to stop the smile from showing on her face. "So, when did you want to start?"

"Hmm?"

Of course, Adora's mouth was already stuffed with the pie.

Catra just shook her head and tapped a nail against the table. "Do you need some time to settle in? Or do you want to start as soon as possible?"

"Oh!" She sat up straighter , but not before shoveling another mouthful of pie into her face. "As soon as possible, definitely . I'm just.staying with Raz.so.Not much to settle." She shrugged. "Didn't bring much back."

That made sense. Adora never was one for material things. "All right, well, tomorrow, then?"

Adora wiggled in her seat to pull her wallet out from her back pocket, dropping some bills on the table. "Yeah, sounds great!"

With a flick of her wrist, Catra took a (much smaller) bite of the pie, sighing with relief. Damn. it really *was* delicious.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra barely slept.

She had been on an early to bed early to rise sleep schedule for most of her life, but falling asleep last night had proven to be a struggle. Maybe it was nerves. Maybe it was that her idiot brain ordered a coffee at six pm rather than letting Adora know she still knew anything about her.

Luckily she could tell by Adora's reaction that it had paid off, so that was a win she supposed.

Her alarm blared again at five-fifteen and Catra rolled over with a groan, slapping a hand against her lamp and wincing as the new light practically blinded her. She took five minutes to slink to the bathroom and splash some water on her face, staring blearily into the mirror. This was going to be fine. She didn't even have to really interact much with Adora once she got out to work, right? Honestly, the less they spoke the better, probably.

Their night had wrapped up pretty quickly after Razz made them both take home extra pie, and Adora had walked Catra over to her car, hands jammed into her pockets.

"So," she had hummed, rocking back from her heels to her toes. "This was fun." It had almost felt like the end to one of their old dates, until Adora shrugged as if she felt it too and added "... for a business meeting."

"I guess," Catra had laughed, tossing her bagged up food into her car. "I've definitely had worse meetings."

Adora grinned and crossed her arms over her chest, smug. "Have you had better? ...Meetings?"

"Oh, definitely ." She could help but laugh at the frown on Adora' s face. "Most of my business meetings end up with me getting paid." Then, just for fun, "and most of my *nonbusiness* meetings end up with me getting *laid* ."

Ah, it was worth it for that pink on Adora's cheeks. But then she said "too bad this was a business meeting, then," with a quick dart of her tongue against her lips, and Catra found herself groaning in multiple types of frustration.

"I walked right into that."

Adora's shoulders lifted with nonchalance, as if it hadn't affected her in the slightest. "Couldn't resist."

A silence fell between them again for just a moment before Adora jerked her thumb over her shoulder and hummed. "So, uh, early morning. Should probably head home."

"Y eah," Catra agreed, tapping her keys against her knuckles. "W ell… see you tomorrow."

"Y eah."

Catra had begun to stick her hand out for a shake when Adora came in and wrapped her arms around her for a hug, trapping Catra's fist awkwardly between their stomachs. She took in a heavy breath, full of Adora's scent, still the same...still familiar and overwhelming. She was practically lost in it by the time Adora pulled away, shoving her hands back in her pockets as she mumbled an uneasy apology.

Oh, right, they weren't *that* anymore.

"It' s fine, Adora."

And then they said goodbye, and then Catra drove home, and then she proceeded to lay in bed for an absurd amount of time just basking in the warmth of the very missed embrace.

And now she was leaning over her sink, eyes drooping, because a *hug* had sent her spiraling.

Catra rolled her neck and reached - a little more aggressively than she meant to - for her toothbrush and began her morning routine. Brush teeth. Try not to think about Adora. Wrestle hair back into some sort of presentable ponytail. Try not to think about Adora. Put on sunscreen. Try not to think about Adora. Get dressed.

Fail at not thinking about Adora.

Catra pulled a light linen shirt over her shoulders and stumbled as she stepped into her work shorts. A frustrated yelp tore from her throat. Okay, *fine* , maybe she would let herself think about Adora for just a moment.

Because old feelings were rearing up, and it had hurt like hell when she left.

Adora really had tried to keep up with Catra. She called every night, and came back to visit when she could - but as her first year at school continued on and she got busier, she could only visit on breaks when she didn't have practice. Catra had started working at Raż s on the weekends, and at the corner store during the weekdays, so even when Adora could visit, it felt almost pointless. Catra had tried to go up to visit Adora as a surprise once, but she had been drowning in school work and passed out after morning practice and they just decided it maybe wasn't worth wasting the gas.

Then one night, after text upon text confirming their scheduled phone call, Catra sat and waited two hours past when she was supposed to hear from Adora. Figuring she had just gotten caught up with school work, Catra had dialed her up with only a little bit of irritation.

Until she heard the pounding music in the background.

"Caaaatra!" Adora hollered, her voice barely beating out the background noise, and Catra's minor annoyance blew up into full-on anger. "Hiii, hiiiiii."

"You were supposed to call two hours ago."

"... What?"

Catra bit her lip hard and hugged her knees closer to her chest. "Are you drunk?"

"Kinda, I'm...hang on!" She could hear Adora making her way out of the noise, heard her excuse herself as she presumably pushed through a crowd, before she blew out a loud "whew!" and laughed into the receiver. "Sorry!"

"You promised we'd talk tonight."

"Oh, shit, oh my god." Adora's words were just slightly slurred, and Catra was glad she caught her before she was totally gone. "I'm -- baby, I'm really sorry. Fuck. I had my last final tonight and Glimmer and Bow surprised me and --"

She could feel her hair rise on end at the mention of Adora's other friends. "You know what? I'm over this."

"What? Catra, what do you m--"

Catra pressed the heel of her palm into her forehead and ignored the stinging beneath her eyelids. "I'm done, Adora." She could feel everything in her fighting the words pouring from her lips, but she was so fucking *hurt*. "I'm done with the not seeing you, and you always having practice, and you flaking on our calls, and your other friends *always* being a priority over me --"

"Catra, they're *not* -- I --"

“We’re done.” Her throat burned. “Don’t bother me if you ever come back to town. Though it seems you think you’re too good for us now anyway.”

Then she hung up and blocked Adora from every form of contact they had.

It had worked for seven years. She didn’t know if Adora ever came back to their home town in all that time, and honestly that suited her just fine. If she had, at least Adora had enough respect for her to listen to what she wanted.

Well, until now.

Catra almost fell down the stairs just in time to catch the bright headlights of Adora’s truck rolling up the driveway - she was a little early, typical Adora - before Catra flipped on the coffee maker. She was going to need *buckets* to get through today, and she figured it would be a good peace offering.

Her ears twitched just slightly as the truck rolled to a stop and she heard Adora jump onto the dirt before footsteps bounced up the porch steps before hesitating at the door. Would she come right in? She had used to - but that was when it was Weaver’s home and it was allowed. The rules were different now. Would she just wait outside, not wanting to disturb Catra so early? But certainly she saw the lights on…

Then Catra heard a familiar rhythm of rapping on the wood - one that she had heard so many times on so many late nights before Adora snuck in through her bedroom window - and she couldn’t stop the small laugh that bubbled up from her chest.

She raised her voice just enough to be heard. “Come in, Adora.”

The door creaked and Adora peeked through the opening, grinning wildly. “Hey , I could have been anyone! What if I were a murderer?”

Catra crossed her arms over her chest and leaned up against the counter, one eyebrow raised. "I heard your truck, and you used our old *secret* knock." Then she shrugged. "But honestly , if a murderer came all the way out here to kill me, I think I'd have to give it to them."

A chuckle and a snort, and then Adora was fully in her kitchen, leaning up against the door like she belonged there. "Sorry I'm a little early."

Catra rolled her eyes before moving to the cabinet to get down two mugs. "I expected nothing less. Cof fee?"

"Y es please!"

She chanced a glance back at her visitor, who was looking directly at her. "Cream and sugar?"

Adora smiled wide, her face soft. "A ww, you remembered."

Catra chuckled, fixing her mug. "Of course I did - it' s not like it's hard. Your preference is just the sweeter the better ' ." She listened carefully to Adora's movements behind her, only a tiny bit disappointed that she hadn't come over and propped her chin on Catra's shoulder to observe what she was doing like Adora would have when they were younger. With a deep breath, she spun on her heel and froze for just a second at the sight of Adora seated in the kitchen, leaned back in the chair and flipping through the newspaper on the table.

This was all Catra had wanted, once upon a time. A life with Adora, just like this.

"Don't know how you drink it like this," Catra grimaced as she plopped the mug down on the surface, wincing as a little spilled out onto her hand. "So sweet." She sat down in front of Adora, lifting her own coffee - black - up to her own mouth.

Adora thanked her and sipped at the far-too-pale drink before sighing contentedly. "You always do make it just right."

"If you keep complimenting me like that I'm gonna get a big head."

Their eyes met across the table. "Ah, then I guess I'll keep at it."

Catra's heart sped up beneath her ribs and she tugged uncomfortably at a loose strand of hair. "Anyway ," she mumbled, turning her head to look out the window. "Everything' s pretty much the same. You can just run through your old routine if you remember it. Only things I've added was a little mushroom farm in the back shed and expanded on the peppers a bit."

"Still got animals?" Adora peered up at her , expression clearly hopeful. Her favorite part of the job was always the critters.

"Just the chickens. I didn't like raising meat..." She still shuddered at a vivid memory from childhood. "There are also some new barn cats that have migrated here. There's a gray one who will probably either love or hate you. I think they're attached to me."

Adora had a small smirk on her lips. "Did you name them?"

"... No."

She snorted and leaned forward, her smile growing. "You definitely did"…

"Ugh," Catra pushed up of f her chair and frowned, crossing her arms over her chest. "I'm not paying you to torment me. T ake your time finishing your coffee but then get to work, Adora."

Adora practically saluted her. "You got it, boss."

--

So this was *way* better than Catra had expected. Adora had very clearly remembered everything, and was flying through the work

much quicker than anyone else would have ever been able to. She was practically anyone's dream employee.

The only downside was how outright *distracting* she was.

It was no secret that Adora was attractive - she always had been - but it was clear that after she left she devoted much more time into perfecting her body. Maybe it was just a result of being an athlete, but the sheer volume of her spoke to it being more than that.

Catra had watched with a dry mouth when, after about two hours, Adora had taken down her signature ponytail before flipping it up into a messy topknot, presumably to keep all of it off of her neck, and exposed the tiniest bit of skin. That had taken a minor toll on Catra, causing her to fumble and drop the egg she was about to package. She cursed to herself and cleaned it up, but recovered relatively quickly.

It was when Catra walked out to offer Adora something to eat that she just about lost her mind.

Adora was standing there in just a tight gray tank top, overshirt now being used as a rag to wipe the sweat off her forehead, and stretching her arms behind her back. She was completely oblivious to Catra's wide-eyed stare, and Catra knew she *had* to pull it together before Adora *did* take notice.

"Hey, Adora!" Catra yelled, hoping the scrunch of the holler would realign her face to something more normal. "Do you want lunch? I made..." Adora's smiling gaze turned up to meet her stopped Catra in her tracks. Oh no, she was completely drawing a blank on what she made. "... Food." Eh, good enough.

"Oh ho!" Adora started jogging towards the house, and Catra had to look away from all her... movement. "You cook? Since when!"

"Since -" she was nineteen and moved out on her own. "A while now. I didn't know if you brought anything so..." Adora hopped up the

steps and wrapped a hand around the post, leaning against it, sufficiently drawing Catra's eyes back to her slightly heaving chest and much-larger-than-she-remembered arms. "Ugh, jeez, can you put a damn shirt on?"

Adora blinked once, eyebrows coming together as she looked down at her body. "I... do have a shirt on?"

Catra felt her eyes narrow as their gazes met. "You're going to get sunburned."

"... I mean, I put on sunblock?" Adora's lips had turned into a pout, and she looked like she genuinely wasn't able to figure out what on earth Catra was so worried about before she pointed back over her shoulder with her thumb. "If it'll make you feel better... I can put my flannel back on... I was just really hot."

God, she was *really* hot.

Catra swallowed and rolled her eyes before waving her hand up in the air. "Nevermind. Are you going to come eat or what?"

Perking right back up, Adora practically strutted in through the doorway before following Catra to the kitchen, and propping herself up on the counter just behind where Catra had to stand. "What did you make, chef?"

Catra was doing her best to ignore the heat radiating off of Adora's body and how close she was and how she could practically hear the blood rushing through her ears. "Just, um," she stammered, cheeks flushed. "Just some eggs in red sauce. Weaver made it a lot and it's easy -- she called it, um," Catra turned to look over her shoulder at Adora, who was smiling softly as she listened. "Eggs in Purgatory? I think? It's... it's good. I make it spicy, though."

"Oooh," Adora hummed, leaning closer and admiring the perfectly cooked eggs. "Like... how spicy?" Some of her loose hair tickled at Catra's cheek, and Catra practically groaned at the contact.

"My kind of spicy ." It almost came out with the tone of a threat.

Adora laughed and stepped back, shoving her hands in her back pockets and leaning away from the stove. "So what you're saying is I might die."

A chuckle bubbled up from Catra's chest against her will as she crossed her arms and felt a smirk tugging at her lips. "Yeah, pretty much."

"All right, challenge accepted."

Adora stepped away and moved to the cabinets, easily remembering where everything was, before pulling down some plates and cups. Everything about her movement in the room screamed comfort, familiarity, and *home* . It was indulgent to think, for just a moment, what could have been if Adora hadn't left, if they were still something.

Grabbing the pan from the stove with a huff, Catra set it down on the table before dropping into a chair.

It didn't matter what could have been, did it?

This was where they were.

When Adora sat down across from her and gave Catra the biggest smile could muster before digging right into the food, Catra bit at her lip.

This was better than nothing, right?

Chapter End Notes

when the update a week doesn't happen after a single week

,,,,,,,,,

(tbf i *did* post another fic ;))

Thank y'all so much for reading as always!! I really appreciate comments &love chatting with all of yooou~

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> I drew some art for this chapter! I do not know how to embed pictures into the fic because I am OLD but it's linked riiiiiight heeeere :3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora *might* be the death of Catra.

They were headed to the farmers market today, so it was clear that Adora had decided to dress slightly more fashionably - at least by Adora's standards. She had arrived with her hair down, dressed in a simple black bandeau covered only by a pair of overalls that had been tucked at the ankle, and when she had hopped out of her truck, hair flowing around her bare shoulders, Catra felt like her entire mouth was glued shut.

"I brought an overshirt.you know , just in case.Sunburn." The innocent way she said it made Catra's cheeks flush so deeply that there was no way Adora didn't notice.

Catra would run herself over with a tractor if she could.

"Can you just load up your truck, please?" Her voice was strained, but Adora just nodded and made her way over to the pile of boxes.

All right, correction --

Catra sighed as she watched Adora heave up heavy crates into the bed of her truck, her uncovered back and arms flexing with every move.

-- Adora absolutely *would* be the death of Catra.

With one last grunt, all of the boxes were in the truck and Adora was brushing her hands together before placing them triumphantly at her hips. "Anything else you need me to grab?"

There was no helping it as Catra stepped closer and pinched at Adora's biceps with hardly an iota of annoyance. Adora flinched, but didn't pull away. "You play soccer," Catra said, wrapping thin fingers around the width of her arm. "There's no way you just looked like this without try-harding. Why are you so big?"

Adora snort-laughed and flexed just a little, her dorky little grin blooming a warmth in Catra's chest. "Well I guess it started because I needed a distraction after -" She hesitated for a moment, swallowing before averting her eyes. "After the seasons ended. So I started lifting. And I liked it." She winked and lifted one eyebrow slightly before flexing just a little more. "And *girls* liked it."

"Blegh." Catra tugged her hand away, rolling her eyes, and walked quickly towards the passenger side door. "Girls are so easy. Just a wink and a flex, huh? Then they were doing whatever you asked, I bet."

Adora's laughter only cut off when Catra slammed the door shut, rubbing her hands down her face quickly enough for Adora not to catch her as she opened her door and hopped up to her seat. "You know, I wish it had been that easy."

"Please," Catra said, laughing as her mouth formed around the next question without her mind's consent. "I bet you were easily in the double digits of partners."

Oh no.

The truck started, and Adora's hand clapped against the back of Catra's seat before she started backing out, humor evident in her voice. "Why do you say that?"

Shut up. Just stop talking. I mean, *look* at you." That is *not* being quiet. She crossed her arms over her chest and sunk down in the seat before taking a glance at the driver. Their eyes caught, and Catra groaned as Adora's smirk stretched. "Oh, shut up."

"I didn't say anything." She just shifted the truck into drive, and started down the dirt road.

"We both know what you look like, okay? This doesn't mean I like you or whatever. It just means I have eyes."

"Got it. You do not like me," Adora said with a chuckle before turning onto the main road and starting their drive to town. "But, for the record, I also have eyes." Catra risked a peek up at Adora, and felt her eyebrows rise as she noticed the pink tinging Adora's cheeks. "And I always thought you were way too hot for me. So. I figured you did pretty well for yourself." She shrugged and bit at the inside of her cheek.

"Do you want to ask my number, Adora?" Catra couldn't help the flirty lilt of her voice as she sat back up in her seat, confidence boosted.

"No," she said too quickly, blush darkening. "... Okay, maybe a little."

Catra laughed, twisting in the seat and leaning against the window to face Adora. Was she really going to answer this? It wasn't high, and she couldn't help but wonder if the mystery of it all was more intriguing than the truth. "Tell me yours first, and I'll think about it."

A snort. "I didn't keep track."

That was surprising. "Not even of your relationships?"

"Oh, there were zero relationships," Adora said, a frown on her lips. "I was too busy for that."

Interesting. "Wow, all right. Estimate?"

Biting at her cheek, Adora shrugged. “... I really don’t know . I liked going to parties, and usually hooked up with someone. City life was different. You never really ran into them again.”

Catra couldn’t help but feel an unwelcome pit of jealousy rise up in her stomach. “Guess you moved on easily enough, then.”

The truck jerked to a stop and Catra threw her arm out to brace herself against the dashboard. “What the hell, Adora?” She whipped her head around to glare at the driver, whose jaw was clenched as she stared back at Catra, a clear irritation evident on her features. “... What?”

Adora swallowed before her brows furrowed deeper. “You’re kidding, right?”

“Well you were already going to parties when we broke up,” Catra scoffed, sinking low back in her seat again. “I can’t imagine it was long before the rest of that started.”

A bitter laugh tore from Adora’s throat before she practically threw the gear shift into park and dropped her head against the wheel, triggering the horn to blare. Catra jumped as she clamped her hands over her ears, hollering a frustrated “Stop!”

When the horn finally silenced, Catra could feel tension in her throat as she stared on with bewilderment at Adora. “Again, what the hell?!”

“Nothing.” Her voice had changed, and she took a breath before sliding the gear back to drive, and continuing down the main road. “We’re going to be late.”

Well that was the end of that.

--

They set up her booth in silence.

Catra hadn’t been able to stop sneaking glances at Adora, who had gone straight to unloading the product without a word. The only communication they had had in the last hour was Adora glancing at the row of booths and asking which one was Catra’s before heading over and setting up the baskets. Catra couldn’t help but feel like this was her fault, but every time she came close enough to say anything, Adora had practically darted away.

She used to do this.

Adora would react one of two ways to any sort of disagreement they had when they were younger - she would either fight with her teeth bared, or she would avoid Catra until she figured it out on her own. It seemed she was on the avoidant route this time, which would absolutely make for a stressful few hours trapped together behind a seven foot long booth. But there was no talking until Adora was ready, and Catra hoped by the time they were headed back to the homestead she would be.

Catra grabbed one of the lighter crates before heading back to the booth, gnawing at the inside of her cheek as she did her best not to interrupt the conversation happening between Adora and Lonnie. Catra knew that Lonnie was just picking up her weekly stock of eggs and veg and would be on her way soon, so she did her best to stay quiet.

“Hey , Catra!” Damn it. She lifted her head up just enough to greet her old classmate, pushing her bangs off her face. “Man, Adora’ s back and you managed to get her to come work for you? Lucky.” She placed a palm flat on the table with a grin. “If you ever get annoyed by her or her attitude, consider coming to work at the bar, huh?”

The two women in front of her laughed, and Catra could feel her teeth grinding.

“Nah, you know she’ s all talk,” Adora said, leaning back just a bit, her arms crossed over her chest. “No real *bite* behind it. Besides,” she

finally looked back at Catra and shrugged. "She feeds me. Can't quite let go of that."

Lonnie let out another whooping laugh before turning away with a smug little "well, it's an open offer!" leaving Catra practically seething behind Adora.

With a heavy breath, Catra threw herself down onto one of the short folding chairs that the market provided, dropping her chin into her hand with a frown. After two more quick exchanges, Adora sat down beside her, scooting her own chair just a touch closer. "Hey," she prodded, bumping their shoulders together. "You keep looking like such a sourpuss and you're gonna scare off all the customers."

"My stuff is good," Catra mumbled, turning slightly away from Adora. "People buy from me all the time and I always look like this."

Catra could hear a hum and the slight squeaking of Adora shifting in her chair before she felt someone else approach the booth.

"Oh, *you're* new"…

Catra felt her ear twitch with interest. She didn't recognize the voice, but clearly the person knew who worked here on a regular basis. Catra risked one glance up to see a tall woman with broad shoulders and long red hair leaning over the produce. "What's your name?"

"Oh!" The chair Adora had been sitting on screeched slightly as she stood, throwing her hand out for a shake. "Adora! Yeah I'm. New? Ish? I grew up here but just got back. Went to college but -- Ah, sorry, you don't care --" The woman laughed and Catra's eyes darted down to the joined hands between the two. "Your name is?"…

"Charlotte. Charlie if we're friends." Then her eyes dropped to Catra's for just a moment before locking back onto Adora's. "*You* can call me Charlie."

Catra felt her stomach drop as she let out an audible groan at how lame that was before Adora practically kicked her seat backwards.

"Well, nice to meet you, Charlie." Adora was doing that dorky laugh thing that happened whenever she was flustered, and Catra *had* to leave. Right now.

She stood up quickly from her chair and turned on her heel. "I'm getting another crate," she said, excusing herself, but felt her hackles rise at the complete lack of response.

Feeling the tension rising in her shoulders, Catra stalked back to the truck and sighed as she jumped up to sit on the edge of the bed, drawing her knees up to her chest. They had parked far enough away that she could get a moment of silence, but not so far that she couldn't still *see* that damn woman shamelessly flirting with Adora from across the booth if she sat in just the right position. Shit. Stop looking. Stop *looking* . But then Adora tugged all of her hair over one shoulder, and leaned forward on the table, and her smile grew and --

"Catra?"

She yelped and startled before gripping tightly to the edge of the truck bed before turning a narrowed gaze at the intruder . She groaned. "What do you want, Kyle?"

"I .Y. ou looked tense so I wanted to see if you were all ri--"

"I'm *fine* ," she hissed, her ears pinning back to her skull.

"Yeesh, all right," he said, backing away with his hands raised in the air. "Just wanted to check."

By the time he left, Catra could feel her frustration turning onto her *own* actions. There was literally no reason for her to be acting this way, but something inside of her felt like it had been shaken loose - a feeling she hadn't had in a long while, that honestly she thought she had managed to erase completely from her repertoire of *feelings* .

Then again, this only came up when it had something to do with *Adora* , who was new and fresh back in her life again. Maybe this had just been a terrible idea after all.

But at this point, Catra kind of wanted to start a fight.

Hopping down from the truck, Catra grabbed a heavy crate, stormed back to her booth, and dropped it onto the table, shaking their entire inventory.

"Hey , Charles!" she hollered, eyes glancing down to the fruit in the strangers hand and sticking out a palm. "You gonna pay for that?"

The woman blinked at her and frowned before placing it back in the basket.

"Nah, if you're not buying anything, move it along."

The confusion on her face would supply Catra with enough laughter for the next month, easy.

"And *you* ," she huffed, pointing a finger at Adora as the customer practically ran away, Adora's eyes following her for just a moment before snapping back to meet Catra's. "I'm not paying you to flirt. Get it together and keep it in your pants."

Adora blinked a couple times, her brows drawn close together, before nodding. "Yeah, sorry," was all she mustered before turning back to face the rest of the market.

That was better.

--

The rest of the day was silent. Every so often one of them would excuse themselves to get more product, and before they knew it they had sold pretty much everything and were packing it up for the day. It was profitable, even with the commotion she caused, and Catra was

more than thankful she hadn't just scared everyone off with her outburst.

Shame had settled in pretty quickly, though, and Catra had spent more time than she ought to have worrying about what to do next. She helped Adora load the crates back into the truck, snapped up the door to the bed, and made her way to the passenger side.

They both climbed in, and Adora started the truck with a sigh.

"I'm sorry," she mumbled, gripping the steering wheel harder. "You're right. I was working. That was unprofessional."

Catra genuinely couldn't believe her ears, and she balked at Adora's sincerity. "Okay, no, hang on, I was going to apologize. You can't ruin this for me!"

Then after a short moment, a soft laugh filled the cab of the truck. "You? Apologize? Since when?"

"I've been in therapy, Adora," Catra sighed, an air of drama lacing her words. "And." She swallowed, shrugging. "You weren't doing anything wrong. I really am sorry. I don't." A beat, and a lie. "I don't know what came over me."

She did. It was jealousy. Just like this morning.

"If it helps." Adora's cheeks were pink, and her fingers were twisting on the steering wheel. "I wasn't going to call her or anything. It just.felt nice."

That did help, and Catra thought maybe she should spend a moment investigating that later.

"I don't want that kind of thing anymore, you know?" Adora stuttered, working her jaw. "I.want something real, I guess."

Catra rubbed at the back of her neck before tearing her eyes away from Adora, a flush rising from her chest. "Yeah," she murmured,

drawing her knees up to her chest and wrapping her arms around them. "I get it."

It was what she wanted, too, if she was being honest with herself. Something real, with someone who cared.

She just wasn't ready to admit who the 'who' of it all was yet.

Chapter End Notes

> Looks like maybe we've got a little conflict arising hmmmmmmmm?
>
> Thanks again so much for reading y'all! I looove your comments and talking with all of you!! <3 please keep the feedback coming i really do thrive from it ;w;
>
> come hang out with me on twitter!!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hellllooooo!" Catra's front door swung open with a bang and she jumped, frowning at the sudden racket. "I come with the gift of coffee!"

It had been a few weeks since Adora had started working at the homestead, and she had quickly made herself completely comfortable in Catra's home. She would come over unannounced on her days off, let herself in through the front door, raid the kitchen when she needed a break, and even started using the shower before leaving.

When Catra had tried to tell her off the first couple of times, Adora had just given her one of those sad little pleading puppy dog pouts that she was *so* damn good at, and Catra would simply groan and give in. Now, it was almost like they had established a whole routine. Adora would come over, they would have coffee and talk about what the plan for the day was, maybe eat a little breakfast, and then Adora would get out to working.

So it went.

"I have cof fee here," Catra mumbled, holding up a steaming mug in front of her face. "And it's free."

Adora frowned and glanced down at the two cups in her fists, before lifting them just a fraction higher. "But it's from Spinny's cafe." A small waggle of her eyebrows, as if to be enticing. "I got the dark mocha just for you! I know it's your favorite."

Narrowed eyes scanned down and then back up the woman sheepishly standing in front of her before Catra sighed and put her

mug on the counter. "Well, since you already paid for it, I guess I *have* to drink it." It absolutely didn't affect her at all when their fingers brushed as she took the cup from Adora's hands. "Just lightly flavored, right?"

"Only two and a half circles around the cup, I know."

Of course she did.

Adora's grin grew even wider as Catra took her first sip, feeling slightly annoyed that it was absolutely perfect. At this point she almost wished her tastes had changed since she was eighteen. "Thank you," she said, nail tapping at the lid of the cup. "It's great."

She watched as Adora's satisfied lips curled over her own cup, sipping slowly at the steaming hot beverage, eyes locking onto Catra's. She leaned against the counter, taking another long swig of her own drink, before a flush blossomed over her cheeks and chest as she realized that they were just *staring* at one another as they drank their coffee. It felt too intimate, and Catra felt uncomfortable.

"Do you want the paper?" Catra asked, reaching blindly behind her to find the slightly crumpled newsprint. "Nothing too exciting. Some political scandal, some rich white man saying misogynistic things, you know. Typical."

Adora closed the space between them to lean on her elbows right next to Catra, brushing their arms together just slightly. She started flipping through the pages as Catra felt her heart racing beneath her ribs, but she couldn't find it in herself to pull away. Adora was always so warm and strong, and having the pressure of her pressing against Catra's own body felt nice and familiar and safe. "What sports news do you get out here these days?"

Snorting, Catra let her head fall back to catch Adora's gaze. "Not much, hotshot. They covered you for a little while, though." Adora stood up again, and Catra found herself frowning at the loss of

contact before she lifted her hands up, fingers spread, in front of her chest to frame the scene. "Hometown Hero Wins Again."

"What' s the last thing they said about me?"

Catra startled slightly at the panic in Adora's voice. She lifted her head rather lazily to look back up at Adora, squinting while trying to remember. "I don't know ." Truth be told she had tried her best to avoid the stories about Adora altogether. "Maybe. When you got signed? I didn't pay attention after a while."

Her eyes dropped to where Adora had started tugging at a loose thread on her shirt. "... You okay?"

"Oh, me?" She laughed, waving her hands in front of her face. "Yeah, yeah, *yeah* . I'm good! Excellent!" Catra watched her face falter before spreading into a wide smile. "Just peachy!" Adora stumbled backwards, reaching for the door. "So. Gotta go feed the chicks! Uhh," she paused and flexed her hand once, as if she was debating saying something else.

Catra hadn't moved, a little taken aback by this anxious display in front of her. "Adora?"

"Chickens, then root veg, then ." she had begun mumbling to herself as she pulled the door shut behind her, and Catra was left blinking in utter confusion.

--

Catra had tried to bring Adora her coffee that she had left sitting on the kitchen table, but she had seemed so spaced out that she barely even registered it - now it was just getting cold on the hood of the tractor instead. Catra couldn't help but continue watching her more closely than usual.

It almost seemed like Adora was on autopilot, going through the motions but not really experiencing anything she was doing.

Everything seemed to have a sense of urgency, and…

Catra's ear twitched as she frowned, a memory of a much smaller Adora storming out into the field flashing in front of her.

Then she turned around, and could practically *see* a much younger set of heterochromatic eyes staring back at her.

"Adora?" Catra's tail whipped behind her as she stalked through the kitchen, heading to the porch. "Adoraaaa?" She frowned and looked out across the field, finally spotting Adora running back and forth between the sheep, as if trying to herd them herself instead of letting the dogs do what they were purchased to do. "Adora!"

Catra used all four of her limbs to sprint out and over the fence, leaping onto her friend and knocking her to the ground. "Hey, Adora," she smirked, poking one finger against her best friend's forehead. "What'cha doin'?"

Blue eyes stared up at her, wide and wet, as Adora wiggled under her hips in a struggle to get out. "Let me go, Catra."

Sitting up, Catra frowned and settled into the others' lap as Adora followed to sit upright. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong." Adora wiped at her cheeks with a clear air of irritation before pushing Catra off of her. "Just gotta do the work."

Catra grunted as her bottom hit the dirt, and growled up at Adora. "You're not even supposed to be working! We were doing homework and then you disappeared!" Adora stood in front of her, hands balled up into fists, before Catra jumped up to her feet. "Besides," she yelled, controlled but annoyed. "Weaver isn't here and she hates when we do stuff without asking."

Adora froze then, before her entire body deflated and she fell back to her butt and drew her knees up to her chest, burying her face into them. Catra could hear her mumble something, but her words were

muffled. She heard Mira's name, though, and that was enough to make her sit back down beside her best friend.

"It'd be easier to hear you if you weren't eating your pants."

That got a small chuckle out of Adora, and she turned her head to press her cheek against her knee. She hesitated for a moment, but then let out a shaky sigh. "They won't let Mira adopt me."

"What?" Catra genuinely couldn't believe her ears. Mira had practically been raising Adora since they were seven and she was sixteen, when she became her big sister at the local youth center. The second she turned eighteen she had applied for adoption, and the home had been running her in circles for the last three years.

"They said she's too sick, and that they don't want." Adora swallowed, and Catra watched her eyes grow glossy. "They don't want to have to rehome me again later, or something like." She stopped, and Catra knew exactly what she was thinking.

Rehome. Like she was an animal.

Catra frowned, and scooted closer to Adora, leaning her head against her shoulder. "Has she been getting worse?"

Adora only nodded.

They sat in silence for a while, Adora slowly relaxing as Catra dragged a light nail up and down her arm. "I..." Adora started, frowning and wrapping her arms tighter around her knees. "Can we go do something?"

"Yeah!" Catra said, a little too enthusiastically as she jumped back to her feet. She wasn't good with words, but she was pretty okay at being a distraction. "Wanna get ice cream?" She held a hand out for Adora, smiling when she felt a shaky palm slide into hers.

Adora smiled as she leveraged herself off of the dirt. "Yeah, sounds fun."

A mischievous smirk curled on Catra's lips. "Last one to the end of the drive has to pay."

With a giggle and an ignored protest, Catra started to run, laughing harder as she heard Adora's smiling shouts of "you're a cheater!" echoing down the path.

As she snapped out of the memory, Catra felt an urge to do something childish and stupid. She didn't hesitate as she threw open the porch door, and started sprinting towards Adora, who was busy weeding the tomato patch. With a swiftness she forgot she had, she clambered up the nearest tree, perched herself on the edge, and started throwing small bits of bark at her farmhand.

Adora flinched and swatted at the air around her before turning her gaze up to the tree.

"Hey, Adora," Catra purred, flicking her thumb and pointer finger claws together. "What'cha doin'?"

She looked around, momentarily confused, before drawing her eyebrows down on her forehead. "... Working?" Adora looked like she was trying to hold back a smile as she crossed her arms over her chest and shifted her weight to one foot. "What are *you* doing?"

"You know," Catra hummed, moving smoothly from a squat to lay her body across the firm branch of the tree, using her bent arm to prop her head up as her tail swished in the air below her. "I *was* just minding my own business, but then my farmhand started acting all weird and tense out of nowhere." She etched a couple lines into the bark with her claw, sighing. "And *then* while I was making lunch, I remembered that the *best* way to get her to snap out of it"…

She felt Adora's gaze lock onto her before a low and warning "Catra" filled the space between them.

“W as a little friendly competition.”

And before Adora even had a moment to register what was happening, Catra had sprung back to her feet before leaping off of the tree branch to tackle her friend to the ground, trapping Adora’s body beneath her own. Hands encircled wrists, feet hooked around thighs, and suddenly they were in a position that had Catra flushed from both exhilaration and embarrassment as Adora’s hips bucked beneath her.

“Get of f!”

“Ask *nicer* ,”Catra laughed, and then felt her entire body tense as Adora stilled beneath her, chest heaving. “Or tell me what’ s wrong.”

“Catra, seriously .”Adora’ s voice was even, but clearly irritated. “W e’re not little kids anymore and you can’t just.”Her fists flexed and Catra knew she had more than enough strength to just push her off if she wanted, but Adora was holding back. “Nothing’ s wrong. I just have to work. That’ s why you’re paying me, right?”

There was something in her voice that Catra couldn’t quite place. Something wrong. Something that hinted to what exactly was going through her ex’s head.

She let go of her wrists and sat up, still straddling Adora’s hips. “Y ou and I both know you get everything done in half the time you’re allotted for it.”

Adora lifted up to rest on her forearms, shrugging nonchalantly.

“Y ou can take a minute, if you need one. You know.”Catra swallowed and, against her better judgement, placed a firm hand against the side of Adora’s neck, relief washing over her as Adora leaned into the familiar comfort. “This shit doesn’t matter .”

Adora’s head lolled back between her shoulders as she laughed, her whole body shaking underneath Catra. “W ow,”she sighed, a few

lingering chuckles escaping her lips. "Therapy really has been doing wonders for you, hasn't it?"

"Oh, shut up." Catra shoved a hand against Adora's cheek, smirking before standing up and offering an outstretched hand. "Do you want some lunch or not?"

Adora took her hand and stood, fingers gentle against the racing pulse in Catra's wrist. "Last one inside does the dishes?" Adora offered, before leaping into action and sprinting towards the house.

"Hey!" Catra let out a loud groan before taking off on all fours, catching up with ease. "I cooked!"

--

Adora had actually *asked* to use the shower, after weeks of just running up Catra's water bill, and Catra had been taken aback enough to press a palm to her forehead and ask if she had been running a fever. Adora had laughed her off and apologized for just barging in and taking over, and very meekly excused herself to the bathroom after Catra had promised her that, yes, of *course* it was fine.

But she wasn't sure that Adora was fine.

So she sat awkwardly in the kitchen, reading some trashy novel that Weaver had stashed in her office, and waited quite impatiently for Adora to descend back down. Adora was a quick showerer, but the eight minutes she took today felt like a lifetime to Catra as she continued to read the same line of the book over and over again. Damn.

The water cut out, and a few minutes later heavy, offbeat footsteps came down the stairs, and Catra did her absolute best to seem nonchalant, flipping the page slowly as she let her eyes drag up to Adora, who was scrubbing her hair dry with a large towel. "So"…

Adora said, her cheeks tinged pink either from the heat of the shower or mild embarrassment. "Thanks for earlier."

Catra frowned, folding down the page she was on as if it mattered, and sat up a little straighter. "Sure"…

With a soft throat clear, Adora stepped into the other room to throw the used towel into the laundry room and pushed her still damp hair back off of her neck. "I guess I can still get. You know. In my head." Adora shrugged her shoulders before coming closer and dropping herself into the chair across from Catra. "Thanks for noticing."

Her eyes had gone soft, and she smiled with just one side of her mouth as her eyebrows dropped down into this gentle curve and it was *so much* like the way she used to tell Catra that she loved her, that Catra felt like she was being choked, and that she had to *run*.

But. She didn't *want* to.

Catra smiled. "Not something you just forget about a person, I guess," she said, and she meant it in the best way she could.

Adora took a deep breath in before sighing and leaned backwards in the chair. "Guess not."

They sat in silence for a moment as Adora seemed to grow uncomfortable in her seat, clearly not taking this lull in conversation well. Catra watched her, carefully, eyes tracking the twitch of her fingers and the tensing of her shoulders as she seemed to debate with herself what to do next. "I," she started, tensing and then dropping her head to look at the ground. "I left the league on. not so good terms. That's why I was curious if. they said anything about it here."

"... Oh?"

Catra watched with intrigue as Adora caught her bottom lip between her teeth, pulling at already flaking skin. "Yeah it just. it didn't work

out. And I didn’t know how to…handle it. So I just…left?” She shifted again, her shoulders coming closer to her ears as she let out a heavy breath. “The season’s over so it’s not like it *really* matters I guess but…I…”

She hadn’t realized it, but the next thing Catra knew she was kneeling by Adora’s side, her nails digging into the skin of Adora’s forearm. “You don’t have to say, if you don’t want to.”

Adora’s face washed over with relief and then her arms were encircling Catra, pulling her up into a warm hug as Adora pressed her chin into the crook of Catra’s neck. “Thanks. Seriously.” When Adora paused, Catra raked her fingers through still damp hair, nodding once. “I’m…really happy you gave me a chance, Catra.”

“… You’re such an idiot.”

“I know.”

Chapter End Notes

> What was the point of writing ahead if i still can’t manage to keep a consistent update schedule lmaoooo.
>
> There’s a touch of softness returning here, and isn’t it lovely?
>
> Thank you all for your kind comments as always ;w; they really make my day!!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was definitely juicing this lemon with far more force than was necessary, but she couldn't *help* it. Adora was out there looking cuter than she had *any* right to be, and Catra was stuck in here doing paperwork. And juicing lemons.

A few days ago Adora had made a stupid joke about how she sometimes thought maybe she should be dressing more the part of a farmer, and Catra had told her that she didn't have the guts, and then she grinned and said *watch me* - and now she was here in a red and black flannel with thick black embroidery, and dark high waisted pants that seemed to be modeled after chaps, fringed at the top of her thighs. Not to mention the oversized and tacky silver belt buckle at her waist, and those *god awful* big brown leather boots.

"You look more like a cowboy than a farmer"…

Adora had grinned and shrugged, shoving her hands deep into her pockets. "It's all that was in Mara's closet, and we know she pretty much *was* a cowgirl."Then her smile turned overly excited as she jumped back towards her truck, telling Catra just to hang on for *one minute*, and disappeared into the cab of it.

And, god damn it, Catra almost fell to the ground laughing as Adora reappeared from behind her truck with the *worst* looking stetson she had ever seen. "Take it off, please, oh my god,"Catra wheezed between laughter, practically screaming as Adora darted at her, mischief on her face.

"You're right,"she had said, hooking an arm around Catra's shoulders to keep her in place. "It would look so much better on you."Adora caught the tip of the hat between two fingers and

maneuvered it over Catra's curls. "Pretty girls in big dumb hats, what a combo!"

"Get of f!" Catra laughed, shoving at Adora's chest, a squeak of surprise escaping her as they lost their balance and went toppling down to the dirt drive. Adora had landed on top of her, as they both tried to catch their breath from the hysterics that had busted out. "You're," she sighed, bracing a palm against Adora's shoulder, swallowing thickly as she caught sight of Adora's exposed collarbone. "The worst."

"Actually," Adora smirked, reaching out to grab the hat again before pushing it back over her ponytail, and tipping it downward. "I'm the *best*."

"Whatever you want to think, hotshot," Catra grunted as she shoved with more force against Adora's shoulder, encouraging her to move. "Now get of f me!" There was no edge to her words as she bit back a smile. "Will you get to work?"

Adora had given her a nod as she stood up, brushing off her pants and helping Catra back to her feet. "You got it, boss."

And then she went to it, pretty loudly complaining about how she had made a mistake and couldn't do her work as efficiently as normal, and Catra had only laughed at her and told her to *suck it up, buttercup*, because there was no way she was getting out of doing her work just because she had to be stubborn. She had abandoned the hat, at least.

Catra yelped as a stray squirt of lemon hit her eye and threw the offending object down to the ground with a hiss. She reached blindly for a towel, pressing it against her irritated eye, and glared at the lemon now sad and limp on the floor.

Why the hell was she making hand-squeezed lemonade anyway?! There was literally no reason for this, because she didn't even really *like* lemonade!

But…

Adora did.

A frustrated groan rumbled up from her chest as her eye calmed down, and she dropped the towel back onto the counter before looking over what she had managed to get done. There was just the right amount of juice for a couple servings, and that was going to have to be good enough. Catra moved to finish the mixture, making sure to keep it just as tart as Adora liked it, and poured it over two big glasses of ice before heading out towards where Adora was moving some hay bales around.

"Hey ," Catra started, feeling her throat tighten as Adora looked up at her, a question raised on her features. "I…" Her eyes dropped to where Adora had unbuttoned the top of her shirt, low enough that the top of her bra was peeking out. "Here' s some lemonade." Her throat was so dry.

Jesus christ, It wasn't even a sexy bra! Catra seriously needed to get a *grip* .

A smile pulled at Adora's lips as she dropped the last bale and stood up straight, glancing once at the cups in Catra's hand. "... Thank you, Catra," she said, reaching forward to take one of the drinks. "I… definitely needed this."

"Y -yeah, sure." God damn it. Catra could hear the stammer in her voice as their fingers brushed together and Adora lifted the dripping glass to her lips. She went at the lemonade as if she had never had a drink before in her *life* , and Catra knew she was staring - *God* was she staring - as the cool liquid trickled down from the rim of the cup, over Adora's chin, down her throat and sharp clavicle and settled right between her cleavage.

She had to be doing this on *purpose* .

Catra's tongue darted out to wet her bottom lip as she definitely *wasn't* thinking about how nice it might taste to drag her mouth over the expanse of Adora's sun flushed skin, now sticky with sweet sugar and lemon. She *absolutely* wasn't remembering their last summer together, when they took popsicles up into the loft of the barn and Adora's clueless licking of her fingers as the ice pop melted down her skin turned Catra into such a wreck that they wound up letting the popsicles soak into the wood as their mouths became otherwise occupied.

".spilling!"

Catra snapped her head up to meet Adora's questioning gaze, and immediately felt her whole face flush at the smirk pulling on Adora's chapped lips. "What?"

"You're." Adora pointed down with one finger unwrapped from the glass. "... spilling your entire drink." Catra yelped and threw the cup over the fence with much more aggression than was necessary. She was practically seething until Adora chuckled and offered a weak "... didn't you feel that?"

"I." she swallowed and felt her face grow impossibly redder as she forced her eyes to meet Adora's, not backing down. "I was distracted."

Adora snorted and Catra couldn't help but notice how her knuckles were growing slightly white as her grip on the glass tightened. Interesting. Adora's eyes dragged down Catra's flushed chest and she raised a cocky eyebrow. "By what?" She *had* done it on purpose.

"Ugh, shut up," Catra mumbled, crossing her arms over her chest. She tapped her foot once on the slushy ground beneath her toes and grimaced. "I'm gonna .go shower and change."

Adora's lips were pressed together as if she were holding back a laugh. "Okay." She put her glass on a flat edge of the fence before placing two firm hands on the wood. "I'll go retrieve that cup you

decided was worth punishing,”she said, before hoisting her body up and over the fence.

Fucking Adora, always having to show off. And fucking *Catra*, so easily distracted by how good her ass looked in those dorky pants.

Catra growled under her breath as she turned back to the house, stomping her wet feet against the ground.

She supposed it was going to have to be a *cold* shower.

--

So maybe Catra took a little extra time in the shower. Maybe she couldn’t stop thinking about Adora’s strong body pressing her into all of the secret corners that they had discovered in high school. Maybe she couldn’t stop picturing those thick, calloused fingers helping her out of her clothes, or warm palms stroking over her skin. Maybe the thought of a smart mouth making its way down her entire body was enough to topple her over the edge.

Maybe it was time to admit that she still had *something* for Adora.

But admitting it didn’t mean she had to do anything about it. Doing something about it wasn’t *safe*.

Catra made sure to take all the time she needed to hopefully ensure that Adora had finished her work and given up on waiting around to say goodbye. She sat in the bathroom in her towel for about thirty minutes, letting herself dry as naturally as possible before moving to the counter to start on her neglected hair routine. A handful of products and drying time later, Catra finally emerged from the still steamy bathroom before peeking out of the hall window to check if Adora’s truck was still parked outside.

It was.

With a sigh, she started moving around the upstairs again, doing mindless tasks that might take up some time. Maybe if Adora heard her moving around but not coming *down* the stairs, she'd take a hint and leave.

She managed to kill another hour by starting laundry and folding some old sheets and tidying up her bedroom.

Adora still hadn't left.

God damn it.

With a sigh, Catra resigned herself to the fact that Adora probably wouldn't be going anywhere until they spoke. It frustrated her to no end that Adora was *still* like this - always needing to make sure everything was all right before she could relax and move on with her life.

Catra stomped down the stairs in an attempt to make as much noise as possible before swinging around the knob at the end of the banister. Their eyes met, and Catra did her best to stay deadpan. "You're still here?"

Adora's eyes fell to the ground as she shrugged, crossing her arms over her chest and drawing Catra's attention to her large forearms, now exposed by rolled up sleeves. "You seemed." Blue eyes looked up again and her mouth quirked to one side like it always did when she thought something was wrong. "I don't know . Not upset but"…

Rolling her eyes, Catra took some steps forward to close the distance between them. "I'm fine. You can go now."

"Wait but --" Adora took a step forward, hand out as if she were reaching for Catra's shoulder.

"Adora." She paused, and Catra felt her lips curling up to bare her teeth. "You don't have to do this still, you know." Catra almost

relished in the confusion on Adora's features, feeling the hair on the back of her neck standing on end. "I'm not your responsibility anymore. I haven't been for a long time."

"Catra. I know I don't *have* to do anything..." Adora's voice was low and gentle, just like it was when she had tried to talk Catra down from anger when they were younger - when she was more regularly out of control. "I just wanted to make sure you were all right." She was approaching slowly, as if Catra were a wild animal.

It just pissed her off more.

"Get out of my house."

Adora stood firm, towering further over Catra as she sunk back on her heels, as if she were ready to attack.

"Catra, I'm not doing that."

She really hadn't expected to get this angry. She hadn't gotten angry like this in years, and in all honesty, she didn't even know *why* she was this angry, but everything inside of her needed Adora as *far* away from her as possible. A groan tore from her throat and Catra tangled her fingers into her own hair. "Why are you like this? I'm asking you to *leave*." She was pacing now, and she could feel her tail flicking dangerously behind her. "Why can't you ever just do what *I* want you to do?"

"I…"

"You weren't there when I *wanted* you to be! Why won't you just leave now, like you did before?"

Oh.

Adora looked stunned, her eyebrows high on her forehead as she stared back with disbelief. Catra didn't know if it was thirty seconds or thirty minutes before Adora responded, but she *did* know that it

wasn’t what she wanted to hear. "That’ s not *fair* . You broke up with *me* ."

Taking a deep breath, Catra straightened up and did her best to regain some composure, pushing her bangs back off of her face. "Y ou left first."

A scoff tore from Adora’s throat and she threw her hands up over her head. "What? Did you just want me to rot here forever?" Her voice broke, and it was *so* satisfying to get Adora angry.

Catra dragged her eyes down Adora’s body, and let out a bitter laugh. "W ell you’re *back* now so clearly it’s not *rotting* ." She felt out of control. She felt like she was eighteen again. This wasn’t good. This was so, so *bad* .

She watched as Adora’s throat bobbed as she swallowed, the way she shrunk back. "I.. I needed to go, Catra. I needed to see what else there *was* ."

"And then you just come crawling back?" Catra crossed her arms over her chest, smug and demeaning. "Why are you even here, Adora?"

"I"…

Catra let out another scoff of a laugh. "Honestly , I don’t really care. Just leave."

The look on Adora’s face as she grabbed her keys and stormed towards the door made Catra falter and she took off after her, a hand reaching desperately for Adora’s wrist. "W ait, Adora, I -"

"I thought you were dif ferent, Catra," Adora snapped, spinning on her heel and poking a hard finger into Catra’s chest. "I thought you had grown up. I thought we might." The words got caught in her throat as she bit them back, shaking her head. "But you’re still just as quick to shut me down as you always have been, aren’t you?"

no no no no please, don't leave again.

Adora took a deep breath in through her nose at Catra's silence and fisted her hands at her sides. "Are you willing to talk about this, or not?"

"I am," Catra said, too quickly, and she didn't know *why* but her fingers were curling around Adora's wrist. "I didn't. I didn't mean it."

Adora's eyes looked down to where their skin met, and let out a heavy sigh. "... Okay." And then her fist was opening and she was holding Catra's hand, giving her a firm squeeze. "Then we'll talk about it."

"Okay."

Releasing her grip, Adora took a step back and sucked in a clearly insecure breath. "I know I don't work tomorrow but I could come by. If that works."

Catra nodded, stepping back and gripping at her upper arm with shaking fingers. "Yeah," she started, before adding on a hasty "please."

"Okay," Adora smiled, taking a step back. "I'll see you tomorrow, then."

And then she left, and Catra stepped back into her house, shut the door, and slid down the wall until her knees were under her chin.

Maybe Adora caring so much if she was okay wasn't the *worst* thing in the world.

Chapter End Notes

Catra :(sometimes she still lets her anger get the better of her.

At least she fixed it quickly though. No sense in getting that mad just because you have FEELINGS, right?

Sorry for the delay on this! I try to stay ahead but I've been in a bit of a block lately, and drawing a lot more than writing these past couple of weeks.

Hope you all had a great holiday!!

As always, i love and appreciate all the comments!! You make my heart soar ;w;

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[hey adora .are we okay?]

[yeah,we'll be okay .talk tomorrow ,right? can come by at like 9]

[please]

[cant wait)]

Catra couldn't stop staring at her phone. Adora's reassurance had been enough to let her sleep last night, but now it was nine and she had finished all of her morning work and she was just *waiting* . She had almost been hoping that they could just avoid this talk altogether - what was the point in bringing up the past when they had both moved on?

Except..they hadn't, had they? Not really . Not when her subconscious mind got her angry and yelling about Adora leaving. Not when Adora clearly hadn't been telling her the whole truth about why she was back, even if Catra had said she didn't need to.

Catra really had thought this would be okay - to ignore their past and just move forward with whatever this was - but maybe in the end this would be for the better. Her therapist had been trying to convince her that it was all right to be vulnerable and to let people know how she was feeling in regards to their actions. Maybe it was time she listened.

Especially since a major part of the reason they had crashed and burned so spectacularly was *because* they failed to talk about the big things. So much could have been avoided if she had just let Adora *know* that she had been feeling neglected. Maybe if Adora had come

to *her* with her stress, too.Catra had even managed to hide that she was —

Her phone chimed, and Catra sighed with relief.

[my thing wrapped up early .can i come over now?]

[definitely]

[)]

That meant at least thirty less minutes of awkward and anxious waiting around. So Catra did her dishes, swept up some of the dirt that made it into her kitchen, and then perked up with an involuntary chirp when she heard the telltale sound of Adora's truck crunching up the drive. It took her about half a second to abandon the broom in the middle of the floor and dart outside just in time to see Adora park as she dug her claws into the railing of her porch.

The engine shut off and Adora stepped out, immediately catching sight of Catra and smiling, and Catra resisted every pull in her stupid body that was telling her to just leap over this rail into Adora' s arms and let her hold her until it was all okay again.

"Hey , Adora,"she settled for instead, pushing up just enough to lean forward so she was hovering over where the tall blonde had stopped beneath her. Catra looked over her non-work clothes, smiling at her dorky t-shirt under her light jacket - it had a picture of *Adora* diving for a soccer ball poorly screen printed on it and simply said *She's a Keeper!* in cursive underneath. Catra could only assume it was some jokey shirt that Adora' s college friends had made, and Adora always had been the sentimental type. "W anna come inside?"

Adora shrugged and jabbed a thumb over her shoulder . "I was actually thinking maybe we could go for a walk? Might be easier than just staring at one another ."Catra cocked an eyebrow but made quick work of moving to hop down the short stairs. "W e can go to the creek, maybe?"

Nodding, Catra took a few steps before turning back to face Adora, whose brows were knitted together with worry. With a half smile, Catra pressed her pointer finger to the crease on Adora's forehead, dragging her attention back to Catra. "Hey , what's wrong?"

"I guess," she started, finally bringing her gaze up to meet Catra's. "I never thought we'd actually get to talk about this?"

Catra understood that. She had gone to pretty meticulous lengths to make sure Adora couldn't contact her for a while there.

"I just." The fear in her voice was overwhelming. Catra couldn't stand for her to continue. Not here. Not yet.

"Let's walk, yeah?"

Adora gave her a short nod before they started the trek, side by side.

They stayed quiet for a few minutes, just walking, bumping their hands together on occasion, as they continued down the very familiar path towards one of their more secretive spots. Catra had come here once after they had split up, and it had been almost too much. But it was at least a twenty minute walk, so Catra knew that they were going to have to say *something* before they got there.

"Hey I'm…"

Adora looked up at her, a small but encouraging smile on her lips.

"I'm sorry , about last night. I… I shouldn't have snapped like that." Catra kept walking, grateful that Adora was keeping up with her slightly faster than usual pace.

"I mean, I get it." Adora paused and made a low humming noise in the back of her throat before sighing and shrugging. "Well I guess I don't really *get* it."

Catra bit at her lip, and crossed her arms over her chest, trying her best to find the right words. "It's just like..." God, Adora's overt caring in her stare was unbearable at times like this. "I guess sometimes you're just such a damn good person that it makes me mad."

She could see the confusion washing over Adora's face. "Was that why you used to get mad at me out of nowhere?" she asked, shoving her hands into the pockets of her light coat, clearly from her semi-pro soccer team.

A scoff of irritation. "It wasn't from *nowhere*." How could she explain this better?

"Felt like it."

Catra groaned, running a hand down her face. "Okay, I get that. It must have felt that way to *you*. But I guess sometimes *I* just felt… second best. And like you felt sorry for me." Adora stumbled over a rock, and Catra reached out to help steady her, fingers burying into the puffy sleeves of Adora's jacket. "So... when you stuck around just because you *thought* I was upset, I guess it... reminded me of that? How I always felt like you just pitied me."

Adora's face fell, clear concern lacing into her features. "I never pitied you."

"I know that *now*."

"Do you?"

Adora just kept *staring*, and Catra felt like she might lose it at any minute. So she took a step back, sucking in a deep breath of air through her nose, and let go of Adora's arms.

"*Yes*."

Gesturing for Catra to continue down the path, Adora rolled her shoulders before speaking. "So, what, should I just act like I don't

care if you seem upset then?" There was no edge to her words. There was *rarely* an edge to Adora's words.

"No," Catra sighed, taking a few steps backwards so she could face Adora. "That's not at all what I'm saying."

Adora looked distressed, and her soft voice only enhanced her clear confusion. "Then what do you want me to do?"

"Nothing." Catra paused, and placed her hands on Adora's shoulders. "Be yourself. It's… *me*. I'm the one who has to work on controlling my emotions about that." She squeezed once and dropped her gaze to the ground. "I guess you coming back has stirred up some things I thought had worked through."

She looked up to see Adora's throat bob as she frowned and averted her own eyes.

"Don't get me wrong, Adora. I'm so happy you're back. I really…" Feeling heat blossoming under her skin, Catra lowered her voice, almost ashamed, as she mumbled a soft "I missed you."

But Adora perked up, and raised her hands to rest gently on Catra's elbows. "I missed you, too," she said, her cheeks pink as a small smile stretched across her lips.

Catra took a deep breath before pulling away, and continuing down the path in front of them. She felt lighter already, and couldn't help but bask in the relief as Adora held out a hand to help her clamber over some loose rocks. Had that been enough for Adora? Would she just move on without addressing the rest?

Their hands lingered together as they walked, gently cupping one another's fingers. It felt…nice, and Catra resisted the conflicting urges to both pull away and lace their fingers together. This was comfortable, as they kept moving, until Adora squeezed once, and then pulled away, prompting Catra to turn and look up at her.

"I really didn't want to leave you, Catra. You know that, right?" Her voice was firm but quiet, as if she knew this conversation would be more difficult.

Catra kept her response just above a whisper, scared of admitting the truth. "I don't know."

"Mara was gone, and this town felt suffocating, and I just wanted to see more, you know?" Taking a deep breath, Adora let their eyes meet again, a sad smile on her lips. "See what I could make of myself."

"Yeah."

Adora shoved her hands back into her pockets and continued moving, avoiding meeting Catra's eyes. "I wanted to ask you to come with me. But I didn't want to put that kind of decision on you, either. And I just didn't know if you'd be happy. I would still have been in class or at practice all the time, and." She rolled her head back, staring up at the leaves overhead. "Imagine if you *had* come and we still wound up the same way. I'd feel even worse for making you move."

"I would have. One, I mean." Catra swallowed once, and dropped her eyes to the dirt, watching her step. "I just wanted to be with you."

A heavy silence fell over them for what felt like an *hour* before Adora spoke up again.

"Don't you see how scary that is? Like. Didn't you have your own dreams and goals?"

Catra tensed, crossing her arms over her chest. "Not really. Weaver beat those out of me young. I thought. Maybe." She felt a sharp pang in her chest, as if admitting this would hurt more than she had realized. "As long as I had you, it would be okay."

"But you're okay now , right?" Adora asked, finally looking at Catra again. "And you did it all on your own."

She could have laughed - but she settled for a shrug and a half smile. "It wasn't for a long time. But .some good people helped me out when I needed it most."

There was no missing how Adora tensed. Her shoulders rose up to her ears, her jaw clenched and flexed (and Catra scolded herself for thinking about how *hot* Adora's jawline was at a moment like this), and her hands in her pockets drew in closer, closing up the jacket over her chest. It was all signature Adora Blaming Herself body language, and Catra let out a heaving sigh.

"Look, Adora. It took me a long time to understand that I messed up just as much - if not more - than you did. But we were kids, right? We were both stupid. I wanted to be the most important thing in your life, and I wasn't, for a bit. And that should have been okay . It was okay that other things were more important."

Adora stopped walking, pain evident on her features as her brows drew closer and that crease in her forehead returned.

"You were *always* the most important thing in my life. But I was spending so much time and money to be there and I couldn't let it slip - but they were only a bigger priority at the time, never more *important* - and it would have been the wrong thing to throw it away"…

Catra couldn't look at her, so she settled on watching the erratic movement of her hands, still jammed into her pockets, as she used the motion for emphasis on her words.

"And then you broke up with me and blocked me and I couldn't even talk to you and the one time I tried to come by like a week later Weaver said "—

Wait, what?

"You came here?"

Adora ignored her interjection.

"—that you moved. You left. And she said she had no idea where you went. So what could I do? I just.why didn't you talk to me?"

Adora's chest was heaving as Catra stared at her, caught up in the worry between her eyes. For once, she was at a loss for words. Weaver had known *exactly* where she was, and hadn't known about the break up so why.why *wouldn't* she have told Adora where Catra had been?

"I just wanted you to talk to me. We could have worked it out. I—" Her voice broke as her shoulders fell.

Catra felt a lump forming in her throat as she stepped back and closed in on herself. She could hear the creek, just a few more feet away, and she felt it best to keep moving as she spoke. "It was so *hurt* , Adora. I felt so little, and so much like I would never matter to you again and I just wanted to cut ties and be done with it."

"*Why* ?"Adora was practically jogging to keep up with Catra's quick steps.

"Because."

She felt wound too tightly, bound to snap at the tiniest of tugs.

"Because *why* !"

Spinning on her heel, Catra threw her hands out to her sides, leaning her entire body forward in accusation. Her voice was louder than she had expected it to be as she burst.

"Because you chose your new life over *me* , Adora!"

"I didn't—

A small, barked laugh tore from her throat as she leaned back just slightly, less aggressive than before. "You *did* . And that's *okay* . I know I didn't handle it right. But can you please just admit that that' s what happened? Stop pretending like you weren't happier."

Adora sounded like a kicked puppy as she whimpered out "I would have been happier if you were *there* ."

"But I wasn't," Catra said, shrugging, and turning to head to the bank of the water. "And you *still* were happier."

Sitting heavily on a large stone, Catra brushed the dirt away from the surface beside her. It took a few moments, but eventually she heard the crunch of Adora's shoes coming closer. It felt good to get it off of her chest after all these years, but the silence was deafening as Adora sat beside her, pressing her shoulder into Catra's back.

"I'm sorry , Catra. For making you feel like—" Adora paused, and fixed her words. "For doing that to you."

Catra sighed and leaned her head back, bumping it gently against Adora's. "I know ."

"I think maybe I got caught up in what a dif ferent world it was. There was always stuff to do and I was so afraid to let my grades slip or lose my scholarship *and* not take advantage of everything Brightmoon had to offer that I.put our relationship on the back burner." Adora scooted closer , her hand bracing beside Catra's hip as Adora readjusted. "You're right, and I'm sorry."

A gentle purr vibrated from Catra's chest when Adora hooked her chin over her shoulder, their cheeks pressed together. It was familiar, and calming, and so very *welcome* .

"... Thank you."

Adora nodded, and Catra felt a small bubble of guilt in her stomach.

“And I’m sorry , too. For not giving you a chance to talk about it. That wasn’t fair .”

And then Adora let out a soft laugh of a breath, and nodded again, but kept her chin planted right where it was. It wasn’t until Adora’s hand crept forward to settle on top of her own - so much warmth and comfort in one action - that Catra felt her entire body relax.

“Well, we got to talk now. Better late than never, right?”

Catra pushed back against the guilt, the shame, and the grief over all the years lost where she could have had *this* , and felt a genuine smile tug at her lips.

“Yeah. Right.”

Chapter End Notes

Before anything else, please check out this beautiful art that the ever lovely @candyvela did for this chapter ;w;i'm obsessed!!!!!!!

heeeheee, whoops! sorry for the big break ♡ I got kind of down after getting a few pretty critical (and one downright negative) reviews on here and wanted to take a step back for a bit. Unfortunately it means that I've turned off anonymous reviews but I'm still so grateful for all the super kind anons i've gotten!!

But I hope this chapter makes up for it! :3 this was the last one I had pre-written, so... here's hoping I don't fall *totally* behind again! I've also been working on Stream-Ra quite a bit so if you're into gamers, please feel free to check that one out as I've got a few things finished for it and will hopefully start posting more soon!!

Thanks everyone for reading as always ♡ your comments and support are my life blood :3 (even if i've fallen way behind on replying to them aaaaa)

Come hang out with me on twitter!! (18+only please and thank you)~

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Her laugh was the most infectious thing Catra had ever heard.

It was no surprise that her ears perked up the second she got even the sparest hint of it through her open window, and Catra bit down the blush that burned under her skin. She absolutely could not get distracted today. Razz had made a rather large request, and she needed to make sure that there was still enough supply left for the market this weekend. She had orders to place and inventory to track and invoices to write up, and she had been doing more goofing off with Adora in the last two weeks than was really acceptable.

But the giggling grew louder, and Catra could hear Adora's footsteps running across the dirt and up the porch until she finally swung through the kitchen door.

A very sweaty, dirt covered, and fucking *delicious* looking Adora - overalls smeared with soil and hair tied up in a knot on top of her head - slid into the kitchen, her heavy boots leaving dirt tracks on Catra's clean floor.

(She cared for about half a second before Adora's bright smile and snorting laughter distracted her again.)

"Hey ," Adora snickered, her hands clasped behind her back. "Wanna see this really hot chick?"

Catra's brows furrowed together as she tried to run over past conversations in her head. They definitely were not at a point where they were showing one another dating prospects - in fact Catra had *kind of thought* -

“Look at her!” Adora sang, moving her hands in front of her chest to unclasp them and reveal a baby chick. “She got into the cab of the tractor. I think she liked how warm it was with the sun.”

A *hot chick*. Okay. Got it.


WANNA SEE THIS REALLY HOT CHICK?
LOOK AT HER! SHE GOT INTO THE CAB OF THE TRACTOR. I THINK SHE LIKED HOW WARM IT WAS WITH THE SUN.
TRICKYPINETREE

art by [trickypinetree]

Catra rolled her eyes and stood to approach Adora and take the little chick from her hands. She was definitely warm, and Catra always loved how soft they were in her palms. She stroked one finger down the back of the chick, and asked "did any others get out?"

"No way . Defin..itely"…

Adora's eyes shot wide open and she sprinted out the door again, leaving Catra in the dust as she hollered out a repetition of "oh no oh no oh no."

Oh *no.*

Catra followed, albeit at a much more leisurely pace, only to find Adora with an armful of baby chickens, waddling around the yard, trying to urge them back into the temporary pen that surrounded their small coop with gentle pushes of her feet.

"Go on, get in there"…

Catra looked down to see a flattened piece of netting, and cocked her head to the side. "Did you break the fence?"she asked, letting out a laugh as Adora whipped around to face her, sheepishly grinning before setting the ones in her arms back in the fenced area. "Also you should probably fix it before they --"A handful of them darted right towards the opening again, and Catra gently placed the bird in her hand back down onto the ground. "That."

Adora smacked at her forehead with a palm and stepped mindfully over the still-standing fence. "Okay , okay, what *happened* was I was going to feed them and I heard that one chirping from the tractor. So I darted over here to put down the food so I had the hands to help, right?"

Placing her hands on her hips to watch with a smile tugging at her lips, Catra nodded. "Of course, makes sense."Adora was scrambling

to grab as many as she could while still being gentle enough not to hurt any of them.

"Okay so I might have tripped on the fence and like. Taken it down. Maybe."

"And you left it?"

"... I might have forgotten."Adora stepped back into the pen, placed the chicks in her arms down, and then immediately moved to the knocked down section of netting to adjust it to a standing position again. "There was a baby in a tractor! I had to help her ."

Catra barked a laugh and shook her head, continuing to watch the struggle. "Right, and then you just had to show her to me, instead of fixing the fence."

"Yes. See? You get it."Adora picked up a few more, shrugging nonchalantly and setting them down over the low barrier.

"You're such an idiot,"Catra sighed, pushing her hair off of her face. "I assume you can handle this?"

"Sure, sure,"Adora said, flashing Catra a wide smile before she turned to head back to the house. She was grunting and talking to herself as Catra walked away, but then she heard a yelp and a sound of distress.

"Hey , uh, real quick - different but semi-related concern - I think we need a higher fence."

Catra whipped back around just in time to see a few of the little chicks hopping up and flapping their wings just enough to get them over the top of the netting. "When did they get their flight feathers?" Her voice was just teetering on frantic. This wasn't really on her agenda for the day.

After a half-hearted shrug and some mumbled noise that indicated Adora hadn't known, Catra came back over towards the pen and scooped a few of them up. "All right, let's get them into the coop and then we can run down to Octavia's and get some more netting and taller - *shit* ."

Adora laughed and stumbled slightly before tapping the little bottoms of the babies and shutting the coop behind each one. "Doesn't Octavia hate you?"

"No," Catra hissed, before frowning. "Okay , *yes* , so I usually just make phone orders and have Kyle or someone drop it off. But"… Catra kneeled down to push more of the chicks into the enclosure and sighed, looking up at Adora. "Okay , *you* go, I'll finish gathering them."

"You sure?" Adora asked, brushing off the knees of her overalls. "I've been told I'm really good at picking up chicks."

Catra felt a grimace stretch across her mouth as she tried to hold back the absolute hatred of *two* chick puns in the span of ten minutes. "If you don't leave right now , I will scratch *your* eye out next."

With a dumb little snicker and a salute, Adora scampered off towards her truck and it took hardly a minute before she was out of sight.

--

If gathering up about fifty small chickens and building a temporary pen hadn't been frustrating enough, Catra had only realized about four hours later - while she sitting on the high fence of the yard and chatting with Adora as she harvested some of the ripe fruits and vegetables for the market - that she had completely abandoned all the paperwork she had to do.

It wasn't *her* fault that watching Adora was a treat in and of itself - and it for sure wasn't her fault that Adora kept taking breaks to lean

up against the fence next to her, and smile like *that* while she made eight hundred flirty remarks that had Catra playfully shoving her away - and there was no way on God's green earth that it was *her* fault that Adora decided to feed her the ripest berry off of each bush to *check if they were ready* .

So now here she was at nine pm, finally wrapping up everything she had needed to finish today.

Adora had stayed a little late and, after taking a much needed shower, offered to get them dinner while Catra took one of her own. She had picked up from Raż s, as usual, and they had laughed over their meals, and Adora left shortly after. It seemed like most days Adora only went home to sleep, and Catra found that she hadn't minded it all that much.

Something… *familiar* had been blooming between them again ever since their chat at the creek. Sure, they had pretty quickly settled back into friendship in the beginning, but Catra had maybe been starting to let herself hope for something more. Was it even possible for this to work? Did Adora want it? Did *she* want it?

Either way, a heavy weight had lifted off her shoulders that day, and she thought Adora might have felt it, too.

Rolling her neck and stretching her arms over her head, Catra moved to get ready for bed - that was, until she glanced out of her window and noticed that Adora's truck was still parked in the driveway, and Adora was laying in the bed of it.

What the hell?..

Catra moved swiftly down the stairs and out onto the dirt drive, the soft music playing from Adora's phone reaching her ears.

"Hey , Adora," she said, knocking lightly on the side of her truck, smiling as Adora's eyes snapped open and she jolted up into a sitting position. "What are you still doing here?"

She blew out a relieved breath before laying back and patting the spot next to her, metal covered by a plush blanket. "I was going to leave but then I noticed how clear the sky was."Adora reached over to shut off the music playing by her head and offered Catra a crooked grin. "Wanted to look at the stars for a bit, I guess."

Catra let out a laugh as she stuck one bare foot in the wheel well before hauling herself over the side of the truck. "You're a dork."The truck bounced with the weight of her, and Adora moved the singular pillow over for Catra, laying her own head back against the blanket.

Self-sacrificial asshole.

"Yes, I thought we established that when we were like, twelve,"she said as she tucked her arms up under her head. "When I learned all the names of all the constellations and all the facts of every type of star."

Catra settled down, fluffing the pillow under her head. "Yes, and I was tired of hearing it so I just started making up names instead." She scooted a little closer, sliding the pillow towards Adora. "We can share, if you want."

With a little hesitation, Adora nodded and moved her body closer, resting her head beside Catra's as their bare shoulders pressed together. "Thanks. I probably have another one in the cab but getting up sounded terrible."

"Fair ,"Catra laughed, pulling away slightly when the turn of her head bumped into Adora's. She couldn't help the goosebumps that rose wherever their skin touched - the warmth radiating from the curve of Adora's shoulder, the electricity stinging from her elbow, all the way to the soft fluttering of fingers against the back of her hand.

Adora lifted her outside arm up to point, turning her head closer against Catra's, and whispering as their foreheads came together. "Look, do you remember that one?"

The heat burning in her cheeks was *embarrassing* , but at least Adora wasn't looking at her. "Which one?"

"The." Adora scooted closer still, trying to line up her pointing finger with Catra's line of sight. "That one, it looks kind of... like it's blinking, almost?"

Catra couldn't stop her eyes from turning towards Adora and the sharp line of her nose before she snapped her attention back to the sky. "Yeah. I see it."

"Etheria." Adora hummed, spreading her fingers wide in a sort of presenting gesture. "That's what you called that one." Then she pointed to another. "And... Eternia."…

Biting her lip, Catra pressed the back of her hand firm against Adora's, and couldn't help the smile that stretched across her cheeks as Adora pressed back, hooking their index fingers together. "Oh," Catra hummed. "I think I remember calling one... hmmm." She tapped her fingers against her chin. "Krypton?"

Adora laughed and shook her head, pointing again. "It was Krytis. I don't know where you came up with these names." A heartier snort escaped her nose and Catra found herself slightly startled as she whipped her head to the side to look at Adora, flush deepening when she found that they were practically nose to nose. "You said there was a magical creature named Melog who lived on Krytis. Do you remember?"

"Oh my god, how do you remember this?"

"You wrote a story about them!"

Catra felt a soft giggle bubble from her chest. "Yeah, yeah. They were this magical creature who could shapeshift, and some evil all powerful overlord sucked all the magic from their planet... And they were the only survivor."…

"And then you -- sorry , Catarina, *the princess of the Magicats* -- found the wasted planet and rescued them." Adora laughed again, then, throwing her head back. "Oh my god, *you* were a big dork too!"

"Shut up!" Catra shoved at Adora's cheek, pushing her away from her cherry red face. "You're the dork."

Adora wrapped her fingers fully around Catra's, then, completely distracting her from the conversation. "Yes, that's been well established for years. We're focusing on the fact that you're one, too." She squeezed against Catra's palm, and their eyes met across the pillow. "Can't believe I didn't figure it out back then."…

Catra's eyes darted down to where Adora's tongue wet her bottom lip, before lifting slowly to meet her stare again. She could kiss her so easily, now. She *wanted* to…but. "So, brainiac," Catra started, turning her head back to look up at the sky. "What are those stars' actual names, huh?"

Clearing her throat, Adora started pointing again, the thumb on their interlaced hands running up and down Catra's own. "So. Etheria… that's Sirius. The brightest star in the sky." Her hand shifted. "Eternia…that's Betelgeuse - yes, like the movie."

They laughed together and said, in unison and in a terrible mimicry of the movie, *it's showtime* , before Adora shoved against Catra's shoulder again.

"And then…Kytis. That's Canopus. Sirius is the only star brighter than that one."

Catra placed her free hand on her bare stomach, yawning a soft "mine are better ," before turning her head to face Adora again, who had already been looking in her direction with a smile on her face. "I can't believe you remember all this stuff."

Shrugging, Adora turned her body a little towards Catra, and dropped her gaze. "... I remember everything." She paused, and

before Catra could refute that just based on the events of today, Adora's cheeks burned pink and she continued. "About you"…

.Oh.

Catra swallowed, turned to her side, and squeezed Adora's fingers between her own. "No wonder you don't have room for anything else up there," she teased, smile dropping as Adora's eyebrows knit together before she turned fully to her side as well.

"Catra." Her hand rose to cup the side of Catra's neck, thumb stroking down the curve of her jaw.

Oh.

"I've… never stopped thinking about you. Do you know that?"

Catra's hands moved on their own, one rising to circle the wrist at her neck, the other letting go of their intertwined fingers to slide behind Adora's head, twisting through soft locks. "... No." Her eyes closed as Adora's now free hand wove itself between her hair and the pillow, cupping the back of her skull so, *so* gently.

Adora came closer, her words a gentle whisper. "I've always wondered… if… you'd give me another chance." The fingers at Catra's neck slid to her jaw. "If you'd… let me kiss you again."

She would. Fuck, she *would*.


feistypaaants @ twitter

art by me

"How you'd react if"…

Catra opened her eyes again, taking in Adora's steel blue ones before dropping down to her plush lips, pink and highlighted by the moonshine. Adora's thumb pulled gently on Catra's bottom lip as the hand at the back of her head urged them closer together.

"If I told you that I think I'm still in lov--"

Catra slapped a hand across Adora's mouth, shaken from her bliss.

"No."

"... What?" Adora mumbled, words muffled by the palm over her mouth.

Eyes wide and panicked, Catra finally met Adora's gaze. "No. You can't say that." Confusion was etched in Adora's features as Catra pulled away so fast it was as if she had been burned. "You can't *say* that." She was throwing both legs over the side of the bed before Adora could even get up.

"Catra?"

Her shoulders were tense as her feet hit the ground and she turned back to face Adora, frowning and worried.

"If you don't *know*, you can't say it." Catra's jaw clenched, stress bubbling up from her stomach and popping in her ears. She felt woozy, and like she only had enough left in her to make it inside. "Do you get it?"

Adora looked as if she wanted to protest - to tell Catra *of course I know* - but her shoulders dropped, and instead she settled for "I get it."

"Okay . God." She crossed one arm across her chest, hugging the other close. "Then. Goodnight, Adora." Turning to head back to the house, she steadfastly ignored whatever Adora said after her.

Catra closed the kitchen door, took a deep breath, and listened for the rumbling of the truck to disappear down the main road.

Chapter End Notes

> oops. hello :3 how ya doin? sorry for taking 2 months. time is fake and i don't understand it. I hope this chapter..... made.... up for it.....? maybe. c:
>
> Thanks everyone for reading as always ♡ comments literally make my day and I promise I'm working through replying to all of them aaaaaa
>
> Come hang out with me on twitter!! (18+ only please and thank you)
>
> (there will be some art i made for this chapter there soon hehehe)

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was shaking the whole booth with how wildly her knee was bouncing underneath the table. Every fucking jngle of the bell above the door of Raz s had her jumping out of her seat. She chose a different table than normal and kept her back to the door, hoping that if *she* came in, she would be oblivious enough to not notice her.

"Hey , Wildcat!"A voice boomed across the diner , and Catra clenched at her mug of coffee tighter. "Y ou look tense,"Scorpia tried as she rounded the corner, patting reassurance against her shoulder. "Have you been sleeping okay?"

No she hadn't fucking been sleeping okay.

Things had been weird ever since Adora.since *they* almost…

"I'm fine,"Catra grumbled, tugging the table closer to her slender frame to make more room for Scorpia on the other side. "Just lots of work this week. You know. Razand her produce orders."

Scorpia slid onto the vinyl seat, her butt squeaking along the fabric as her cheeks flushed pink. "Oh, yeah, yeah. Makes sense."She tapped her claws against the table, blowing out a low whistle as she looked anywhere but at Catra's clearly exhausted face.

"Sorry ,"Catra started, rolling her shoulders down to sit up straighter . "For not really being around lately . I've been.distracted."

Blowing out a scoff of dismissal, Scorpia shook her head. "Look, I get it. Long lost childhood love of your life comes rolling back into town --"

"Scorpia"…

"Of *course* you're going to be distracted! I *get* it." She barely needed to breathe once she got started. "It's like, when Perfuma and I got together? Oh boy! You wouldn't have been able to get in touch with me for *weeks*!"

Catra pressed two fingers against the ridge between her brows. "Scorpia, that was like right after Adora and I broke up, and you were with me almost every day."

"... Right, yeah. Okay so. Bad example."

The waitress came by with a glass of water and a steaming mug of coffee for scorpia, giggling profusely as Scorpia offered her a glittering smile in thanks. Catra was never surprised when people fell over themselves crushing on Scorpia. In fact, if not for Perfuma…

Catra groaned and rolled her neck, pushing those thoughts *way* out. It wouldn't have been healthy, anyway. It would have been a shitty rebound and it would have ruined their friendship. Scorpia was undoubtedly attractive, but that would have been a disaster, and Catra's glad they never had the opportunity to even explore that.

"I just." Okay, maybe she had wanted to talk about Adora, but now she felt too bad. She had to at least make an *effort* before bringing up her own problems. "How have you been? Wedding planning almost done?"

The way Scorpia's face lit up made up for the headache Catra knew she was going to have later.

"Oh, oh it's going *so* good, Wildcat! Perfuma's doing all the flowers herself because she's amazing, you know." She pushed hair off her face and pulled a notebook out of her bag, flipping through insane diagrams that Catra wouldn't have been able to decipher if she tried. "Right so we just had our last tasting with the caterer - you're going

to *love* the options - and the baker finalized the design for the cake! And then Lonnie - you remember Lonnie?"

Yes, of course she remembered Lonnie.

"She's going to be bartending! Open bar, your favorite," Scorpia finished with a nudge across the table and a laugh. "I know it's like short notice but do you think I should invite Adora?"

Ah. Fuck.

Catra couldn't help the way she tensed again and the hair on the back of her neck stood up. "Oh. Uh"…

"Or is she gonna be your plus one or?"…

Her face was burning and she rubbed a fisted hand against her cheeks. "Uh, I don't know." She could get off this topic. She could keep it on Scorpia. "I think -"

"… Are you guys… Are things okay? Last we talked you said like, you thought things were going well." Catra noticed the waitress coming back and was never more grateful for Scorpia's ability to get serious when needed, as she gestured for the server to come back later. "Did something happen?"

Catra could feel her fingers tightening around the mug, sharp nails starting to chip the ceramic. "We… Ugh," dropped her head before peering up at her best friend. "I really didn't want this to be all about me. Are you sure?"

Nodding, Scorpia reached across the table to pat her arm. "Always, Catra."

"Okay. So," Catra began, coughing once to clear her throat and shrugged. "We almost kissed, I think?"

"*What*?!"

"It was three nights ago. She was all sweet and romantic and I got caught up in it." Scorpia had her claws up to her chin in excited disbelief, and Catra felt a low growl in her throat. "But then she ruined it, with her stupid talking."

"... What? What did she say?"

Catra could see a protective sheen of anger start slipping over Scorpia's features, and she started to feel bad. Adora didn't deserve *that* wrath.

"She," Catra lowered her voice, frowning deeper . "... Told me she thought she was still in love with me."

A smile almost cracked through Scorpia's facade, and she tucked her tongue into her cheek, thinking over her words for a moment. "She told you she loved you and that ruined it?"

Taking a deep breath and laying a palm against the table, Catra felt her throat tighten. "She said. She *thinks* . She doesn't *know* ."

"Oh, yeah, okay , that changes things," Scorpia said with a small smirk pulling at her lips.

Catra knew Scorpia wasn't mocking her - the girl didn't have a mean bone in her body - but Catra felt the shame run up through her chest regardless as she curled her claws into the tabletop. "Look, she… She broke my heart, okay? And I want… *something* to happen … I think"…

"You *think…* "

" *I'm* allowed to be unsure!"

"Right, sorry ."

She groaned and rubbed a hand against the back of her neck. "Look, she's the one who left, who got a whole life without me, who and yeah, we talked about it, kind of, but it also feels like there will

always be this kind of unresolved..something..and she just"…
Catra heaved a sigh and raised a hand to prop her chin up. "I don't want her to say that unless she's positive. I don't"…

"Y ou don't want to get hurt again."Scorpia shrugged and tapped at the table. "It makes sense, really ."

"Y eah."Catra took in a deep breath and sighed, making eye contact with the timid server who wasn't sure if she could come back yet or not. "... Y eah."She sat up straighter and waved the girl over before turning back to Scorpia. "But now she' s been avoiding me and ignoring me"T.hey paused briefly to make an order before Catra continued. "I just.I stopped her from kissing me and told her she needed to know before she could say that, right? She said she got it, so I think maybe she realized that she *didn't* mean it."

Scorpia took a sip of her water, before shrugging. "Or she is just trying to give you some space since you rejected her"…

With a scoff, Catra rolled her eyes. "Adora doesn't give anyone space, ever. She pesters you until you tell her what's wrong. Besides, I didn't *reject* her --"

"Also, is she *ignoring* you, really?"

" *Yes* . She just. Comes to work and brings me a coffee and then does her thing, and now she eats lunch in the tractor, and then comes in at the end of the day to say goodbye and that's *it* ."Scorpia was making a weird face, which Catra thought meant she didn't believe that this was something abnormal. "Listen, she used to come over early, and we'd eat breakfast together."Her voice was maybe getting louder as she spoke. "And then she -"

Scorpia made some strange noise that had Catra raising an eyebrow. "Right... She would work, and then we'd make lunch *together* and talk for a bit and then like she'd -"

"Catra, I-"

“- go back to work and then we’d have dinner , and watch a show or something, and then she’d -”

“ *Catra* ,”Scorpia hissed, lifting her arms up to signal for her to shut the hell up.

“What?”

“She just came in so -”

Catra whipped around so quickly that she felt a crack in her neck. Shit, shit. Of course she would. Why not? Adora literally didn’t do anything but work, and on her days off she had been coming to the homestead anyway. Of *course* since she’s avoiding her right now, she’d be at Razz s.

Fuck.

They met eyes briefly before Adora looked away and headed to a corner booth on the opposite side of the diner, immediately pulling out her phone to, Catra could guess, play one of her stupid puzzle games. So she was *definitely* avoiding her, then.

“Okay , that seemed cold. I’ll admit it,”Scorpia sighed, twisting her mouth in thought.

Catra dropped her head against the table, sighing. “I told you.”She wanted to fuse with the sticky surface and forget all of her troubles. Just become one with the comfort of the diner and --

“Awww, what’s the matter?”Catra’s shoulders rose to her ears when she heard the familiar voice of Netossa hovering over her. “Why so blue, kitty cat?”God damn it. She was *not* in the mood for this antagonizing.

Netossa forced her way into the booth, sliding Catra along the cheap vinyl with her hips, completely ignoring Catra’s noises of protest.

"Lover's quarrel," Scorpia lamented, sliding over to make room for Spinerella on the opposite side of the booth.

"Scorpia." Catra's voice was low growl, and she sat up slowly and tucked her head into her shoulders. "It's not a fucking --"

Spinerella sat up higher, a soft smile on her lips. "Oh, did you and Adora finally get back together?"

"No."

"Then how's it a lover's quarrel?"

"It's *not*."

"They almost kissed."

"Scorpia!"

"Oh!"

"Then Adora said she might still be in l--"

Catra practically leapt across the table to throw a hand across her friend's mouth, grimacing when Scorpia giggled beneath her palm. "What did we say about boundaries? I feel like you telling everyone my business is *crossing* them."

Scorpia lifted her hands in surrender and shrugged as Catra slowly let herself fall back into the booth. The pity in Spinnerella's eyes was mortifying, and Netossa was slowly draping her arm over the back of the chair when Catra could feel steel blue eyes boring into the side of her head.

She resisted the urge to look.

"Funnily enough," Netossa said, knocking her head against Catra's. "Adora is exactly who we're here to meet. Want us to talk to her? See what's up?"

"Absolutely not," Catra growled, low and threatening, before Netossa's hand clapped down hard on her shoulder.

With a frown, Scorpia reached across the table to touch gently at Catra's hand. "You know, you can tell them what's going on. You once said they were like sisters to you"…

The satisfied laugh from Netossa made Catra tense, her shoulders drawing up to her ears and her tail flicking wildly against the seat. "Scorpia. I told you to *never* repeat those words," Catra said, pausing only when Netossa's fingers pinched at her cheeks. "Great, you see what you've done?"

"Like a *sister*? Aw, baby," Netossa cooed, clasping her hands on both of Catra's cheeks. "You're like the little bratty sister I never wanted but had anyway."

Spinerella was giggling behind her hand when she jumped as her phone vibrated against the table. She paused to check it, and frowned before glancing towards where Adora was sitting. "Darling, I think we should." She trailed off with a nod of her head towards the other side of the restaurant.

Risking a glance, Catra couldn't help but feel a *little* bad. Adora was hunched over her phone, brows knitted and knee bouncing erratically as she was obviously trying incredibly hard not to look back their way. It would feel pretty shitty to see the people you were there to meet fawning all over the person you were trying to avoid.

"Go," Catra nodded. "I'm fine."

And, as they stood up, the vinyl squeaking beneath them, she added a curt "do *not* mention this to Adora."

Netossa scoffed as Catra's eyes followed Spinerella to the other booth, worry clear on Adora's face as she looked up, her shoulders still raised with tension. "Don't you worry, kitten, I won't say a word.

But I do hope the two of you will sort it out, and sooner rather than later. She's"…

Catra's eyes snapped up to meet Netossa's, narrowed in concentration. "She' s happy to be here, I think? But..for pretty specific reasons."Before Catra could fully comprehend what she had said, Netossa was gone, sliding in across the way from Adora as the waitress came over to greet them.

"Huh,"Scorpia sighed, scratching at the back of her head. "That was kinda cryptic."

Chewing on her thumbnail, Catra risked one more glance over towards Adora, catching her gaze for only a moment before she turned away.

"... Y eah."

The rain had come out of nowhere.

There had been blue skies and warm, soft breezes until a single deafening crack of thunder shook the whole house and suddenly her property was flooding.

Catra had dove to the porch as quickly as she could, grasping onto the railing and trying desperately to see through the near white-out conditions. "Adora!"she had called once, voice drowned out by the pounding rain, to no response. "Adora?"

After another few minutes passed with no sign of Adora or of the rain letting up, Catra took in a deep breath. Even thought she *knew* full well that Adora was probably *perfectly fine* , Catra gripped firmly onto the railing, readied herself to leap, and prepared to run back out into the *horrible and nightmarishly wet* -

Suddenly a mop of blonde hair came stumbling onto the cover of the porch, and Catra froze, startled. "Phew!" Adora laughed, leaning forward to brace her palms on her knees as she caught her breath. "That was a surprise, huh?" She stood up straighter, pushed her hair off of her face, and looked at Catra's stance, before smirking. "Whatcha doin'?"

Catra looked at her feet, and then back up at Adora before stepping down from the railing. "What? Nothing."

There was something so fucking smug in the way Adora said "were you looking for me?"

"No," she said, too quickly to be true. At Adora's cocked brow, she crossed her arms over her chest. "Well, you should answer when I call for you."

Adora leaned against the railing, her smirk only growing. "Were you.worried about me?"

Catra scoffed a laugh and started walking towards the door. "Please. Get over yourself."

"Aww," Adora cooed, following closely behind. "You *were*, weren't you?" she teased, before Catra stopped her at the doorway with a hand on her chest.

With a cocked brow and a pout full of false confusion, Catra hummed, thoughtful. "You're soaked. Do you think you're coming into my house like that?" Her varicolored eyes scanned down the length of Adora's overalls, stopping critically on the water dripping off the hemmed ankles. "Absolutely not."

"Oh come on, Catra!"

"Sorry, Adora, I don't make the rules." Then, she grinned. "Oh wait, I *do*."

The rain was already starting to calm down, and she couldn't help but feel a *little* bad as Adora pouted and wrung out the ends of her long hair. "Just hang on, I'll get you…multiple towels." She moved towards the linen closet, shrugging. "You can be done early if you'd like, get heading home?"

"Uh, yeah, about that." Adora's voice rose, as if it were a question.

Catra scrunched up her nose before holding three towels to her chest and heading back towards the door, to see Adora frowning towards the direction of her truck. Peeking around the door, Catra quickly noticed the problem, too.

The heavy rain had turned her completely dirt driveway into mud.

"Shit."

"I'll try to get it out but I'm not holding on to much hope. I haven't gotten better tires yet…it's still my." Adora chuckled and pressed a nervous palm to the back of her neck. "Very old ones."

"Adora"…

"I know!"

Catra sighed, pressing the pads of her fingers against her temple. "You take such good care of that truck but didn't think to change the tires?"

The rain had stopped and Adora was digging in her pockets for her keys. "I'll go see what happens." She held out a hand for the towels and grimaced before hopping down the stairs into the first puddle of mud. "Oh, jeez."

Catra watched with zero confidence as Adora sank into the drive with every step, struggled slightly to hop into her truck without getting dirt everywhere, and started up the engine. One press of the gas pedal, and another, and all that was accomplished was thick mud

splattering all over the bottom of the gray truck. The engine turned off, and Adora strolled back towards the porch, a smile plastered on her face.

"So, bad news."

"Your truck is stuck?"

"My truck is definitely stuck."

Rolling her eyes, Catra groaned and dragged her hands down her face. "Fine, you can stay here tonight." She pushed her curls away from her forehead as Adora sheepishly started walking towards the open door. "Do you need a change of clothes?"

Adora shook her head quickly before wordlessly waddling back over to her truck and pulling out what Catra could only assume was her gym bag, probably containing multiple pairs of shorts. "All set!" she sang as she made her way back to the porch yet again.

This was a bad idea, wasn't it?

Catra sighed and scanned her eyes along Adora's height again. "Shoes stay out here."

Dropping her bag onto a chair, Adora grunted with a little effort as she pulled the filthy boots from her feet, the wet socks following.

Then, when Catra noticed all the mud caked onto the bottoms of her overalls, she sighed.

"Regrettably , the *pants* as well."

Adora snorted before unclasping the buttons at her chest, shoving the denim down over her hips, and kicking her feet out of the legs. Catra's eyes caught on the tight curve of crisp white boxer briefs over muscular thighs and groaned.

I can lose the shirt too, if you want.” Catra didn’t even need to look up to see the smirk on Adora’s mouth.

She spun on her heel, cheeks burning, and hissed “just get inside.”

This was a *terrible* idea.

Chapter End Notes

hiya pals! is it even worth me apologizing for the wait? writing is hard :)

but thank y'all for sticking around!! <3

You may have noticed that I dropped the rating from M to T!! I've decided that smut just doesn't fit into the main story , so if i do write some it'll be published separately!

Anyway, thank you as always for reading, and comments make my whole day!

Come hang out with me on twitter!! (18+ only please and thank you)

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra tossed the frozen lasagna into the oven with much more force than was necessary, almost knocking the rack off of its resting place. She muttered a curse and listened to make sure the shower was still running before slamming the door of the oven shut and starting up a timer. She leaned up against the counter and blew out a heavy sigh before shoving her fingers through her knotted curls.

Okay. Adora was spending the night. This was *totally fine* and definitely not going to be weird. If they just ignored the fact that the last time they had actually had meaningful interaction Adora had tried to kiss her and Catra had stopped her, and that they haven't spoken much since. This was going to be *fine*.

They were going to have to talk, probably. Catra didn't think that they could avoid it. She wasn't really sure she *wanted* to avoid it, anyway.

The shower stopped, and Catra rolled her neck. Well, she could at least put it off for a little bit.

A few minutes passed before Catra heard the bathroom door open, the jingle of a spritely little whistled tune, and then the heavy footsteps of Adora skipping down the stairs. She couldn't help the smile that tugged at her lips as she looked up to catch Adora - towel wrapped around her neck and still damp hair like a wild nest atop her head - squat down to reach into her bag for a hairbrush.

Catra forced a neutral expression back on her face as Adora looked up at her and grinned.

"You finished?" she asked, voice falsely hinting at annoyance.

"Y up, all yours," Adora groaned as she pushed back to a standing position. "I am of ficially mud-free."

Catra had pushed off the counter to check the timer - still about an hour - and hadn't noticed just how close Adora had come. Catra jumped, startled by their new proximity , and lifted her eyes to meet Adora's gaze.

"Whatcha making?" Her question was so innocent, so fucking earnest, that Catra was sure that Adora had no intention of crossing *any* boundary - she was simply being Adora.

Rolling her eyes, Catra offered a curt, "lasagna," before side-stepping out of Adora's reach. "It'll take a bit to cook. Are you okay if I go upstairs?" Adora nodded with a hum of af firmation and reached up into a cabinet to get herself a glass. Catra could feel her heart picking up speed at the goddamn familiarity that she didn't think would ever leave, then wrapped her arms across her chest. "Great. Make yourself at home."

As Catra moved towards the stairs, she could feel Adora's eyes burning into the back of her skull. She took the steps two at a time, desperately needing to escape that gaze.

Wincing as she accidentally slammed the door shut, Catra took a deep breath and started the shower, turning the heat up as far as she could physically stand. She needed to calm down, and she needed to do it *now* . She stripped out of her sweat-damp clothing, hissed as she stepped into the scalding water, and worked quickly at the curls sticking to her back.

All in all, it only took her ten minutes to actually shower and change, but Catra sat without shame on top of the counter for an extra twenty, mindlessly scrolling through her phone. She knew that there was no way they would get through this whole night without the incident coming up, but the rock that formed in her stomach urged her to put it off as long as possible.

She heard her name hollered up the stairs, and her ears perked up.

"Catra? I was thinking of making a salad or something." There was a short pause, a tiny moment of hesitation as if Adora were wondering if this was all right, before she added "I mean, if that's okay with you? If you want?"

Catra hopped off the counter and sighed, pushing her sopping wet hair back over her shoulders. She could hear Adora start to ramble, anxiety clearly creeping up the longer Catra didn't reply.

"If not that's okay too, I just thought it might go well with the pasta… but I'm not here to like, use all of your food I just "—

"Adora," Catra started as she appeared at the top of the steps, making Adora jump slightly as she came into view. "That sounds great."

"Okay!" She clapped her hands together with a smile before it turned sheepish. "As long as you're sure."

A cocked eyebrow from Catra was all it took for Adora to chuckle and spin on her heel back towards the kitchen. "Right, yup. One salad, coming right up."

Not caring about how it would dry, Catra tossed her wet hair up into a messy bun before making her way down the stairs, pausing for just a moment at the bottom, her breath catching in her throat.

The sight before her was… literally breathtaking. It was something she had wanted all of her life, and here it was - *real,* and… Painful.

Adora was humming softly as she moved around the kitchen, a dish towel slung over her shoulder and an assortment of vegetables held firm in her arms. She dropped them onto the counter and began chopping - and Catra could almost see the smile on her face through the way Adora's head was bobbing back and forth as if in time with music only she could hear.

In her dreams, Catra would have walked up behind Adora, slung arms around her waist and pressed a kiss against her neck, blissful in their domesticity. A gentle life, full of love, earned despite - and *in* spite of - the challenges they had faced both separately and together.

In reality, she sat down at the kitchen table and crossed her legs, pretending she didn't want any of that.

The table had already been set, and Catra twirled a knife on its point, waiting patiently for the rest to be finished. With a smile and an offering of a beer, Adora set the lasagna and the salad in between their plates, serving up a hefty portion to herself before handing the spatula over to Catra.

Adora tried to talk through dinner.

Catra felt her whole body tense.

—

Adora had been kind enough to offer to clean up, and Catra had moved to the living room, putting some useless noise on the television to try and keep herself distracted. She knew her eyes had glazed over and she hadn't retained a second of what had happened, so when Adora plopped down on the couch beside her and asked "what are we watching?", all Catra could offer was a shrug and a mumbled "some soap opera, I think."

"Cool," Adora started, shifting and settling deeper into the plush couch. "I love soap operas."

"No you don't."

Adora let out an uncomfortable chuckle before propping up one foot on her opposite knee. "Sure I do!" Then Catra cocked an eyebrow in her direction, and Adora simply scoffed. "Okay fine, but you don't either."

"I wasn't really watching," Catra admitted, before lowering the volume and taking a deep breath.

She ignored the worried furrow of Adora's brows.

"Well, we can watch something else." Adora pulled out her phone to start flipping through a channel guide, and hummed. "Oh, that one criminal show you like is on - with the behavior psychology stuff? Or. Looks like there's a documentary about sharks or space… sharks...in space? No, no. They're different. Or if you "—

"Why have you been ignoring me?" Catra cut in, placing one hand over her other, hoping to stop the tremors that had started. She kept her eyes closed, as if she couldn't feel those steel blue eyes burning into her skin. "Things have felt weird ever since"…

The tremble reached her voice, and she swallowed against it.

"It's. It's okay if you realized you didn't mean what you almost said, but I...thought we were becoming friends again." She took a deep breath, and risked opening her eyes, turning to face Adora. "So you not talking to me as much has...sucked. Like, a lot."

Catra could see guilt all over Adora's face, and she *almost* regretted this.

"I." Adora started, clenching and unclenching her fists as if she were physically trying to find the words she wanted to say. "I thought you wanted space?"

She simply blinked in disbelief. "Why would I want space?"

"Well I thought - I *know* that I overstepped - and I just thought...you wanted some space from me." Adora looked small, avoiding Catra's questioning gaze. "You always used to want space when you were upset...I thought that's what you meant when you asked if I got it?"

"It wasn't," Catra sighed, her shoulders slumping. "I just didn't want you saying shit you weren't sure about."

Adora appeared to chance a look in Catra's direction, blowing out a heavy breath. "Oh." She picked at her fingernails as a single chuckle escaped her chest. "That makes more sense."

Dropping her head into her hands with a groan, Catra was completely unable to stifle the traitorous fucking laugh that bubbled up from the frustration. "Why are we still so bad at this? You'd think we would have figured out how to fucking communicate by now."

She felt Adora shift, and then felt the weight of her pressing closer to Catra's shoulder. "Beats me." Then, after a few minutes of silence, Adora said, "maybe we're still getting to know one another again. It *feels* comfortable, because it *is*. But you said it yourself, that first night." She bumped her hand against Catra's, both of their eyes locking onto the point of contact. "A lot about you has changed. Me, too."

Catra hated to admit it, but Adora wasn't wrong.

They sat like that for a while, the tips of their pinkies slowly interlocking as the television babbled on in the background. "You were right, you know," Adora offered as a way of starting the conversation up again.

"I usually am."

Adora laughed. Catra loved that laugh.

"I went too far, and I'm sorry. You just." Adora turned to actually face Catra, even if she couldn't yet meet her eyes. "You mean so much to me, and I got over excited about this."

Catra knew Adora had always been better at showing her feelings than talking about them, but the fact that she was *trying* was enough. Shifting her hand to cup into Adora's palm, she let Adora's fingers

interlace with her own. Her eyes glanced up quickly to Adora's face, lingering on the half smile on her lips.

"I *want* to try this again," Adora practically whispered, as if she were scared of the response. "I can say , with no hesitation, that I am positive about *that* ."

Catra's heart practically leapt into her throat, her fingers squeezing Adora's tighter.

The confidence in Adora's voice grew with each word. "And if you don't want to, I understand, I *do* . But being with you, it's it's being home."

home .

"I don't care whether it's as a couple or as friends, okay?"

Catra finally let their eyes meet, sure the disbelief was written all over her face.

"But I'm not letting go of you this time. Not having you in my life was too hard, Catra." Adora swallowed hard, and dropped her eyes back to the couch. "I don't want to do it again."

It was too much.

She threw herself at Adora, then, wrapping her arms around her neck and sighing with relief when firm hands embraced her back, running slowly down the length of her spine. Catra pressed her nose into the side of Adora's throat, sighing against the warmth of her skin.

Adora's grip tightened, and gentle fingers came to stroke at the nape of Catra's neck. The silence that fell over them was comfortable - familiar - and Catra couldn't hold in the rumbling purrs that burst from her chest.

"So." Adora tried, after a few minutes. "Is is that a yes, or?".

Catra couldn't help but laugh, squeezing tighter. "You're such an idiot."

"I know," Adora said, but she pulled back slightly, her hands dropping to Catra's hips, before pressing her forehead against Catra's. "Spell it out for me. So I don't make another stupid mistake."

Lifting her hands to cup at Adora's jaw, Catra smiled. "It's a yes, Adora." Then, a small stutter. "But... I want to take it kind of slow, okay? No grand declarations of love - not yet. I'm..." Her thumbs stroked over Adora's cheeks. "I'm not ready for that."

Adora nodded, audibly swallowing, her fingers pressing into the flesh of Catra's sides. "I can do slow. I'm happy to."

"Okay." Catra bit at her lower lip, fighting the smile. "Good."

—

In the end they had settled in to *actually* watch some television - Catra's head in Adora's lap, and Adora's thumb stroking over the back of Catra's hand - and hurt their sides from laughing at the sheer ridiculousness of the reality show that they had turned on. When it finally got late enough, they pulled out the couch and set it up for Adora to sleep, before saying a sort of awkward goodnight with a lingering hug before Catra retreated to her bedroom.

But now the squeaking of the pull out mattress was just loud enough to hear in the silent house, and Catra found herself staring at the dark ceiling, fingers twitching as she listened to Adora toss and turn.

Slow. Take it *slow*.

But…

Fuck.

Catra threw the blankets off to the side and sat up, rubbing her hands down her face. Maybe this was stupid, but they shared a bed

all the time before they started dating for the first time. It didn't mean anything, and she had the feeling Adora was just as restless as she was and she had *always* slept better next to someone.

She heaved a sigh.

Grabbing her favorite pillow, Catra moved swiftly down the steps, hardly making a noise. She saw the soft illumination of Adora's phone and the quiet sounds of some commentating - Catra could only assume it was soccer related - before she made it to the side of the bed, kicking her foot against the mattress.

Adora jumped, gasping and dropping her phone before twisting to look up at Catra.

"Move over." Catra threw the pillow onto the bed, slipping under the covers as Adora shimmied closer to the edge.

Whispering, Adora said "you okay?"

Catra moved quickly, laying a hand on Adora's shoulder to stop her from turning over, and pressed her cheek against Adora's back, arms snaking around her waist. "I'm fine, but I kept hearing you moving around and it was keeping me awake."

"Sorry," Adora mumbled, humor laced in her voice. "Couldn't sleep."

She picked up her phone to shut off the video she was watching, flipping quickly to her alarm. Catra honestly wasn't trying to snoop, but she couldn't stop curious eyes from looking at the message notifications that kept popping down.

Hope

[Adora,you need to answer me.]

Hope

[You can't keep ignoring me just because you're upset.]

"Hey, Adora." Catra's voice felt so small.

Fuck.

"Hmm?"

Catra lifted one hand to the screen of Adora's phone, pointer finger tugging on the notification. "Just for the sake of communicating… That's not a girlfriend, right?"

The laugh that burst from Adora's throat was both humiliating and relieving, and Catra pouted against the collar of Adora's shirt.

"Well it's a fair question."

Taking a deep breath, Adora sighed. "No, no you're right, sorry." She dropped the phone onto the mattress and traced her fingers along Catra's forearm. "Not a girlfriend, I promise. Also not an *ex*-girlfriend, in case that was a concern."

The soft drag of Adora's fingertips against Catra's skin was already lulling her to sleep. "Then who is she?"

Adora's hesitation made her ministrations pause as she took in a deep breath.

"My manager. But." She gave Catra's hand a squeeze, before snuggling back against her. "I'm not ready to talk about that yet, is that okay? I promise I'm not hiding anything, and you have nothing to worry about, and I'll tell you later, but -"

Catra yawned and buried her face deeper into Adora's back. "It's okay, really." And then - because she *really* did - "I trust you."

"Thank you."

Sleep was taking over her faster than she realized, and even the soft light of Adora's phone wasn't keeping her awake. Catra was warm, and comfortable, and *safe* for what felt like the first time in years. She felt her breathing slow and lacked the energy to consciously stop her tail from wrapping around Adora's thighs as she squeezed her arms just a little tighter around Adora' s waist.

"Good night," she heard, soft and far away .

Then silence.


fuzzypaws @ twitter

art by me

Chapter End Notes

And if I actually update in a decent time frame? What then????

I don’t know if this will happen again but I do hope this chapter is satisfying enough to hold y’all over if it takes me another month or more uu;

I’m also working on some art for this chapter because I couldn’t resist, and it’ll be over on my twitter once i finish it.... hopefully that doesn’t take me forever lmao :^)

Feel free to come hang out with me on twitter ! 18+ only please! ♥

As always your comments make my WHOLE DAY and I’m trying to get back to all the absolutely amazing comments y’all left on the last chapter asap!! ♥

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> Hey friends, I just want to make a note that while it's not detailed, we do talk a little more in depth about Mara's death in this chapter. Please just be aware of that before reading. I promise it's not detailed or in length, but it's there and I wanted to give a bit of a heads up!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The rumbling of her own chest was what woke her.

The first thing Catra was aware of was blunt nails scratching at the base of her neck, gently tugging at knotted curls. She was stiff, but content, while her soft purring grew louder - almost out of her control - as she nuzzled deeper into Adora's chest, both sets of arms squeezing tighter.

"Good morning," Adora mumbled, voice low and raspy as Catra struggled to open her eyes. "How'd you sleep?"

With only a grunt for a response, Catra lifted her head just enough to rest her chin against Adora's sternum and catch those steely blues looking down at her. She couldn't stop a dopey grin from stretching on her lips as she absorbed the overwhelming adoration that poured out of Adora's gaze.

Adora pressed her mouth against Catra's forehead - not quite a kiss, but comforting nonetheless - and Catra let out a happy sigh. "Really good, actually," she said, tracing her nails gently against Adora's throat. "Even if this shitty mattress is hard as a rock. You?"

"Also good," Adora said with a soft laugh, carding her fingers into Catra's hair. "I always slept better with you."

After a groan of false disgust, Catra whipped her body up in the blink of an eye to straddle Adora's hips, sleep shorts riding high on her thighs as a flush of red bloomed over Adora's cheeks. "You're so gross," Catra teased, bracing her palms against Adora's chest, fingers stroking in the dips of her collar bones. "Wanna go get breakfast?"

Catra tried to ignore the twitching of Adora's fingers by her knees, clearly unsure whether or not it was okay to touch her in such a casually intimate way yet. Leave it to Adora to worry about boundaries even as Catra's thighs are wrapped around her hips. To save them both some torment, Catra hopped off of the bed and stretched her arms over her head.

Blue eyes grew slightly darker as they lingered on Catra's exposed stomach, forcing a flush onto her cheeks. Well shit. This was a whole different kind of torture.

Adora blinked twice, then tore her eyes away.

"Yeah, sounds good," she sighed, shoulders slumping as she sat up. "I just gotta swing by Razz's to get a change of clothes."

They moved quickly to get ready - Catra running upstairs to change and grab Adora a spare toothbrush, Adora throwing the sheets into the laundry room and folding the couch back up - and, after making sure the chickens got fed, were out the door in a flurry.

Getting Adora's truck out took a little extra work, but the drive had solidified overnight so at least it wasn't *impossible*. Catra tried to convince Adora to let her drive herself so Adora wouldn't have to drive the twenty minutes back up and another twenty back afterwards, but she insisted that she didn't mind.

Catra teased that Adora had just wanted to spend more time with her.

With a snort and a "you're so full of yourself," as a response, Catra's joke was only confirmed.

They pulled up to Raz's home, and Catra couldn't help but smile. The house was old and small, but incredibly charming, with bright pink shutters and trim, and oddly shaped, curving rooftops. She remembered fondly sitting out on the rickety porch with Mara and Adora, staring up at the twinkling stars as they listened to Mara's stories of faraway planets and magical princesses before she tucked them both in for the night.

"C'mon," Adora smiled, killing the engine and hopping out of the truck. "It's been a while since you've been here, huh?"

Catra followed, simply nodding as they stepped up onto the porch, but looked down with surprise as it didn't creak underfoot. "Did Raz actually get some work done on the house? She was always so against anyone coming to fix it." Catra smirked, crossing her arms, and said "I remember that she always said it ruined the natural lifespan, and that everything had the right to age as it pleased."

A laugh and a blown noise of dismissal from Adora was the only clue Catra needed.

"Or.you've just been secretly working on it, haven't you?"

Rubbing a hand up against the back of her neck, Adora turned sheepish. "... Don't tell her , okay? I'm not convinced she doesn't actually think the house is alive."

Adora swung open the door as Catra laughed, grinning ear to ear.

"Since when are you a budding contractor?"

"Needed something to fill my free time." Adora shrugged, pushing on the doorframe and frowning as it bent slightly under the pressure.

"Have you ever tried relaxing?" Catra asked, moving towards the threshold.

And, with a snarky little pop of her lips, Adora said, "don't know the meaning of the word."

They stepped into the home and Catra was almost floored by the familiar scent. Her breath caught, and tears involuntarily sprung to the corners of her eyes as she took in her surroundings. The bright kitchen was just as she remembered - light woods and cheap beige countertops, big windows that lit up the whole room, and a fridge so covered in memories that you couldn't even see the white face of it anymore.

She felt gentle fingers tug at her own, and met Adora's warm smile with a sniffle she failed to hide.

"C'mere," Adora almost whispered, leading her to the fridge. "She wouldn't take them down even when I begged her to." Pushing aside a few Christmas cards, Adora revealed a bunch of photos of the two of them when they were younger. "She said they were important." Adora paused, and wrapped her arm around Catra's shoulders, tucking her firmly under her chin. "She said *you* were important."

With a small hiccup, Catra wrapped her own arms around Adora's waist and squeezed.

"I'm glad she didn't let me take them down," Adora finished, turning her cheek to rest on top of Catra's hair.

"You're an idiot."

"Yeah."

"I would have shredded them."

She could feel Adora smile against her. "I know."

Catra snorted and shoved back, wiping at her eyes with as much subtlety as she could manage, settling into Adora's chest as she wrapped her arms around Catra's waist from behind, and reached forward to push a few more cards to the side.

There were photos of them as little kids, arms wrapped around one another at the homestead, wrestling on the soccer fields, cake smeared on their faces at birthday parties, and asleep on the couch on New Years, with party horns hanging from their mouths. It was as if their entire life together was mapped out on this fridge.

She couldn't help but run her fingers over a faded photo of the two of them, fifteen and flushed with embarrassment, as they got ready to go on their first date.

"Mara was absolutely overjoyed that we finally decided to go out." Adora settled her chin into the curve of Catra's shoulder, her smile so wide Catra could feel it against her cheeks. "Remember how I tried to rush out the door but she gave us the worlds' largest guilt trip to come inside and take a picture?"

"She did love to pull the whole *I'm dying* card, huh." A bittersweet laugh bubbled between them as Catra's tail flicked to wrap around Adora's ankle. "I remember you were so scared to ask me out that I wound up having to do it for you."

Adora groaned. "God, don't remind me."

"I'll never let it go. Sorry that you were such a dork."

A comfortable silence fell over them before Catra twisted around to poke a finger at Adora's forehead. "Were you going to change?" Catra asked, watching as blue eyes crossed to try and look at the point of contact before Adora scrunched up her nose and nodded.

"Please go, I'm starving."

With a salute and a quick twirl, Adora disappeared into the back of the house. Catra could only shake her head, amused, before she started looking around the kitchen again. It took about ten seconds before her eyes landed on something else familiar. "No way," she breathed with a laugh, taking a few short strides to reach some framed artwork on the wall.

Catra looked over the first painting she had ever gifted to Mara and Razback when she was about nine, sloppy and novice but resonating joy, and right beside it, the last, from when she was seventeen and far more skilled, a portrait of Raz, Mara, and Adora that she had painted for her final project. A smile tugged at her lips as she ran gentle fingers over the canvas, remembering so vividly the late nights holed up in her room trying to perfect all the details.

Raz really had kept her alive in their house, and Catra felt a lump forming in her throat.

She shouldn't deserve this.

But they always made her feel like she did.

Sighing, Catra turned to peek down the hall, eyes landing on a sliver of light pouring from where she knew Mara and Adora's old bedroom was. She couldn't help but wonder if the rest of the house was still the same, or if Raz or Adora had tried to change it after Mara had passed.

She knew they were both sentimental…

Catra dragged her fingers along the hallway wall, flinching when they hit the edge of another frame. Raz did love her pictures; She said it helped with her scattered memory, said it helped to keep her present instead of floating to the past, or attempting to predict the future. When Catra turned to look at the photo she expected to see one of the three who lived here staring back at her, but instead was met with her own face - ten years younger and smiling bright, but definitely hers.

She took it off the wall, holding it gently between her hands, and couldn't stop smiling. They were about sixteen here and at a school football game. Adora had black paint on her cheeks, colored ribbons wrapped around her ponytail, and a thick white sweater on. Her arm was wrapped behind Catra's back, hidden by Adora's red letterman jacket that had been slung over Catra' s shoulders. She remembered this night so clearly:

It had been the last time Mara was well enough to go out.

They all went to the game, then got ice cream, and then…

Swallowing against the tears she felt forming, Catra hung it back on the wall, delicately straightening it and moving on to the next frame of the five that stretched along this hallway. She qickly gathered that these were all photos Mara had taken of them, but this one felt less painful.

It was, again, her and Adora, but they were on the porch, probably only a few weeks after the football game. Catra was sitting in Adora's lap, her legs hung over the arm of the chair, and her arms had been wrapped around Adora's shoulders. Adora's hand was resting on Catra's knee as Catra leaned in to press a kiss against the corner of Adora's mouth.

She had been so, so in love. She had been so *happy* .

But…

Catra reached up to take this one off the wall as well, looking more closely.

Adora was smiling - she *was* - but her smile didn't reach her eyes, and the usual sparkle of pure joy was missing. Had she not been happy?

Had.Had Catra completely missed the signs?

She bit her lip and moved to the next, taken a few months later, and frowned. Adora had the same half-smile, but it was now accompanied by paler skin and slightly furrowed brows. The next photo came with the addition of dark circles under her eyes, and the last…

Adora looked so *tired* .

How hadn't Catra noticed it at the time?

She hugged the stack of photos to her chest and leaned against the wall, frowning when she heard Adora call out "sorry! I can't find a clean shirt!"It was coming back to her , now. Adora was always falling asleep in class, and found any excuse to lay her head on Catra's lap and close her eyes. Her grades had started slipping, and she had begged Catra to tutor her - which sometimes worked, but other times resulted in Catra just doing some of her homework for her.

Adora had said it was because of soccer, or because she'd rather spend all her time with Catra, or she needed to help at the diner, or some other excuse. There had always been an excuse. She had always laughed it off.

And Catra had been so caught up in finally being with Adora, finally being able to soak in all of the love she had always craved from her…

But she hadn't noticed that Adora had been struggling.

But Adora never asked for help, always said she just hadn't slept well that night, always said she was fine.

But Catra should have noticed.

Fuck.

She walked to the cracked door, and knocked lightly. "Hey , Adora?" she asked, pushing against the wood. "Can I come in?"

"Y eah of course!"

Catra's cheeks flushed slightly when she opened the door and was greeted by Adora's strong back, only covered by the strap of her bra. "Sorry ,"Adora huf fed, bending down to grab a t-shirt off the ground and lifting it to her nose to take a whiff. "I haven't had time to do laundry I guess."She shrugged and threw this one over her head, clearly deciding it would be good enough. She spun around and gave Catra a smile before her eyes landed on the frames in Catra's arms. "Whatcha got there?"

Looking down and frowning before holding them out for Adora to take, Catra bit at her bottom lip. "When we were kids"…

Adora took the photos from her hands and looked through them, a smile growing on her face. "A w,"she said, holding one up for Catra to look at. "Look how sweet we were."

"Adora."Catra' s voice was sharper than she meant for it to be, and she drew her brows together as Adora frowned, staring down at her. "Look at you."

She tried, she really did. Adora looked at each picture, setting the frame down on the bed after each examination. "I don't know what you want me to look at, Catra."

Catra grabbed the last photo taken out of Adora's hands and jabbed her finger against the glass. "Look how tired you look."

It had been taken just three weeks before Mara passed, in the doorway of the very room they stood in now. Catra remembered it too vividly - remembered Mara's weak voice as she asked them to come in, her shaking hands as she held up the camera, and the soft smile on her lips as she asked them to humor her, just one more

time. They both looked sad in their smiles, but Adora looked like she had been masking sheer devastation.

"I mean, yeah. It was a bad month." Adora lifted her hand to rub at the back of her neck, eyes darting around the room.

Catra set the photo down gently, before stepping forward and placing one palm flat over Adora's chest. "Adora." Blue eyes snapped down to meet hers, brows furrowed with worry. "I'm sorry that I didn't notice."

"What…"

"All of those photos, Adora," Catra started, running her free hand down Adora's arm, and settling it around her wrist. "Those were taken over like eighteen months. You look tired by week four."

Adora frowned and recoiled slightly, so Catra pulled her hands away.

With a drop of her shoulders and a deep breath, Catra asked "how much of Mara's care were you handling by yourself?"

Adora's throat bobbed as she swallowed, and she crossed her arms in front of her stomach, as if holding herself together. "Catra, that was like almost a decade ago. It doesn't matter." She locked her gaze onto the door behind Catra's shoulder, and squeezed herself tighter.

"How much?" Catra risked taking one step closer, keeping her hands at her sides. "All of it?"

She saw the scoff more than heard it, Adora's body language turning dismissive like it had all of those years ago. "Razz couldn't. Between the diner and her bad memory. She just couldn't. But they took me in, and I was living here for free, so it was the least I could do anyway. And I didn't mind at all."

Catra reached for Adora, and settled her palm on her elbow when she didn't flinch away. "Adora, they didn't *take you in*. They *adopted* you because they loved you and wanted you to be a part of their family." Adora's eyes rolled and Catra couldn't help but squeeze. "You know that, right? You know that they love you? That they wanted to make sure you were taken care of?" Adora stiffened, and Catra remembered.

You take care of me, and I take care of you.

It was something Adora had said all the time. Had it been something Mara had said to her, too?

"You know that Mara being sick, her not getting better. You were just a kid, and it wasn't on *you* for her to get better." Adora wouldn't look at her, and Catra squeezed tighter. "It wasn't your fault, Adora. Tell me you know that."

Tensing under Catra's hands, Adora's shoulders lifted to her ears and she frowned deeper. "You know, I always thought that maybe if they had just not spent all the money on lawyers and getting me adopted, that Mara might have been able to afford better doctors." She paused, and leaned into Catra's touch. "It wasn't worth that, you know? I would have been fine."

Catra risked pressing her other palm against Adora's chest again, fingers just curving around the base of her neck, and felt relief wash over her when Adora tucked her chin down to almost hug Catra's hand.

"But, they spent all that money on me. I had to help. I had to do everything I could to help."

"Adora." Catra slid her hand up to cup the side of Adora's neck, frowning. "Mara knew what was coming for her. She *knew*. She wouldn't have spent money she couldn't." Her other hand rose to match, almost holding Adora's head straight so she couldn't look away. "She wanted you to be her daughter more than anything."

When Adora met her gaze, eyes wet and dim, Catra felt a bittersweet smile tug at her lips. "That was the choice she made. She wouldn't want you beating yourself up for her choice."

Adora dropped her gaze, with a small, sad nod. "I know ."

"I'm sorry I didn't notice."Adora shook her head, but Catra stepped forward and wrapped her arms around Adora's neck, tucking her face into Catra's shoulder. "You shouldn't have had to do it alone. I would have helped if you had just *told* me."

Catra felt Adora's arms tighten around her waist, and she pressed her cheek on top of Adora's head. "Were you sleeping at all?"

A shrug, and a soft, "I don't remember ."

Biting the inside of her cheek, Catra frowned. "I mean. I was here or you were at my place most nights until one in the morning doing homework. and I remember you said Mara had early mornings. If you were doing it, I assume you were up at like four every day. Then. School, and soccer , and you worked at the diner *and* at the homestead"…

How the fuck had she not realized?

Adora said, pathetic, "so I guess not really , then."

"Why didn't you tell me? I wouldn't have minded sacrificing some time with you so you could rest."

"You were so happy, Catra."Adora' s words were muffled against Catra's shirt, and her arms tightened. "You were so happy and you were the only *good* thing I had and I didn't want to lose out on a second of that."

She didn't know what to say.

Realistically Catra wasn't sure if she would have taken it well, or if her mind would have flipped it to be a rejection, if Adora *had* started

spending less time with her. *Now* she would understand, but at sixteen, seventeen? Maybe not. So all she did was pull Adora impossibly closer, and hold on tight until Adora signaled that she was ready to let go.

"It got worse when I left for school, too."

Catra blinked, frowning as Adora pulled away, her gaze downcast.

"I just felt like I couldn't risk all the things she sacrificed for me not being worth it." Adora sat on the bed, sliding the frames over and frowning when they clinked together. "I had to be perfect. I had to keep up with everything and then my friends expected more from me than I really was able to give them so I never slept and I was just so burnt out by the end of it"…

Catra came to sit beside her, pressing their shoulders together. It made so much sense; Catra couldn't help but think back to the weekends before they broke up, when Catra would say Adora didn't need to visit, but Adora would insist - and then be tired and snippy the whole time, before quickly apologizing and saying she was stressed. Catra had felt so much resentment as a teenager, and felt so much disgust at how unaware she had been now - but she stayed quiet and let Adora get whatever she needed to off of her chest.

"I just if I stopped, I would *think.* And thinking led to feeling bad and letting everything slip and letting everyone down." Adora's fists were clenched in her lap, knuckles turning white before Catra moved her hand to rub at those tense knuckles, feeling a little relief as Adora's hands relaxed. "I"…

She looked up at Catra, eyes wet and tired. "I let you slip."

"Adora"…

"I know we talked about it, I know, but I let you slip and I never wanted to." Her voice was strained, and her fists tightened again. "You were the best thing I had and I couldn't balance everything and

I should have sacrificed something else."Adora squeezed her eyes tight, frown deepening. "I need you to know that I never wanted to lose you. I messed up and -"

" *Adora* ."

Adora took in a gasp for air as Catra's sharp tongue cut her off.

"Can we make a deal?"

Adora nodded, keeping her eyes shut.

Catra used gentle strokes of her fingers to encourage Adora to loosen her grip, scooting the tiniest bit closer. "Let's agree to never fucking apologize for the past again, okay?"

With a breathless laugh, Adora nodded.

"I mean it. We've both apologized. We were both stupid and both fucked up and I just." Lifting a delicate finger to Adora's chin, Catra asked for Adora to look at her, adoration flooding over her when she did. "I want us to just do this. And be together. And fuck the past. Can we do that?"

Adora's lips stretched into a smile, and she twisted to wipe her wet cheek on her shoulder. "Yeah," she laughed, sweet. "Yeah, we can. I want that, too."

"Okay, good," Catra said as she let her hand drop back to Adora's lap, holding both of those fists in her palms. "Now can we *please* get some fucking breakfast?"

With a sigh of relief, Adora mumbled "god, *yes* ."

Chapter End Notes

> As always, sorry for the long wait <3 thank you guys for being the best ;w;

I hope you enjoyed(?) a little peek into Adora's side of the past. This chapter got away from me so it's longer than most of the other chapters in this fic have been so...:')

Anyway, as always, comments make my whole fucking day, and I'm trying to get to the backlog of comments i havent replied to yet!

Come hang out with me on twitter! (18+ with age/DOB visible please!)

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You are," Catra huffed, gasping for air as sweat dripped down her back, pooling between her shoulder blades. "The *biggest* dork alive."

Adora burst into laughter, throwing her head back as she braced her hands on her hips and took in big lungfuls of air. The sun coming through the high windows of the barn was hitting her just so, leaving her glowing golden and ethereal. Catra couldn't look away.

"Sorry." Adora wiped the sweat off her brow and pulled her t-shirt out in pulses, as if hoping to get some air flowing under the cotton. "You looked bored."

Bored?

Catra had walked out to the barn after hearing music blaring expecting to find Adora cleaning, but instead opened the door to the goofiest sight that was Adora dancing around to some country song Catra only barely recognized. The woman had absolutely *no* rhythm - she never had - but the pure joy on her face as she hopped around and swung her hips and twirled the gear she was in the process of hanging up made Catra's chest bloom with fondness.

No, she was absolutely not *bored* as she leaned against the door and watched Adora with a smirk on her lips. She was completely, stupidly enamored.

Adora had caught her staring and smiled, a flush burning her cheeks.

"Oh, please continue," Catra had smirked, and then somehow, with flirty words and insistent hands, Adora had convinced Catra to join

her, spinning around the disgustingly hot barn - even throwing a few old moves they had learned in school when they did square dancing in gym - sweating buckets.

Now she was regretting it, but only slightly, and only because she hated the way her sweat soaked shirt clung to her back.

"Definitely wasn't bored," Catra breathed, finally feeling her heart rate evening back out. "Watching you dance has always been a treat."

Adora's cheeks were pink - whether from the heat or embarrassment, Catra didn't know - as she huffed and asked "because I'm the worst dancer alive?"

"A little of that. A little because it's the only time you ever seem to really let go." Catra dropped her eyes to Adora's hips, raising one eyebrow before locking their gazes again. "And also because you're hot."

With a roll of her eyes and a bark of a laugh, Adora darted forward and lifted Catra into the air by her waist. Ignoring her half-hearted protests and wiggling of her legs, Adora moved Catra just a little closer to the side of the barn to sit her down on a railing that put them at the same height, Adora settling between Catra's knees. Their eyes met, and Catra felt her heart stutter.

Adora glanced down to Catra's mouth in such a quick, fleeting moment, that Catra wondered if she was seeing things, but then Adora pressed her lips together and cleared her throat before turning her head away, and Catra knew she wasn't. "You want a water? I have a few still in the cooler."

They had agreed to take it slow, and for some dumbass reason Catra had suggested they not kiss until they go on a proper date.

Maybe she was still a little spooked by what intense feelings might flood back the second she felt Adora's lips again. Maybe she knew if

she was able to kiss her, she'd want to do all the *other* things they used to do. Either way, it was the choice she made, and Adora respected her boundaries, and Catra was fucking regretting it.

"Y -yeah," Catra stammered, her eyes following the shift of Adora' s back muscles as she leaned over and grabbed two ice cold bottles from the cooler. Adora came back and cracked the bottle open for Catra, letting her take it from Adora's hands before she found her way back between Catra's knees. "Thank you."

Adora nodded and smiled before opening her own bottle and tipping her head back to drink.

Catra froze, holding the water to her lips but failing to actually take even a sip as her eyes locked onto the bobbing of Adora's throat as she swallowed. When she stopped to gasp for air, steel blue eyes noticing the still full bottle of water at Catra's mouth, Adora smirked.

Fuck. Fuck!

"Y ou should drink that."

And, with her thumb tracing the inside of Catra's knee:

"Y ou look thirsty."

Fuck this stupid fucking suggestion.

She put her water bottle down.

"What if we kissed?" Catra could see the strain in Adora' s face as she tried to hold back an amused smile, but she pressed on. "W aiting is stupid. We've kissed, god, how many times before?" Catra looked down for half a second at the hand slipping just a fraction higher on her thigh. "Just kiss me. W e can go up to that ledge," she said, pointing upwards. "Like we used to when we wanted to make out but Weaver was home."

Catra was a stupid horny fucking teenager again and all she wanted was for her hot as hell best friend to kiss her absolutely senseless.

"Catra," Adora said, amusement evident in the lilt of her voice. "We agreed to wait."

A scoff tore from the back of her throat. "That was stupid. I'm stupid. I've been dying to kiss you since you showed up on my driveway asking for a job."

Catra's cheeks flushed at the admittance, but, *whatever*, who the fuck cared if she was admitting humiliating shit; She just wanted to feel those sweet, always slightly chapped lips on hers again.

"That's pretty embarrassing for you," Adora teased, leaning closer.

With a roll of her eyes, Catra frowned. "What's *embarrassing* is that you dancing like an idiot is what's breaking my resolve." Then, after a short laugh from Adora, Catra huffed. "So are you going to kiss me or what?"

Adora's bottom lip was caught between her teeth, as if she was seriously contemplating breaking their agreement. She came a hair closer, pressing her lips together before her tongue darted out to wet them, and Catra felt her heart hammering beneath her ribs. Oh, fuck. Okay. Shit.

Was she actually ready for this?

God, *yes*.

But then Adora stopped, patted her hand against Catra's thigh, and smiled. "I still think we should wait."

God fucking *damn it.*

"Then you better ask me out on a proper date soon because I don't know how much longer I'll last without kissing you until you can't remember your own fucking name."

Adora's cheeks were burning red, clearly flustered by the thought, and she swallowed hard as her eyes darted between Catra's intense gaze and her plush lips. "*You* can ask *me*, you know," Adora said, trying to get some hint of smugness back into her words.

Catra laughed, and pressed her index finger against Adora's forehead. "No fucking way. I did that when we were fourteen and you were too awkward and dorky to get the words out. You're asking me this time."

Biting her lip to stop from smiling again, Adora shrugged and nodded, before letting out a sigh. "Well. Okay, I had an idea, but I thought you might hate it, so I was hesitating to ask?" Adora said, scrunching her mouth to one side, eyes following the movement of Catra's hand as she dropped it back to her lap. "But they're having the monthly square dance party thing this weekend. I know dancing isn't your *favorite* but we always used to have fun when Mara would take us, and we can leave if you do hate it, but"—

"Absolutely." Catra didn't bother to wait for the rest. "If it'll count as a first date then yes, hell yes."

"Okay!" Adora's smile was so bright and so happy that Catra couldn't stop her own lips from stretching to perfectly mirror that excitement. "Perfect. I'll come pick you up, and we can get dinner first, and then maybe something sweet after, and then I'll drop you off and." She blushed, and then clamped her mouth shut, her grin still present.

Nodding enthusiastically, Catra finished for her:

"Then you're going to fucking kiss me and make up for seven years of lost time."

Catra's heart fluttered at the laugh Adora gave, and she couldn't help but throw herself off of the railing with her arms spread wide, knowing that Adora would catch her without question. She wrapped her legs around Adora's hips, and smiled when Adora buried her nose into the crook of Catra's neck.

"Then I'm going to kiss you," she repeated, her voice softer now , but with a hint of something Catra couldn't quite place. "After seven years."

They stayed like that for a while, Adora rocking them just slightly as the music still blared in the barn. Their skin was sticking together, drenched with sweat - but Catra didn't even care, not one fucking bit.

Adora broke the comfortable quiet between them by bouncing Catra up higher on her hips, readjusting her grip. "I'm almost done in here," she said, her lips moving against Catra's skin. "You want to take the shower first?"

"How sweet of you," Catra purred, teasing. "Offering me the shower first in my own home."

As she unwrapped her legs and hopped down, Adora shrugged. "What can I say? I'm a gentleman."

Catra hummed in approval, taking a few steps backwards to break their contact. She looked up at the loft of the barn, smirking as Adora followed her gaze. "Last chance. We can go up there right now, and kiss like we're dumb teenagers again. You don't *have* to be a gentleman."

Adora shoved her hands in her pockets, as if that was the only thing that could ground her, that could stop her from saying fuck it and dragging Catra up the ladder bodily. "Just a few more days," she said, rigid. "I wanna do it right."

"Okay," Catra sang, turning on her heel and starting her trek back up to the house. "But you better wear that stupid fucking cowboy hat."

"Oh I will *absolutely* be wearing the cowboy hat."

—

After one of the best showers Catra thought she had *ever* had, she moved down the stairs with a spring in her step and spun around the railing before being stopped in her tracks.

"I'm not fucking doing that."

Catra was startled at the anger in Adora's voice, and she moved to lean against the wall, staying as quiet as possible. She knew she shouldn't eavesdrop, but Adora *rarely* sounded like that, and Catra needed to know what was causing it.

"What do you mean? I *am*."

She couldn't quite make out the words that the other person was saying, but their voice held the tone of someone who was worried.

Adora dropped down into the kitchen chair with an audible thud. "I don't care what she says. Glimmer." An exasperated sigh blew through her lips, and the chair creaked as Catra could only assume she leaned back. "Do you not fucking remember?"

Catra's ears perked up as the other person's voice rose.

"Of course I remember! I've never been more scared in my life!"

"Then why do you want me to go back?"

She could feel her tail whipping behind her, shoulders tensing. She remembered Glimmer - they had met a couple times when Catra went to campus to visit Adora. She seemed nice enough, but... was she part of the reason Adora had left? Was Adora trying to avoid her, too?

Glimmer's voice had lowered enough that Catra couldn't make out the words anymore, and she felt her ears pin back down.

"They... They don't *care*, Glimmer. They didn't. No. No, I didn't." Catra could hear her fingers drumming on the table, an old anxiety tic that it seems has never gone away. "I *am*." Then, "what

aren't you getting? —No, don't — *fucking*." She groaned, and Catra heard the tell-tale whack of Adora having dropped her head against the table in frustration.

A new voice - a deeper one - was vibrating through the phone.

"Hi, Bow ," Adora said, a frown evident in her voice. Catra remembered him, too. He was kind - almost overly so. "I'm not being nonsensical — I *am* thinking."

There was a lot of his voice - with a couple interjections of Glimmer 's - before Adora stood back up and started pacing. "Look, please let me talk."

Catra shouldn't be fucking *listening*.

"I understand that you guys are just looking out for me, and I understand that you think it can all be fixed with just a positive attitude and creative thinking — let me *talk*."

Adora was so rarely this intense and outwardly frustrated, and when she *was* , it had always been for a good reason. Catra wanted to comfort her, to let her know she was there. She took a deep breath, trying to calm herself down, and attempted to get her expression and heart rate down to somewhere where it would look like she *hadn't* been listening.

"I wasn't happy there. Do you not get that? It was only fun when I had you guys."

Catra took a step out.

"I'm happy *now*. I'm"…

Catra looked at how Adora's shoulders were risen, how her jaw was clenched. "*Don't* fucking say that. You don't *know* " A pause. "No. This is what I *want*. Why don't you get that? I'm so — *no*. Glimmer , please *stop*."

Her fist was clenched at her sides, shaking, and Catra could see the knuckles of the hand holding the phone had started turning white.

"I understand why you think that, but you're *wrong*. I'm so happy here, okay?"

Adora turned in her pacing, and caught sight of Catra, and her whole body relaxed in what looked like a visible sigh of relief.

"More than I've been since I was a kid." Adora's eyes were locked onto Catra, and a soft smile tugged at her lips. She held up one finger to Catra, swallowing when she nodded.

"I'll talk to Hope, but she's not going to like my answer."

They both started talking, and from this distance Catra could pick up something along the lines of *that's all we want,is for you to talk to her* , and *we just don't want you throwing away your whole career without knowing all the options* before Adora cut them off again, her eyes never leaving Catra's.

"Look, I gotta go. Thanks for checking in, I guess."

And then she hung up, not even waiting for their goodbyes.

And then she surged towards Catra, wrapping desperate arms tightly around her waist, and she whispered, "have I told you how happy you make me?"

Catra's worries melted away as a soft purr vibrated from her chest, her arms reaching up to stroke at Adora's hair. "I think I could stand to hear it more often," she teased, trying to lighten the mood - but her throat tightened when Adora pulled back, locking their gazes together.

"You make me so happy, Catra." Her brows were furrowed, and the burning intensity behind those blue eyes startled Catra, just slightly. "Being home, and.with *you* .I'm so fucking happy ." And her voice

cracked, as she stammered out, "I don't want you to ever think that's not the truth, okay?"

She hadn't *said* the words, but this sure fucking felt like a huge declaration of love - something she agreed she wouldn't do.

What the fuck had her friends *said*?

Catra felt panic in her chest.

Not because she didn't want to hear it.

But because she knew Adora fucking meant it.

And she felt it, too.

So soon.

But was it really so soon?

Maybe it hadn't ever really left.

Catra pulled Adora back to her chest, tucking Adora's chin against her shoulder. She ran her fingers through blonde locks, frowning when Adora's body started to shake. "I know , Adora," she murmured, wincing slightly when Adora's grip tightened. "I know ."

It took Adora a little while to calm herself back down.

Catra had insisted they move to the couch, and had positioned Adora against her chest, with her head in the curve of Catra's collarbone, and stroked tenderly at her hair. She had done this plenty when they were kids, but Adora got to a point of being able to function again much faster these days, it seemed.

"I'm sorry ," she had mumbled, eyes closed as her breathing evened out. "I just-it's s.it' s a lot. I'm sorry."

She started to tremble again, and Catra shook her head. "Why are you apologizing?"

Adora shifted just slightly, hooking her knees under Catra's elbow, curling into herself even tighter. "I want to tell you," she whispered, as if saying it too loud would make it come back. "But every time I think about talking about it...this happens."

"Do you have your meds?"

"No." Her voice was sharp, and Catra swallowed the rest of her question. "I don't take them anymore."

A soft "why not?" left her lips before Catra could think better of it, and she regretted it as soon as Adora tensed. It wasn't hard to figure out that it was a sensitive subject, and probably fit in with all the things Adora wasn't quite ready to talk about. So Catra offered a quick *nevermind*, and Adora relaxed - just slightly.

"I'm sorry."

Catra learned quickly and chose her next words more carefully. "You don't have anything to apologize for."

Adora nodded, and settled back in against Catra's skin.

They stayed that way until Adora took a deep breath, moved to stand, and said she should probably get back to Razz. Catra had offered for her to just stay over again, but Adora, with an apology in her eyes, said she needed just a night alone to cool off.

Catra understood. She was grateful for the communication - unlike when they were kids and Adora would just disappear and be unreachable for a day or two after a severe panic attack - and asked just that Adora let her know that she got home safe.

Thirty minutes later, she got a text with a picture of Adora, curled up in bed with the covers over her head, hugging an old stuffed horse

toy to her chest.

[swiftwind says hello]

[youre such a dork]

[I know]<3

[<3

Catra tapped her phone against her chin and sighed before crawling into bed. She wished Adora had stayed. She frowned, and prayed that something in this bed still smelled like her.

She pulled a pillow - the one Adora had borrowed the other night - to her chest.

She buried her nose deep into the cushion.

It didn't.

She groaned.

—

Adora seemed...of f the next morning.

First of all, she was late. Adora was *never* late.

She had come over and brought Catra a coffee, gave her a lingering hug, and then went to work..all as usual. But she seemed..Catra couldn't put her finger on it. Adora was carrying herself a little smaller, her eyes were drooping, and she was holding her own coffee like it was her only remaining life line. Her movements were sluggish and heavy, and she kept pausing to catch her breath.

Was she..hungover? Maybe she just hadn't slept well…

Catra guessed she could understand after that call yesterday but…

She sighed. It was a one time thing, so she decided to let it go and move on with the day. Adora had never had the best coping mechanisms, but Catra just made a promise to herself to look out for any further signs of trouble, and bring it up *if* it became an issue.

So she went ahead and made them lunch.

"Hey , Adora!" Catra called, poking her head up into the open window , frowning when she didn't see Adora on the field. She moved to the door, stepped out onto the porch, and craned her neck to the edges of the property. "Adora?"

No response.

Weird.

She took a few steps out, deciding to check the few buildings surrounding the homestead. "Lunch is ready ," Catra called, chewing at the inside of her cheek. Still nothing.

Then she heard a crash in the barn.

Her feet carried her more quickly than she thought possible, fearing the worst. There were a lot of sharp objects in there, and god forbid Adora lost her balance or —

There was a sharper crack this time, one that sounded like something being thrown.

Catra pushed on the door, eyes adjusting to the dimmer light as she scanned over the ground. She heard it before she saw it - a thump, and a whimper, and a heavy inhale, a choked sob and —

"Adora ?" —

Shit.

Chapter End Notes

ETA: it has come to my attention that the ending of this chapter is WAY more ominous than I thought it was – I promise Adora is fine!!!! This is not a tragic story and never will be!! She just has Severe Anxiety 😭 the next chapter will have a pretty detailed description of that but - please do not fret!!! It's not tragic!!!!

Hiya friends! Finally we're getting some more peeks into Adora's life, hmm? Wonder what's got her so riled up…

I hope y'all enjoyed this chapter! At least for the most part :D

Comments literally make my whole day every time and I love reading how you feel/what you think! And as always, if you're 18+ feel free to come hang out with me on T witter @fistypaaants!! I also have a CuriousCat linked there if you ever want to talk to me about fics or anything else really! :3

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

Hi friends! Some content warnings for this chapter:

Please be aware that the beginning of this chapter is a fairly descriptive depiction of a panic attack. It's from an outside perspective which may make it a bit easier to read, but just wanted to give a heads up.

There is also mention of an accidental overdose and hospitalization, but it is a quick mention.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra ran, ignoring the sting in her knees as she dropped in front of Adora, curled up in the corner of the barn. "Hey , Adora." No response. Her eyes were glazed over and wide, locked onto something invisible across the room. One hand was over her heart, fingers clenched into her shirt, as she pounded it repeatedly against her chest - the other was barely curled around her drawn up knees as her whole body shook.

Fuck.

Catra scooted as close as she dared before she was sure that Adora knew that she was there. "Adora. Hey." Catra tried again, softer , but still firm. Adora's brows drew together as she gulped in a lungful of air before releasing it in an audible sob. "I know , I'm here," Catra whispered, giving one sharp nod as Adora's eyes darted to her for a fleeting second before finding the empty spot across the room again.

Okay, that was good. Adora knew she was here, and Catra hoped she remembered what to do. This unfortunately wasn't new to her… but it had been so long.

"Hey, Adora, hey." Catra hovered her hands by Adora's face, not yet touching her. "It's me. It's Catra." She could hear the strain in her own voice, but she had to pull it together. She couldn't risk showing her fear. "Can you nod once if I can touch you?"

It was a jerky, barely there nod, but enough of a confirmation that Catra felt comfortable placing her hands onto Adora's neck, thumbs grazing the bottom of her jaw. "Hi, hey." Catra swallowed hard against the lump in her throat, but plastered a small smile onto her lips. "Baby, can you look at me?"

Her glossy eyes shifted from side to side, but not quite where Catra wanted them. Adora's breathing got quicker, her whole body trembling as she spiraled, clearly unable to steady herself, and Catra felt panic rising in her bones.

Fuck.

Catra had done this so many times, she just had to remember. She fucking needed to *remember*. It was there, in the back of her mind, but she had pushed it down - now she needed to dig it back up.

Adora needed grounding. She needed touch, and sound, and someone *familiar.*

So Catra moved herself instead, blocking everything else from Adora's view, and smiled when blue eyes finally met hers, slowly beginning to refocus. "Hi. There you are," Catra said softly with a smile. She moved one hand to Adora's chest and pressed it firmly against her sternum; a comfort, and also a barrier from Adora's own self harming fist. "Can you breathe with me?"

Adora didn't take her eyes off of her as Catra shifted on her knees. That was good.

"Okay, breathe in." Taking a deep, slow breath in through her nose, Catra kept Adora's eyes focused on her. Adora tried - her breath stuttered as she inhaled, and broke into a few quick breaths

before she managed to start a slow exhale. "Yeah, that's perfect," Catra practically whispered, and "all the way out, that's it."

She breathed in again, less shaky this time, and Catra's voice stayed low as she said "you're doing so good," before urging Adora to release the breath. Adora's hands had shifted, gently touching Catra's knees as her breathing got slower and deeper. Relief bloomed through Catra's veins from the touch, thankful that Adora's hands were no longer beating at her own body.

In.

Out.

Color was slowly returning to Adora's face, a soft pink dusting at her cheeks and lips, and Catra felt her shoulders slump. "Hey." She couldn't control her quick, happy nodding before she pulled Adora slightly closer, gently tilting her head to press their foreheads together. "There you go," she whispered, stroking her thumbs across Adora's cheeks. "You're okay."

Continuing to whisper affirmations and praise was all Catra could think to do as Adora's breathing continued to even out. They stayed there for a while, foreheads together, Adora's thumbs slowly stroking along Catra's knees as Adora's legs straightened out to her side. "I'm here," and "I've got you," and "you're doing so good, Adora."

Adora stayed quiet for what felt like hours, but she kept breathing, and her fingers kept stroking against Catra's knees, and she was going to be fine; she was going to find her way back down. Catra would be patient and would stay here as long as Adora needed her. She could even ignore the sticky syrups and honeys and jams that were coating her legs, shattered from the storage shelf beside them.

Scooting a little closer, Catra pressed one hand more firmly against the back of Adora's neck, her lips turning into a smile when Adora's hand rose to brush at her elbow. "There's my girl," Catra hummed,

scratching her fingers against the base of Adora's skull. "Take all the time you need, okay?"

"S-sorry ."

Catra couldn't help the surprised jolt of her shoulders at Adora' s words.

Adora's voice was raspy and quiet as she spoke, still not fully back, but much more coherent. "I'm sorry , I'm"…

Without any hesitation, Catra shook her head and pressed somehow closer to Adora. "Shh, it' s okay. You have *nothing* to apologize for ."

They sat in silence for another moment, millions of questions running through Catra's head - but it didn't seem like the right time for any of them. She settled for a simple, "what happened?"

Adora huffed a shaky breath, her hands grabbing onto and pleading against Catra's hips, begging her to come closer, and Adora only began to settle again when Catra crawled into her lap, curling their bodies together. Catra didn't want to pry, but "I understand that you haven't wanted to talk about it, Adora, but if it's causing you this much stress". She leaned back just far enough to catch Adora' s gaze and gave her a sad smile. "I just want to help, but I don't know how if I don't know what's going on."

A warm hand slid up Catra's back, landing under her hair against her neck. "No, you're right. You". Adora' s voice was still hoarse, and she pressed her nose into the crook of Catra's neck, avoiding eye contact. "I'm afraid you're going to think I'm being stupid."

Catra shook her head in refusal, frowning when Adora's shoulders slumped forward. "I, like, know you won't? But also what if you do?"

"I won't." Anything that caused *this* could never be stupid.

With a nod and a heavy breath, Adora lifted her head, but still wouldn't let Catra catch her eyes. "I called my manager ."

Catra waited for her to continue, but it seemed Adora needed another nudge. "Oh? How'd that go?" she teased, quirking a brow , clearly aware that it definitely hadn't gone *well* .

Adora laughed, barely, and took in a deep breath, finally daring to meet Catra's gaze. "Oh, just great. Y ou know," she shrugged, rolling her eyes. "She wants me to come back."

Ignoring the sharp stab in her chest, Catra pursed her lips. "Do you want to go back?" She tried to ignore the way her fingers tightened against Adora's neck, tried to ignore the fear of losing her again that bubbled in her throat. This wasn't the *time* for her selfish concerns.

"I..." Adora started, frowning and dropping her eyes to the floor . "I don't know."

Catra only hummed in response, forcing her grip to loosen.

It took Adora a moment to continue, her lips scrunched to one side in thought. "I like soccer ... I... think I like soccer," she said, voice rising almost as if she were asking.

"Y ou think?" Catra prodded, simply stroking her fingers against the tight muscles of Adora's neck.

With a shrug and a quick glance up at Catra, Adora blew out a heavy breath. "W ell it was more fun before. With you." She hesitated, and twisted her fingers into a loose thread on Catra's shorts before continuing. "And with Bow and Glimmer. But"...

"Playing professionally killed it?"

"Y eah."

She looked so disheartened, and Catra reached forward to tuck some loose hair back behind Adora's ear, frowning. "I mean, what

did she say back when you quit?"

Adora froze, biting at her lower lip and paused the distracted ministrations of her fingers along Catra's thigh. "Well, that's kind of the thing," she said, shrugging again before offering a meek and crooked smile - one that held so much shame. "I didn't quit?"

Huh?

"Then...shouldn't you...still be there?" Catra asked, her face showing obvious confusion.

And, with one more shrug of her shoulders and a pop of her lips, Adora said "I mean, I... *left*."

Catra didn't want to push, she really didn't but...It just wasn't making *sense*. "You left without quitting?"

"Yep."

"Why?" Adora tensed beneath Catra's hands, but she had to know. She needed to ask. "Why did you leave?"

The only sound in the room was Adora's still slightly ragged breathing as her fingers clenched and unclenched on top of Catra's leg. Every so often, her lips would open before closing again, until finally she offered a quiet, defeated answer. "Because I fucked up."

She could tell it hurt Adora to admit - but what could have been so bad that Adora would just up and leave with no notice?

Catra hesitated for a moment, hoping not to make Adora feel like she was being judgemental. She just wanted to *understand*. "Was it really that bad, Adora?"

"It was."

Adora's hands moved back to Catra's hips, settling over her curves. Catra could feel them starting to shake, and she couldn't stop her

frown from deepening.

Adora sighed, taking a deep breath in to steady herself before continuing. "I got so in my head about being perfect, about being the star player, that I kept fucking up and missing easy saves and I ruined my teams' chances of getting into the finals and then to cope I got myself so messed up that I had to be fucking hospitalized and I let everyone down and I just had to go I *had* to I couldn't face them after that I couldn't—"

Wait, what?

Moving her hands quickly to Adora's shoulders, Catra shook her head and pushed back, forcing Adora to look somewhat in her direction. "Wait, wait. Slow down." Catra furrowed her brows and pressed her lips together. "Please."

There was a shame so heavy in Adora's features that Catra felt tears burning at the corner of her eyes as Adora's looked everywhere but at her. "Hospitalized?"

Adora took a deep breath and hid her face in the curve of Catra's neck, nose against her collarbone. Weak, and reluctant, she shrugged before saying, "you asked why I don't take my anti-anxiety meds anymore?"

"Yeah." Catra already knew where this was going, and didn't fucking like it.

"Well. That's why. They weren't working, so..." Adora paused, wrapped her arms around Catra's waist, and blew out a heavy sigh. "I took another , and another, and another"…

"Adora"…

She shook her head, and Catra tried to ignore the tiny spots of wetness she could feel touching her neck. "It's fine. Glimmer came

by after she heard what happened with the game and she got me there."

Fuck. Catra couldn't bear to think of it, but her mind couldn't stop thinking of Adora, scared and alone, and Adora, probably unresponsive and half conscious when Glimmer got there, and Adora so *desperate* to feel better that she fucking almost --

Catra choked, her stoic front breaking - only for a second - and wiped one hand at the side of her face.

"It wasn't on purpose or anything." Adora continued, her hands stroking up Catra's spine, as if she were trying to reassure her. "I don't feel like *that* . I just. I hadn't had an attack that bad in so long and it wasn't *working* ." Adora shrugged again and pressed her nose closer to the underside of Catra's jaw . "It was scary. But kind of a wake up call? I..."

Her voice was almost a whisper, breaking with an inaudible sob.

"I wasn't happy ."

Catra wanted to pour every ounce of care and warmth she could into Adora, so she let her arms come around Adora's shoulders, holding her head closer as she pressed her cheek against the top of Adora's head. Catra didn't know what to say, how to react.

So she held her.

And she held her.

And she held her.

—

It took another thirty minutes or so for Adora to pull away and say she felt well enough to get up. Another three for Catra to grab Adora's face between her hands and examine her, making sure color was present in her face and in her lips, searching desperately in

Adora's eyes to make sure she was *there* before agreeing that they could. Another two of Adora profusely apologizing for all the broken jars and wasted honeys and jams and syrups. Another one of Catra telling her it was *fine* and she did not care.

Another uncountable amount of time for Adora to wrap her arms around Catra again, mumbling thank yous into her hair. Catra simply pressed as close as she possibly could, stroking her fingers against the back of Adora's neck until she was ready to let go.

When she finally did, Catra told her to head inside and clean up - that she could throw her clothes into the laundry and take a shower. Catra just wanted to hose off the mess so it didn't attract any wildlife before she came in. Adora had frowned and said she'd do it, but Catra insisted.

She needed a minute to gather her thoughts, anyway. She needed a minute to be upset.

"Really, it's fine, Adora. I've got it." She had already begun picking up the largest pieces of glass and gathering them into a pile. It must have taken all of Adora's weight on this shelf to knock it down with enough force to shatter almost every jar. "Just go take care of yourself."

Without even looking, Catra could feel Adora's hesitation - could almost hear her fists clenching and unclenching at her sides, clearly feeling guilty but not wanting to push. Then, with a sigh, Adora turned to leave the barn. Catra waited until she heard the kitchen door bang shut before letting her shoulders slump, hating the way tears pricked at the corners of her eyes.

What right did she have to be this upset?

Fuck.

Sniffling and wiping at her face, Catra slammed the barn door open to retrieve the hose, turning on the water and making sure all the

goop had a place to drain to. Everything she did came with more force than was necessary, frustration oozing from her pores.

Maybe if Adora had just fucking told her sooner, this wouldn't have happened. Maybe if Adora had just trusted her, they could have figured this out together. Maybe…

She let out a high groan that was almost a yell before squeezing the handle of the nozzle, spraying a sharp spread of water into the sticky mess. It wasn't worth questioning. Adora had every right to her privacy - every right to figure this out however she wanted to. Catra just felt…

A suffocating weight settled over her chest.

She had been so bad at reading Adora at the end of their relationship. She had missed so many signs and disregarded so many of Adora's struggles. But Adora hadn't ever told her. She still didn't tell her until she physically couldn't keep it in anymore.

Catra knew now that Adora never wanted to burden her with her issues. Catra knew now that Adora hid shit from her because she didn't think Catra could—didn't *want* Catra to take on more than she had to.

But Catra was different now.

This time Adora needed her to be a support - and she would be. Catra would do whatever she could to make sure Adora knew that she could talk to and rely on her; about this. About anything.

Adora had carried her grief and expectations - heavy and burdensome - all alone for so long now.

Catra was upset. because she wanted to help. If she could do nothing more with the rest of her life than relieve some of the pressure that Adora had hauled with her from the day they had met, well.

That was clearly enough.

With a huff, Catra sprayed the water over her own legs and checked to make sure none of her clothes had anything sticky on them before wrapping up the hose and heading back up to the house. Adora was probably done by now, and Catra didn't want to stay out here long enough to let Adora think she was mad.

She hopped up the steps of the porch, pushed open the door and —

Catra's cheeks flushed with color when she came into the kitchen and her eyes landed on Adora sitting at the kitchen table;her hair was soft around her bare shoulders as she chewed on her thumbnail, body wrapped in only a definitely-too-short bath towel. She looked up, slight surprise on her face, before dropping her hand back to her lap.

"Sorry."Adora said sheepishly as she tried and failed to cover more of her thighs. "Dryer cycles.take a while."…

Catra swallowed her shock and pushed her hair back off of her face, blowing out a heavy breath. "All good."This was absolutely *not* the time for her lusty desperation to make an appearance. "How are you feeling?"

Adora watched Catra as she stepped closer, moving slowly around the back of Adora's chair. "A lot better , thanks,"she said, trying to keep her eyes on Catra even as she stood behind her. "Sorry , again, about.W ell."

Winding her fingers through Adora's hair, Catra shook her head and laughed. "Seriously , if you apologize again I'm going to kick your ass."She dragged her hand down, slowly easing apart any knots she hit before scratching her nails along Adora's scalp. This was Adora's favorite when they were kids.

The way her eyes dropped shut told Catra it was still effective.

"At least," Adora started, humming softly as Catra hit that spot behind her ear that always made her melt. "Let me pay you for the stuff I broke"…

Catra couldn't stop her eyes from rolling as she twirled golden locks between her fingers. "So you *want* your ass kicked?"

With a half-hearted scoff, Adora almost whined "that wasn't an apology!" as she twisted in her chair to look up at Catra, a small pout on her lips.

"It was apology adjacent." Catra smirked and let her hand drop to Adora's shoulder, squeezing gently. "Stop worrying about it."

Adora sighed and nodded before bringing her own hand up to settle over Catra's. "Thank you." She stroked her thumb back and forth, smiling up at Catra as her cheeks flushed just slightly. Catra's heart was pounding in her throat.

Even now, after multiple rough days and a major panic attack, everything about Adora was magnetic. She seemed to pull herself together so easily - it was honestly frightening - and now her hand was on Catra's hip, urging her to come closer as Adora sat up a little straighter and *apparently* had stopped caring about how high the hem of the towel sat on her thighs.

"You always know how to make me feel better." Her voice was barely a whisper, and Catra was hanging on to every crack and hum and pop of it. "I." She swallowed, and her gaze moved side to side to search Catra's face before her eyes scrunched with a smile as she ran a warm palm up the curve of Catra's waist. "I'm so lucky to have you."

Oh, Catra was a *goner*.

She let herself be guided to Adora's lap, her whole body sinking into the familiarity of it.

So many times - in this exact kitchen, in this exact chair, before Weaver had gotten home and they hadn't yet started their work - Adora had pulled Catra in, just like this, stroked a calloused thumb along her cheek, and kissed her. Kissed her until she was breathless. Kissed her until Weaver's car came crunching up the driveway.

But there was no threat of a car coming to force them apart.

No risk behind a kiss that could get carried away.

And…

Adora was so warm.

Damp skin and hair so supple beneath the pads of Catra's fingers as she dragged them along the planes of Adora's shoulder blades.

She was so close.

"Adora"…

Catra's voice was strained, her exhalation ghosting over Adora's lips.

Their eyes met, and their noses bumped, and, *oh* …

The moment was shattered by the sharp buzz of the dryer.

Catra fell from Adora's lap with a yelp, cheeks burning as she scrambled away along the wood floor. *Jesus Christ.*

She looked up to find that Adora had sprung up out of her chair as well, tugging the towel tighter around her body, face and chest just as bright red as Catra's were. They were *dating*. They were together! Why was an almost kiss leaving them this embarrassed?

Her eyes followed Adora as she moved towards the dryer and pulled out her clothes, careful not to bend any way that would be indecent, before hugging everything to her chest.

"So, uh," she coughed, looking anywhere but at Catra. "I was going to see if you wanted to go to the bar tonight? Lonnie's? It's a sort of club night and - I think...I think I need a drink and some loud music and...uh." Adora fumbled the clothing in her arms and scrambled to catch it, turning impossibly more red as the towel barely stayed together. "I just...I'd really like you to come with me?"

Catra's voice was tight as she squeaked out as "yeah!" before clearing her throat and trying again. "Y es. That sounds." She looked around for a second before it hit her that she was still on the floor. As she pushed herself back up, Catra nodded. "Fun. That sounds fun, yeah."

"Okay!"

"Okay , um." Catra flushed again and pointed to the stairs. "I'm just gonna...clean up really quick and change? And then"…

Adora stood straighter and pressed her lips together. "Y eah, cool. I'll just...get dressed and then...I'll." She turned to look over her shoulder and point towards the living room. "I'll wait! T ake all the time you need."

Wiping at her face and groaning, Catra moved carefully past Adora - who was completely oblivious to how much of Catra's escape she was blocking - sliding as close to the wall as she could get.

"I can't believe I agreed to this no kissing until we go on an actual date thing," Catra mumbled as she stepped past, biting back a smile as Adora snorted.

"It was your idea!"

Catra tossed her hair over her shoulder as she spun at the bottom of the staircase, a faux frown on her lips. "Hmm," she hummed. "Doesn't sound like me."

With a roll of her eyes, Adora shut the dryer with a bang. "Sure, sure. It's my fault."

"There you go." Catra smirked as she put one foot on the stairs. "And you've seen the error of your ways."

Adora barked a laugh. "Will you just go get ready?"

"Yes ma'am."

The sprint up the stairs did nothing to calm her racing heart.

Chapter End Notes

HI!!! I tried to update this as quickly as possible because I genuinely didn't realize how awful the end of the last chapter sounded until it was pointed out to me :'))))

I'm sorry that I'm an oblivious dumbass lmao.

I promise that I do my best to CW chapters and would absolutely have given a heads up for something that heavy!!!

BUT I hope y'all enjoy(?) this chapter and are sticking with me! I promise it gets better :') Adora's laid it all out now, so only one way to go, right? :D

As always, comments just make me so happy!!! I'm going to work on replying to all of last chapters ASAP, but work is busy right now and I'm Old and Tired™

Anyway!! Feel free to come hang out with me on twitter (@fistypaaants)!! (18+ Only!)

Mwah mwah thanks as always for reading!! Love u all!!

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra could feel Adora's eyes burning into the side of her face the whole drive into town, and couldn't stop the smile that tugged on her cheeks every time she looked over to catch Adora staring. Catra thought she might just catch fire under the intensity of Adora' s gaze.

"What?" Catra finally asked after the fifth time, a little laugh present in her words.

Adora just smiled bigger , looked away with a tiny hint of embarrassment, and then focused back on Catra, mumbling "you're just really pretty and I like you a lot."

Maybe she blushed - just a little bit - but Catra tried to hide it by reaching over and shoving Adora's shoulder, laughing again. "You're such an idiot."

A little hum vibrated from Adora's lips as she nodded in agreement. Her fingers were drumming against her thighs - which were horribly distracting in those tight jeans - as she looked out the window at the passing scenery.

It was fairly abnormal for Catra to be the one to drive them anywhere - even when they had been younger, Adora had been the first one with the car - but Catra had insisted on being the designated driver so that Adora could do whatever she needed to in order to feel better tonight. That clearly was leaving Adora unsure of what to do with herself on the twenty minute trip. She had put some music that Catra wasn't familiar with on, presumably to help herself stop feeling quite so antsy, but was still fidgeting around in her seat.

"So," she started, popping her lips, clearly unsure of what she was going to say. "You called me baby."

Catra felt her cheeks burn and glanced over to see that Adora looked just as shocked and embarrassed by the statement. "Well," Catra said, her fingers gripping the steering wheel a little tighter. "We're together, and I used to when you needed me to. Is it," She risked a peek at Adora, who had pressed her lips tightly together. "Is that okay?"

"Yeah! Yes!" Adora was nodding furiously as she sat forward in the passenger seat. "Yeah, of course it is. I just wasn't expecting it, I guess? But I like it." Catra could hear her picking at her nails, clearly nervous. She suspected that there was still some anxiety pumping through Adora's veins. "Can Is it okay if I?"

"You wanna call me baby?" Catra smirked, teasing.

Adora was so fucking cute, and Catra couldn't help but reach over to squeeze at Adora's arm as she stammered through her next sentence. "I mean, sometimes. Maybe. If you want me to. If that's cool."

There was a red light ahead, and Catra couldn't have been more grateful for the break so she could reach over to push Adora's loose hair behind her ear. "You can call me baby," she purred, running the pads of her fingers along golden locks. "You can call me whatever you want."

The look on Adora's face was beautiful, although almost unreadable, and Catra would have gladly spent a lifetime trying to decipher it if it weren't for the sharp honk of a horn from behind them that snapped her back to reality. They were almost to the bar anyway, and the sun was setting over the horizon, so Catra could spend the next four hours decoding every single one of Adora's micro-expressions if she wanted to.

Catra rarely came into town at night these days and it really was a sight to see;Lonnie' s bar was absolutely *packed* , with people standing out on the sidewalk smoking and talking, and colorful lights leaking out of the doors as people entered and left. This place had only opened a few years back, but there hadn't been any bars in the area for the younger crowd that chose to stick around, so it took off pretty easily. Plus, Lonnie knew how to appeal to the masses - but Catra genuinely hadn't realized that this many people even *knew* about this town, much less lived close enough to be a frequent patron.

It took a little longer than she would have liked to find somewhere to park, but Adora's hand rubbing along Catra's thigh soothed her just enough to not say fuck it and turn around. This wasn't really her scene and Catra could feel herself a little on edge already, but Adora wanted to come, and this was for Adora. Catra would do absolutely anything for her;even if that meant squeezing herself into a small bar with way too many people crowding around her.

As if she could tell that Catra was nervous, Adora didn't hesitate to grab her hand and stroke her thumb over Catra's. It instantly calmed her, and as they approached the door to see Lonnie leaning against the wall by the entrance Catra bristled under her appraising eyes. "So that' s happening again, huh?"

She pointed directly to their clasped hands and Catra flushed.

"Good for you guys. I think almost everyone was shocked when you broke up, so this isn't really all that surprising."Lonnie let out a laugh, gave Adora a little fist bump like they had in high school, and told them that the cover charge was on her tonight. "Have fun,"she taunted, grinning, as if she knew something Catra didn't.

Catra caught the tiniest blush on Adora's cheeks before she was being dragged through the door, but they didn't make it too far into the small bar before Adora pressed herself against Catra's body and brought her mouth down to Catra's ear. "Y ou wanna go to the bar first?"she asked, sending an unprompted shiver down Catra' s spine.

"Or I can just get you something if you don't want to squeeze over there."

"No," Catra started, her voice cracking as she lifted her hand up to Adora's bicep, squeezing once. "Bar sounds good. I need a minute to adjust to...everything. That okay?"

Pulling back just enough to catch Catra's eyes, Adora nodded and smiled, then gave her a hearty thumbs up. They made their way to the end of the bar and found two empty stools and quickly claimed the spot with Catra closest to the wall. Adora scraped her seat against the floor to get closer to Catra, knocking their knees together and placed a warm palm over the thin, floaty fabric of her pants. "Thanks for coming out with me," she said, her voice almost too low for Catra to catch.

"Anytime." Catra let her hand slide over Adora's on the bar, and Adora's blue eyes came up to meet hers with that *look* again, and it felt like they were in their own little bubble.

Catra liked that.

Then the bartender came around to greet them and that bubble popped quicker than it had formed.

It was that fucking girl from the fucking Farmers Market.

Catra could feel the tension rising in her throat. It wasn't like she had any reason to be jealous or insecure, because Adora immediately leaned a little closer and let her hand slide a little higher on Catra's thigh - all actions of definitive reassurance - but all Catra could think about was how flustered Adora had been that day. They were together. They were *here* together. Catra had nothing to worry about, she knew it. Adora had never, ever expressed any real interest in the stranger.

"Well, well, well," Charlie sang, leaning over the bar to place coasters by their hands. "If it isn't my favorite beefy blonde and her

little guard kitty?"

Adora's grip on Catra's thigh tightened, but she kept her face neutral. "Hey , it's good to see you," she started before lifting her hand from the bar and tapping her fingers against her chin. "It' s, uhh, Chelsea, right?"

The tiny upturn of the corner of Adora's mouth told Catra it was intentional and the red on Charlie's cheeks brought her endless delight. How could she have ever doubted Adora?

"W ell, now I see why you didn't call me." Her voice sounded strained, but she gritted her teeth and smiled out a short "good for you both." It seemed she knew there was absolutely no chance of getting any sort of lucky. She took their orders - they both decided to try some fruity little cocktail that was a specialty to the bar - and then proceeded to leave and take care of someone else.

Catra snorted and leaned closer to Adora. "She' s one thousand percent going to spit in our drinks."

"Eh," Adora shrugged, the hand above the bar moving to cover Catra's, her fingers drawing little circles over Catra's skin. "The alcohol will sterilize it I'm sure."

Soon enough they were a few drinks deep - Catra stopping after two - and Adora was very touchy when alcohol got involved, apparently. They had gone to the odd college party when Catra had visited her in the past, but she was usually a One Beer kind of girl, always afraid to fall behind on school work or at practice, so this was a new experience for Catra.

And it was driving her fucking insane.

She was positive that if they hadn't been waiting to fucking kiss, Adora would have her trapped against a wall, sucking the life from her; but for now , Adora's hands were just wandering close to dangerous places as they talked. She stroked at the bare skin of

Catra's midriff, tugged gently on her curls, traced fingers down her throat - and Catra could feel fire burning from every ghostly touch. Adora brought her lips down to brush against the curve of Catra's ear and mumbled something about dancing, and Catra was about to fucking die.

She would happily agree to anything Adora asked of her, and before she could even fully process it they were in the middle of the bar with their bodies pressed flush together as they moved in time to the pounding bass that was washing over the whole room. This might've been a mistake;if Catra could barely compose herself when just Adora's hands were on her, how the fuck did she expect to stay in control when it was her hands, and her chest, and her hips, all guiding Catra's movements, all staying aligned with her entire body.

This wasn't like the dancing in the barn.

Catra was fucking burning.

"So,"she started, trying desperately to gain some semblance of control. Catra could feel every twitch of Adora's muscles against her and took a shuddering breath as their mouths hovered barely inches apart. "Is this how you'd dance with girls at parties?"

Stupid, *stupid* .

A slight frown appeared on Adora's lips. "No,"she said, before spinning Catra out and pulling her in again, pressing her whole front tightly against Catra's back. She couldn't help but roll her hips into Adora's, groaning slightly when Adora spoke, her voice low and rasping. "I'd dance with them this way ,"she said, her breath hot on Catra's throat. Adora's hands were wandering again, and Catra leaned her head back into the crook of Adora's neck as they moved.

This was somehow even more intimate than being face to face, the way their bodies slotted together. Something unnameable stung in Catra's chest. "Why this way?"

Adora's fingers dug into the soft flesh of Catra's hips as she pulled her impossibly closer. "If I didn't look at them," Adora started, her lips sticking to Catra's jaw as she spoke. "I could pretend they were you."

Catra's breath caught in her throat, but she lifted her hands to tease at the hair at the back of Adora's skull, holding her right where she was. "How'd that work out for you?"

Adora laughed and turned her nose to rest behind Catra's ear. "Horribly . They never turned out to be you."

Turning again in her embrace, Catra slung her arms over Adora's shoulders and shivered at the way Adora's hands ran slowly over her backside before settling on her hips. "It' s me this time," Catra said as she pressed their cheeks together, her lips loosened from the warmth of the alcohol. "It will be me every time, if you want it."

"I do want it." Adora' s voice was low and a little strained, like she was holding something back. "I want you. Every time. Only you."

They stayed like that for a while, cheek to cheek, swaying too slowly to the club music, lost in their own little world. Catra felt it too heavily in her chest. She wanted this - wanted *Adora* - so much more than she could bear. She needed to lighten the mood, and quickly .

"C'mon," she started as the music picked up, leaning back and sliding her palms down the length of Adora's arms to hold her hands. "W e came here to loosen up and have a little fun, right? So let's," she paused to shake her shoulders and get Adora's body moving, "fucking *dance* ."

Adora threw her head back as she laughed, and soon enough they were practically jumping instead of dancing, twirling around as ridiculously as possible, screaming along with the music and Catra didn't even care about who could see her.

Adora shone so brightly that nothing else in the whole bar mattered.

—

Adora wouldn't stop giggling, and Catra had to admit that it was the cutest fucking thing she had ever seen.

Drunk Adora was handsy and dance-y and giggly and cuddly and all these sweet adorable things that Catra only saw when Adora was at her most uninhibited. Luckily for her, Adora was just drunk enough to be carefree and a little extra goofy, but definitely not drunk enough to not be in her right mind. She had stopped drinking about an hour and a half before they left the bar, so was easily on her way to sobering up.

"You're so pretty," she laughed, stroking her fingers against the curve of Catra's throat as she drove up the dark roads that led back to the homestead. "You got even prettier. When I left I was just. wow. Did I tell you that?"

Catra chuckled under her breath, tightened her grip on the steering wheel, and tried to make sense of the not fully logical path of Adora's sentences. "Tell me what?"

"How like, when. when I came back to ask you for the job. you were so pretty, and the sun," Adora paused to gesture widely with her hands, smacking them against the roof of the car. "Ow. Okay. The sun like. Was just going down - it's, it's what. golden hour? Yes. Golden hour. And the sun was like halo-ing you and you looked so pretty and I got back into my car and after I left I had to pull over and just take a moment to panic because oh my god you were so pretty. You got even prettier than you were in high school."

Biting her lip to stop from laughing, Catra did her best not to blush. "Oh yeah?"

"Yes. Yes! You're so pretty and I like you so much." Then, after a moment of hesitation, Adora asked, "you like me too, right?"

Catra moved her hand to rub a reassuring circle on Adora's knee. "Yes, dummy, of course I like you."

Giggling again and blowing out an overdramatized sigh of relief, Adora wiped at her forehead with the back of her hand. "Okay, phew. I was almost worried there for a sec. Not sure what I would have done if you said no."

"You're so weird."

The bounce of the dirt driveway was familiar and almost calming as Catra made quick work of parking her small car beside Adora's larger truck. The second Catra killed the engine, Adora was throwing open her door, tripping on her way out, and then scrambling over to open Catra's door for her.

"My lady," she said, her voice taking on a faux-pretentious tone as she bowed slightly at the waist and held out a hand. Catra cocked a brow and twisted herself to plant her feet onto the drive, amusement evident on her features. "May I walk you to your door?"

Catra rolled her eyes, but took Adora's offer anyway, leaning on her to stand upright. "You're sleeping here, idiot."

"Shhhh."

She couldn't help but laugh.

After maneuvering their hands so that Catra's wrist was now cradled in Adora's bent elbow, Adora began walking them towards the porch. "I had," she said, knocking her hip against Catra's. "Just the best time tonight. Thank you."

They got up the steps somewhat awkwardly, but it wasn't until they were directly in front of the door that Adora let Catra's hand go.

"Anytime."

A comfortable silence fell between them, but Catra felt a hesitation to open the door. Would stepping into the house break this little bubble they were currently in? Was there something.di.f ferent waiting on the other side? Catra didn't know, and with the way Adora was looking at her, she wasn't sure she was willing to risk finding out.

"This feels like our first date,"Adora said, holding one arm with her opposite hand, a clear shyness settling over her features.

Catra could feel her heart speeding up under her ribs. "Present first date.or past first date?"

"Past."

Oh.

"Present"…

Oh?

"Both, maybe."

Adora tapped the toes of her clunky boots behind her, making a soft bang on the wooden panels of the porch. "I mean.Our first date was that dance, right?"

"Y eah."

"And I walked you up to the door after Mara picked us up and was dropping you off"…

Catra chuckled and couldn't stop herself from twirling one curl between her fingers. "Remember how she literally turned the car around so she could pretend she wasn't watching us say goodnight?"

"That was my fault,"Adora mumbled, pink unmistakeable on her cheeks. "I told her before we picked you up that I wanted to kiss you after.So I think she was trying to be respectful"

"Oh yeah?" Catra's voice was laced with smugness, teasing and light. "You wanted to kiss me? On our first date?"

Adora stepped closer then, leaning her shoulder against the door. "I wanted to kiss you the second I learned what kissing was, and what it meant."

Running her tongue over her lips, Catra dared to move even closer. "Yeah. Weaver was out of town for the week so I remember feeling more confident about everything." Adora's chest heaved slightly with a deeper breath and Catra let her fingers tease at Adora's. "I was hoping you'd kiss me. Especially after you made me do the asking out."

"You're never, ever going to let me live that one down, huh?"

"Not a chance."

Adora's laugh was breathy and sweet as she laced their fingers together. "I know we're going to that thing this weekend but. Do you maybe"…

Oh, yes. Yes *please* . Catra was on the edge of her seat.

"Do you think this could count as a first date? Because I really wanna kiss you again." Her fingers tightened and she ducked her head just slightly . "I don't want to wait anymore."

Catra hummed for a moment, hoping to build up that tension just a little. After all the times Adora had denied her over the last week, a part of Catra just wanted to make *Adora* wait - to tease her about how yes, they had just had dinner , and drinks, and danced, and it definitely *felt* like a date - but a much, *much* larger part of her couldn't stand the thought of not kissing Adora for even one more second.

"Yes," she said, finally . "Kiss me. Please kiss me."

She could feel Adora's hand come up to cup the back of her head, fingers tangling in her curls, her other hand letting go of Catra's to circle around her waist, urging her just a little closer. She could feel Adora's warm breath as she tilted Catra's head up and lowered her own. She could *feel* Adora's heartbeat thrumming through her veins, as they grew closer, closer, closer, until -

A full body chill ran over her as everything she had ever felt for Adora reignited when their lips finally, finally met.

It was like finding herself again.

It was like coming home.

Chapter End Notes

WELL. They did it! They kissed! :') I hope it was worth the wait. Maybe. Hehe.

And the next chapter will just be a continuation of the kissing, because if you think after ALL THIS TIME I would just give you a tiny, one sentence little kiss...you're silly ;)

But it was getting REALLY long and I didn't want it to be ridiculously longer than other chapters so I decided to split it, and this was really the most reasonable spot for it! :D hope that's all right my friends.

Also, is Adora saying she had to stop on the side of the road a reference to the lovely piece Sapph and Vela did for me? ;) maybe. Maybe she's playing it off as just some gay panic, and not.well, you know .

(If you haven't read it, it should be linked at the bottom of this chapter as "works inspired by this one"or something!! Make sure you do. It's delightfully yearn-y and horny all wrapped up in one incredible piece!!)

Anyway, as always, comments make my WHOLE DAY!!! :D I'm so so far behind on replying to them but I read every single one and weep with joy at every turn!!!

Please come feel free to hang out with me on twitter (18+ only!), and chat all things she-ra with me, because this love isn't going anywhere any time soon ;)

Luv u luv u mwah mwah mwah!! xx

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

> There's some almost heavy petting in this chapter but nothing too spicy 😌

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took only about fifteen seconds of chastely pressing their lips together before they got carried away. Adora's hold on Catra tightened, her arm rucking up the back of Catra's shirt as Catra's fingers gripped almost painfully onto Adora's jaw, pulling her in, tasting every bit of alcohol that had sat on her tongue earlier in the night. Catra opened her mouth, letting their teeth clink together just slightly as Adora turned her head to get as close as she possibly could to eating Catra alive.

They parted just long enough to both take heaving breaths before joining together again, tongue tasting tongue and lips and teeth and no, this was *not* like the kiss they had shared after that first dance in high school. That was innocent, gentle, nervous - the first time. This was that, plus dating, and falling in love and hurting and breaking and missing each other for seven long fucking years. Top it off with months of pining and…

That could *almost* describe everything that Catra was experiencing.

Catra thought she might have heard some whisper of her name cross Adora's lips the next time they parted to reposition themselves, but she was *positive* that she heard a throaty groan as Adora's hands dragged down her spine and snuck under the tight hem of Catra's shirt. God. Shit.

She wrapped her arms around Adora's neck and pressed her chest closer to Adora's and the heavy wave of Adora's hips into hers forced a soft moan to slither through Catra's slightly swollen lips.

Adora had gotten better at this. Catra hated that - hated thinking about all the other girls she had kissed between their last and now - but also she couldn't help but love it when Adora nipped at her bottom lip and dragged her mouth over Catra's cheek to latch onto the sensitive spot where her jaw met her neck. Shit, shit.

Okay.

Okay .

"We," she breathed, pretending her claws weren't desperately curling into the muscle and meat of Adora's back. "Should probably go to bed."

Catra whimpered as Adora pressed closer, crowding her against the side of the house. "Bed?" Her singular word was laced with the thick weight of lust and Catra *had* to pull it together.

"To *sleep* ," she managed, squeezing her eyes closed.

Adora bit down into Catra's skin and she felt more than heard the soft whine that escaped Adora's lips; the last fucking thing she wanted to do was *stop* - but Catra knew if she didn't stop it *now* , she'd probably wind up fucking Adora to the edge of her life on her kitchen floor.

They said slow. She was going to keep it slow.

Heavy breaths ghosted over Catra's face as Adora lifted her head and dragged her hands up from where they had settled over the curve of Catra's ass. Knowing Adora, she had been about five seconds away from lifting Catra up to sit on her hips and pressing her into the wall.

About five seconds away from stripping Catra half naked and burying her face between her tits. Five seconds from that ridiculously hot mouth of hers tracing patterns over Catra's chest before dipping lower, lower -

God, she was overheating.

"Yeah," Adora said, her voice strained and tight. "Yeah, you're right. It-it's late."

Catra leaned forward to press smaller kisses against Adora's throat as she swallowed, clearly unhappy. "I don't *want* to stop," she reassured Adora, letting her mouth leave a trail of pecks up over Adora's jaw and cheek before pressing one more against her mouth. "But I think I'll get carried away if we don't."

Huffing out a short laugh, Adora nodded. "Yeah, yeah. I-Same. I think. Yeah."

As she pushed Adora's hair back off of her face, Catra couldn't help but smile as she kissed Adora again, her thumbs rubbing gently over Adora's cheekbones. These softer kisses felt just as good and as meaningful, and Catra could probably do *this* all night as well.

"I'll," Adora tried between the kisses, giggling slightly as Catra's lips popped against hers. "I'll get the couch set up."

No. No fucking way.

"Come sleep in my room."

Adora's arms tightened around Catra's waist, and Catra could feel the warmth radiating off of Adora's cheeks. "Are-Are you sure?"

God, yes, her brain was screaming as she nodded before placing another kiss against Adora's cheek. "Yeah. I'd just wind up coming down to the couch anyway - and my bed is *way* more comfortable."

"Okay," Adora smiled, and kissed Catra's lips once more. "But in that case"…

She pulled away and Catra couldn't help but watch her receding form with growing confusion. Adora hopped with joy down the steps

and back onto the drive, kicking up a soft plume of dirt. "What are you doing?"

"I'm gonna come to your window!"

What the fuck.

"... Y ou can just.walk up the stairs!"

Adora was laughing now as she jumped around the base of the largest tree on the property. Finally finding what she was looking for, Adora dug her fingers into the holds they had installed back in high school to make climbing the massive oak tree on the side of the house slightly easier.

Then, she started singing, off key and off rhythm:

"Come to my windoooow!"

"Adora!"Catra ran of f the porch as well, her hackles raised as she watched this still tipsy idiot clamber up the side of a tree.

This had sure fully sobered her up.

"Crawl inside, wait by the liiight of the moooon!"

"W eaver is not here! You can walk up the stairs!"

"No!"Adora was a little out of practice as she swung her body from the trunk of the tree across one of the thicker branches and caught the back of her boot in the gutter. She grunted with effort as she pressed her toes into the shingles to move fully to the roof. With a wobble as she stood up, Adora grinned and braced her fists hard against her hips. The moon was almost silhouetting her, and Catra had to shake herself out of getting lost in the shadow of her biceps and the curve of her hips.

"This is more fun! Now ,"she leaned over to start rapping her fist incessantly against the window of Catra's bedroom. "Will you please

come let me inside?”

Catra couldn’t help the simultaneously frustrated and endeared “oh my god” that slipped from her traitorously grinning lips as she scrambled back onto the porch, through the kitchen, and up the stairs that led to her bedroom. She glanced around quickly, mildly annoyed that it was messier than she would have liked, but as she looked over at Adora’s smiling face peering through the window, Catra found she didn’t actually care that much.

With a quick flick of her wrists, the window was open, and Adora was ducking her head under the top pane with a wide grin stretched on her lips. “Hi.”

“Hi, you’re ridiculous.”

Adora laughed again before plastering an *almost* serious look onto her features. “We can’t let Weaver know that I’m sneaking in, Catra!” Then, in a hissed whisper: “She can never know that while she was sleeping just across the hall I was tasting—”

“Oh my god,” she said again, cutting Adora off with a hand against her face. This time it was way less fond as Catra’s cheeks burned with the memory of it. “Will you just get inside?”

“Kiss me first?”

Catra was already weak in the knees. The familiarity of this - so similar to sixteen year old Adora with her new-to-her car parking a mile down the road and jogging up to the side of the house before climbing that silly oak tree that Weaver somehow never noticed the modifications to and knocking on Catra’s window - had brought her close to melting.

So Adora directly referencing their back and forth every time she did this made Catra break.

"Hey, Adora," Catra would drawl after opening the window, resting her chin in her palm.

"Hi, Catra," Adora would smile, leaning through the open frame. *"Fancy meeting you here."*

"Hmm. It's funny, I was expecting my other girlfriend."

And then Adora would scoff, and roll her eyes, and lean a little further into the room. *"Ha. Very funny. Can I come in already? It's cold out here."*

And Catra would purr, and stretch up so their noses were just a hair apart, and whisper. *"Kiss me first."*

And Adora would.

So Catra did.

It was just a little one, maybe leaning towards more heated than strictly chaste, but Adora was crawling through the window, desperate to keep her lips attached to Catra's as Catra backed up.

Until Adora got a little stuck.

Her shoulders were significantly wider than they had been back in high school, and that was causing a whole new problem.

"Shit," Adora hissed, wriggling her shoulders. "Hang on."

She pulled back out before throwing her hands forward to meet over her head, tucking her shoulders up to her ears, and practically diving through the open window frame. As she crashed to the floor with a thud - knocking down a few of Catras knickknacks - a hearty laugh burst from her mouth. "I'm okay!"

Catra's heart was hammering in her chest as she knelt down beside Adora, now a giggling heap on the floor, and shook her head, saying "you are *such* an idiot."

"Yeah but an idiot you *like*."

With a roll of her eyes, Catra leaned forward and stuck her tongue out. "I'm starting to rethink that."

"Nuh-uh. No way. You knew *exactly* what you were getting into this time." Adora's fingers circled Catra's waist and tugged her over, grinning wildly as Catra's hands were forced to press into the ground on either side of Adora's head. "You don't have any excuse. You like me. *Like* me like me."

Catra swung her knee over Adora's hips and grinned, wicked and smug, as Adora's eyes filled with surprise. "Oh yeah?" She asked, her curls falling over her shoulder to curtain them. "If I liked you, would I do this?"

Then her fingers were burrowing into Adora's sides, teasing at all the spots she knew Adora was most ticklish, and Adora was wheezing laughing, her palms pressing uselessly at Catra's thighs. Her laughter was absolutely contagious as she sucked in short, rapid breaths through the uncontrollable giggling. "Okay!" She yelled as Catra's fingers slithered up to dig under her armpits, causing a whole new eruption of laughter. "Mercy!"

As Catra let her hands settle back onto the ground on either side of Adora's torso, she felt a hot blush rising to her cheeks. Watching Adora calm down from her most hysterical laughter had always warmed Catra up from the inside out; the way her cheeks were stretched in a smile and how her squinting eyes had tiny tears welled up at the corners of them while a flush of pink dusted over her nose as she sighed and *whew*ed in relief all coiled together around Catra's heart and dragged her right back into Adora's orbit.

She kissed her again.

A little surprised squeak popped from Adora's lips before it settled into a softer hum, and her hands came up to hold either side of

Catra's face. Adora slid her ring and pinky fingers behind Catra's ears and stroked softly, eliciting a rumbling purr from her chest.

"I missed this," Adora mumbled against her lips. "I missed you."

"I missed *you*." Catra pulled back slowly and brushed their noses together before frowning, her hands dragging down Adora's chest. "Do you need pajamas?"

Adora's mouth contorted as she crunched up just enough to look down at her own body, nodding. "I mean, I think sleeping naked or in just our underwear might make the whole no sex thing a little more difficult." Then, with a snort, she added "easy access."

Well. She wasn't *wrong.*

Pushing off of Adora's chest, Catra stood and reached her hand down to help Adora up. "I don't think anything I have will fit you anymore," she said, tapping at her bottom lip. "But W eaver might have had something that will." Catra pointed to the door , shrugging. "Feel free to raid her stuf f."

Adora gave her a strange look that she couldn't read, but Catra simply averted her eyes and moved to dig through her own dresser. Adora mumbled something about giving her privacy before exiting Catra's bedroom and shutting the door behind her, and Catra took full advantage of the moment of solitude.

Every nerve under her skin was on fire, and she needed to put it out *now* .

A heavy sigh passed through her lips, and Catra started to bounce on her toes and shake out her arms as she took in the most calming breaths she could manage. She worked quickly to get dressed as the sounds of Adora banging through Weaver's old dresser ceased, presumably meaning she was nearly done getting changed.

The knock on Catra's door confirmed that.

"Just one more second," she hollered, stripping quickly out of her tight shirt and nice pants and into a pair of torn up sweats and… what she has just now realized is one of Adora's old practice t-shirts.

Oh well.

Catra took three large steps over to her door and swung it open, eyes widening in surprise at the sight before her.

She *hated* how much this enamored her.

Adora stood with one elbow propped against the wall, an eyebrow cocked as she gestured up and down her figure suggestively. "Real sexy, huh?" She asked, grinning.

Draped over her body with no more shape than a potato sack was the ugliest nightgown Catra had *ever* seen - and she had definitely never seen her foster mother wear it before. It was pink and frilly with ribbons on the shoulders and puffy sleeves that cinched at the wrists. The hem went down to an awkward length that wasn't quite to Adora's ankles, and the whole thing was embroidered with roses. It *clearly* must have been a gift from someone who hadn't known Weaver well at all.

"I saw the tags still on it and decided I'd rather wear something she never had so." Adora shrugged and pulled at the fleece like fabric. "The upside is that I'm sure this wipes the idea of sex right of f the table."

Catra snorted and turned on her heel, flopping down onto the bed. She didn't want to admit that even that monstrosity hadn't made her want Adora any less, but it would definitely make it easier to *resist* .

"Come on, granny ."

With a soft laugh, Adora crawled into the bed beside her, flicking off the lamp that sat on the nightstand as she did. They were face to

face, and Adora shimmied her shoulders down to snuggle further under the comforter.

"Hi," she whispered, her fingers playing with Catra's under the covers.

"Hi," Catra whispered back, scooting just a little closer. "How are you feeling?"

Adora's smile was definitely sitting somewhere between happy and sad, but she shrugged anyway. "Better, thanks to you." One hand emerged from the warmth of their cocoon to tuck a loose strand of Catra's hair behind her ear. "I really am sorry for putting you out."

"I meant it when I said I'll kick your ass if you apologize anymore." Catra's gaze darted up and down Adora's face as she smirked. "Don't forget I was a pretty big jock, too."

"Oh, I definitely haven't forgotten that," Adora said as sneaky hands slid up the length of Catra's still-toned arms, squeezing once at her bicep. "You could kick my ass any day of the week."

Catra leaned forward to bump their noses together before whispering a cocky little "you're damn right" as she kissed Adora again - she still couldn't get enough - and moved her hands to settle on either side of Adora's neck. A little whimper came from deep inside Adora's throat, and Catra couldn't help but revel in it.

It was satisfying to know Adora was just as much of a puddle under Catra's touch as she was under Adora's.

Warm hands settled on the small of Catra's back and pulled her closer. As their chests pressed together, their lips grew needier and messier and soon Catra's fingers were tangled in Adora's hair to make sure she couldn't leave this perfect spot. Catra felt the pressure of Adora's hands gripping her ass, and all rational thought went right out the window. How had she stopped this before? Was the chilly evening air enough of a deterrent?

Because here, in her warm bed, where they had done this countless times before, Catra was certain she couldn't stop it again. Not while Adora's mouth was so soft and giving;not while her little breaths and qiet moans were so enticing.

Adora's hips rolled against her and fuck fuck *fuck* , Catra wanted to help - wanted to give Adora everything.

She moved her knee, desperate to get it between Adora's perfect thighs until - by the grace of god or the devil himself - the world's ugliest nightgown made it impossible to do without making more conscious decisions.

"Fuck."

Adora's whole body shook with frustrated, qiet laughter . "Okay . We" she shoved her forehead against the crook of Catra' s neck and took in three deep breaths. "W e're obviously.feeling a lot right now."

A bittersweet laugh burst from Catra's lips. That was an understatement.

"Why don't we… *really* go to sleep, and we can" Adora lifted her head to meet Catra's eyes as she stroked a soft thumb over her cheek. "W e can have an *actual* conversation about how we want to handle this in the morning?"

Logical, problem solving Adora shows her face again.

Catra nodded and sighed, pressing her forehead against Adora's. "Ah, there' s the smarty pants I missed so much."

Adora snorted, and pressed a very, *very* fleeting kiss against Catra's lips. "Y ou wanna be big or little spoon?"

The thought of her ass against Adora's crotch or vice versa sent a chill down Catra's spine and she shook her head;neither of those

would give her even the slightest chance of falling asleep. With a hand on Adora's shoulder, Catra pushed just enough to get Adora to lay on her back. Cuddling up against her side, Catra smiled when Adora's arm that laid under Catra's body came up to stroke at her messy curls. She nuzzled her nose into the curve of Adora' s throat, and they settled in.

"I hate that nightgown," Catra said, her ear locking in on the steady drum of Adora's heart.

"Same," Catra heard muttered back as the soft rhythm below her and the slow strokes of gentle fingers over her skin lulled her quickly to sleep.

—

The sun kissing Catra's eyelids was what woke her up.

She sat up with a start, panic rising in her chest;the sun was *never* up before her. Shit. How on earth did she oversleep this badly? Her alarm must not have gone off. Useless piece of trash!

Adora was probably already here and working —

As her gears finally started turning, grinding off the rust of sleep, Catra remembered that Adora had spent the night again. Here. In her bed. Catra turned at the waist to pat at the empty spot beside her before her eyes landed on a little folded piece of paper sitting on the bedside table.

Her name was scribbled in Adora's messy but legible handwriting with a tiny little heart doodled at the end, and Catra couldn't help the smile that pulled on her lips as she unfolded it.

Good morning!I shut off your alarm so you could sleep in.I hope you slept in late enough for me to finish all the morning work because I don't want you nagging me or trying to do it yourself)

♡

A

Warmth flooded through her as Catra slid the paper delicately between her fingers. Perfect, sweet Adora. Catra remembered all the mornings in high school when Adora would sneak back out of her window before the sun came up and leave little love notes hidden for Catra to find as she got ready for the day.

They were all still in a box somewhere around here.

She never could find it in herself to get rid of anything Adora had given her.

Her ear twitched as Catra heard the door from the porch into the kitchen knock shut - more quietly than normal, meaning Adora was being intentionally considerate - and Catra pushed the blankets off of her body. Getting dressed was an option, but if Adora was aiming for her to have a lazy day, she was damned well doing it in her pajamas.

Padding out of the bedroom and down the stairs as softly as she could manage, Catra felt a childish glee wash over her when she realized that Adora still hadn't heard her by the time she reached the kitchen. Two steps, three, and one graceful leap until her arms were circling around Adora's shoulders and her legs around her waist as Catra purred a "Hey, Adora" into the skin at the base of Adora's neck.

"Holy fuck," Adora hissed as she jumped, hands immediately dropping the box of vegetables she had been holding. She took in a large gulp of air before her arms swung backwards to hook under Catra's thighs, thumbs rubbing against the fabric of her sweatpants. "Good morning," Adora managed - finally - turning her head back far enough for Catra to place a wet kiss against her cheek. "About time you got up, lazy."

"Don't even start."There was a laugh in Catra' s voice as she hopped off of Adora's back and leaned up against the counter next to her. Adora had clearly been up and working for quite some time, and there was soil smudged on her forehead that Catra found beyond cute. "Thanks for letting me sleep,"she said as she reached up to dust it from Adora's skin.

Adora's expression was warm and soft as she said "anytime," but it still made Catra's heart start to thunder under her ribs. She didn't stand a chance. She knew how quickly she was going to tumble right back into everything had always felt for Adora, and…

It was still frightening. There was still such a chance for heartbreak. She wanted to try, wanted to trust and be vulnerable to all of it;but a huge, hardened part of her was painfully cautious.

Adora leaned down to kiss her, smiling all the way, and Catra felt it soften just a little.

"What would you like for breakfast?"Adora asked as she pulled back, Catra's fingers lingering on her jaw. "We still have some of that bread from Spinny's. I could do some French Toast or something?"

Honestly, Catra couldn't care less about the details;waking up to this sweet domesticity with Adora was all she had ever dreamt about. Maybe that made her cheesy or soft, but fuck it.

"That sounds great."

Adora seemed to hesitate for a moment, her eyes darting down Catra's frame before a smirk spread across Adora's lips. She leaned down to kiss Catra once, twice, a third time before standing up taller and stretching to pull what she needed to cook out of the cabinets. "Still wearing my shirts, huh?"

Heat rose to Catra's cheeks and she crossed her arms over her chest. "This shirt became mine the second you left here without it." And, when Adora turned to face her with a cocked eyebrow, Catra

couldn’t stop herself from blowing a raspberry. Too much of their lives had been interwoven that it had become almost impossible to separate everything from Adora - but maybe she had kept *some* things on purpose.

A comfortable silence fell over them for a while, the only sounds in the house were the clanking of pots and pans, the soft swishing of eggs being mixed with milk and cinnamon sugar, and the hiss of the French toast hitting the hot griddle. Catra had offered to help, but Adora refused and insisted she just make herself a cup of coffee and relax. It wasn’t until two hot plates of sweet bread and syrup were on the table that Adora spoke again.

“So about sex.”

Catra snorted, shocked by the blunt introduction of this conversation, but covered it with a little cough. “Yeah?” She let her eyes linger on Adora, whose cheeks were burning pink as she kept her gaze locked on the floor.

“I was really caught up in it last night but, um”…

Why was she so nervous?

“I just, um, I think I need to wait?”

That wasn't what Catra had been expecting. It was fine, of course, but unexpected. “Yeah, of course we can.”

“I just haven’t” Adora’s cheeks burned brighter and Catra set her fork down on her plate before reaching out to lay her hand over Adora’s wrist. “This is so stupid I’m sorry.”

Catra shook her head with a frown and propped her chin up on top of her free hand. “You don’t need to explain. I think waiting is good. I think we should try to make sure that this whole thing works first?” She still wasn’t sure what exactly was making Adora so flustered -

she had said herself that she had been pretty active after they broke up.

"No, no. I.want to."Adora caught her bottom lip between her teeth and shrugged. Catra gave her her full attention. "So I just.um."

Catra stayed quiet, and waited patiently .

Adora took in a deep breath, holding it for a second before blurting out, in one rambling sentence: "I haven't really let anyone touch me since you so I'm just a little freaked out by it now because I'm not even sure if I like it so now I'm just freaking out a little because I used to like it when *you* did it but then whenever I hooked up with other girls I hated even the thought of them touching me so I never let them and now I'm wondering if I just don't like it or if I only like it when it's you but I'm scared of trying and finding out that I actually don't like it at all and disappointing you and ruining this."

When she finished, Adora practically gasped for air, cheeks burning red as she pressed her lips together and drew her brows in tightly, her forehead creasing with worry.

All Catra could do was stare as her brain processed everything that was just said to her in an almost unintelligible fashion.

"Oh god I'm so sorry this is so stupid."

Okay.

"I definitely don't hate *everything* like everything we did last night was so good and a huge part of me is sure I'm still going to like it because it's *you* ."

Okay.

"But I'm not one hundred percent sure and it' s okay if that's a deal breaker for you I would completely understand and "—

"Adora,"Catra said, cutting of f her rambling.

Adora clamped her mouth shut and began to clench and unclench her fists on the table. "Yeah?"

Taking a breath, Catra began rubbing her hands up and down Adora's forearms, waiting for her fists to relax. "It's not even close to a deal breaker, okay?" She watched as Adora pressed her lips together. "I'm serious. Whatever you like or don't like is okay with me. We can do as much or as little as is enjoyable for you."

Those sweet blue eyes were wet and shining, and Catra couldn't resist pulling Adora's knuckles to her lips and pressing a reassuring kiss to them. "I mean it. We can take it slow - I think that's a good idea anyway - and try things if you're up for it, or never at all. I just…" She hesitated, but then said, "I just want *you*. So nothing about you could ever be a deal breaker."

Shit.

That felt pretty close to one of those Grand Declarations they had agreed were off the table for now.

Oh well.

Catra could not find a single fuck to give when Adora leaned over the table out of her chair, hands grasping at Catra's jaw to pull her in for another kiss; messier and more emotional than others from this morning. She could taste the sticky sweet maple syrup on Adora's lips and tongue and - as the kiss grew deeper - Catra let her fingers slide up to grasp firmly at the collar of Adora's shirt. Her heart began racing, a heavy *ba-bump, ba-bump, ba-bump* echoing in her ears as she realized how far gone she already was.

God damn it.

When she finally pulled away, Adora whispered "you're amazing" and "what did I do to deserve you?" and Catra resisted telling Adora that respecting her boundaries and limits was probably the bare fucking minimum she could do.

Instead she left one more soft peck against Adora's lips and smiled, pointing at her plate. "You should eat."

Adora sat back with a grin and lifted a fully loaded fork to her lips, biting down happily on the now a little soggy French toast. She hummed around her food the way she has since she was a little kid, her shoulders bouncing in an almost sort of dance as she enjoyed every bite of her breakfast.

She was the most wonderful thing Catra had ever seen.

She couldn't stop watching.

"So I wanted to ask about another thing," Adora said, breaking the almost silence.

Catra mumbled a noise that indicated Adora could go on as she bit down into her own toast. It was almost a little too sweet for her, but she could practically taste the care that went into it.

Tapping her index finger against the table, Adora continued. "So, uh, why have you stayed in your tiny tiny room when the master bedroom is, like, three times the size with that huge walk-in closet and bathroom?"

After a moment, Catra said, deadpanned, "because it was Weavers'," as if that is enough of an explanation.

"Can't you just...redecorate?"

Redecorating wouldn't hide all the ugly bits of Weaver that still clung to the darkest corners of this house. Redecorating wouldn't pull the echoes of her words out of the walls that had bore witness to some of Catra's worst nights. Redecorating wouldn't be enough for Catra to feel comfortable in that room.

"My bedroom is fine."

The mood in the kitchen had completely shifted.

Catra felt itchy.

Adora's eyes were on her, and Catra felt *itchy.*

It wasn't until Adora's hands were pulling Catra's away from her own arms that she even noticed the red marks on her skin;luckily not deep enough to bleed, but Adora's eyes were still drowning in worry.

"Catra..you should make this whole house yours. Make it liveable. I've noticed there are a few rooms you kind of hesitate to go into… but you seemed like you couldn't even stand the *thought* of going into that bedroom."

Adora's palms were rubbing soothingly up and down up and down up and down Catra's arms, her back, and Catra hardly noticed that she was being held until she had to bite back a shiver when Adora's breath ghosted over her skin.

"Let me help."

Catra was fine.

She has lived in this house for most of her life. She was fine.

She had worked through this with her therapist, with her friends, and she was *fine* .

"How would you help?"

But maybe she wasn't. At least not one hundred percent.

Adora - apparently now kneeling on the floor in front of her - pulled back with a grin. "W ell I've been learning some carpentry stuff working on Raż s house, and if you're okay with possibly dealing with me still learning things and maybe taking longer than a professional would, I could make any room whatever you want it to be."

Catra's shoulders relaxed as a soft laugh escaped from between her lips. "You want to tear my house apart?"

"What you call tearing apart," Adora said conspiratorially as her hands braced on the chair on either side of Catra's thighs, "I call trying new things until I get the desired result."

It might not be the *worst* idea. Catra reached forward to tuck some strands of hair that had escaped Adora's bun back behind her ear before running her palm down Adora's cheek. "I mean it's hard to say no to the possibility of getting to watch you do incredibly hot manual labor."

Adora rolled her eyes and sat up a little higher on her knees, bringing their faces closer to eye level. "Let me just do the master bedroom first. You already don't go in there so if you hate it, no loss, right?" Her hands had found their way to Catra's thighs and were rubbing absentmindedly against her sweatpants. "I can put in a big bay window like you always wanted -"

Oh. She remembered.

"And I'll make those super neat built-in shelves for your books. We can totally remodel the closet and even the bathroom - though I might need help with that part. But...whatever you want."

The expression on Adora's face was stunning, and Catra wanted to kiss her again.

"I'll do my best to make it exactly what you want."

So she did.

"Okay," she mumbled against Adora's lips. "Make me my dream home, Noah."

Adora pulled back, an eyebrow cocked in confusion, and snorted. "Noah? What's that a reference to?"

Oh Jesus Christ.

"Nothing," Catra snapped, her cheeks glowing pink. "I didn't say Noah. Weirdo."

Adora snorted as something clicked in her head. "Wait, is that the guy in The Notebook? The movie you whined and moaned about going to but then cried so hard at all your eye makeup came off?"

"Shut up!"

"Oh my god you're such a *girl*," Adora teased with such lightness that Catra couldn't have taken offense if she tried. "You want the romantic dream house built by your lover, huh? Do you want to be kissed in the rain, too?"

Catra leapt forward and out of her seat then, pinning Adora to the cool tile floor as she practically lost it giggling and snorting at *everything* happening right now. "I'm going to leave you if you don't stop," Catra said, her voice softer than she thought it would be.

"Noooo," Adora whined as overdramatically as she could manage. "Then what self-taught carpenter will make your house your *home*?"

"I hate you."

"I think you *like* me, actually."

A groan vibrated in Catra's throat as she stood up with a smile she couldn't stop on her lips, and she poked her toes into Adora's side as her laughter finally started to calm down. "You're *such* an idiot."

"Yeah, I know."

She obviously *liked* her.

She probably already…

Catra swallowed against the lump in her throat and held out a hand, urging Adora to take it and get up off the floor. "C'mon. The work isn't going to do itself."

"A ye, aye, captain!" Adora's hand was warm in hers as she heaved herself up off the floor and left one tiny little kiss against Catra's palm. "See you out there."

Ah, shit.

Chapter End Notes

Hi friends I'm back! Hopefully the longer chapter will make up for the longer update break :)

I'll probably continue with longer chapters from now on because this fic has too many chapters that I could have combined 😂

ANYWAY they're in love ur honor I'm not sure what else to say about it 🥰

I hope you enjoy!!! As always comments make my whole day ily all sm!!!! 🥰

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra was late.

She was so late, and Scorpia was probably already at her house unhappily tapping her toes and feeling like Catra had let her down *again* . Catra had promised weeks ago that she would help out with some last minute wedding details and she had actually been genuinely excited for it! Figure the day she actually had plans to get to, her monthly trade with the apiary would take four times as long as normal.

He was a sweet guy but damn he could *not* do anything right.

So now she was pushing her prius to its breaking point, driving way over the speed limit and waving semi-apologetically to everyone she zoomed past on these quiet back country roads just in the hopes of making sure Scorpia would be a little less upset with her when she saw how hard Catra had been trying to get home. Her tires kicked up a plume of dirt as she turned sharply into the driveway, and she slammed on her brakes just in time to not hit any of the parked cars at the end.

Wait.

Her eyes landed on Scorpia *and* Adora's cars, and she felt her heart stop. Catra wasn't ready for these worlds to collide yet;Scorpia knew too much and, god love her, could not keep her mouth shut if her life depended on it. Shit.

"Meet cute! Like you'd never seen!"Scorpia's voice carried down through the open screen door. "She was just beautiful!"

Before Catra could get into the house, the door was kicked open from the inside, and Adora came backing out slowly, strong hands clasped around the base of a dresser, flexing with every movement. "That sounds amazing!" There was a slight strain in Adora's voice - likely from the fact that she was carrying a heavy piece of furniture - as she turned her head to check where she was stepping. "Oh, hey Catra!"

"Catra's home?!" Scorpia hollered, excitement evident in the pitch of her voice.

The dresser slipped slightly, and Adora winced under the change of weight. "Hey, hey, let's just get this out to the barn and then we can both give Catra the welcome she deserves, yeah?"

"Aye, aye captain!"

Catra blinked in near disbelief as her worlds came crashing together; she had feared the worst, but apparently all she had to worry about was potential damage to her porch. They scurried along, both offering cheesy little smiles as they passed, before disappearing into the barn. A small *thud* echoed from the empty building, and soon enough they emerged again, Scorpia's elbow nudging into Adora's side as she laughed.

The warm golden sun haloed Adora, and Catra found herself practically swooning at the sharp angle of her cheekbone, the cut line of her jaw, the soft pink plushness of her lips;but she kept it together. Sort of. Barely. At the very least she managed not to pounce on Adora with Scorpia watching.

She did, however, purr a far too flirty "hey, Adora," as she stepped forward, wrapped her arms around Adora's neck, and placed a firm kiss against her lips. She could feel the way Adora's body relaxed under her touch. "I can't believe you put the bride-to-be to work."

Scorpia let a *pshh* hiss through her lips as she dropped a pincer down in an almost *don't even worry about it* motion, and said "I'm

always glad to help! Adora told me she's going to remodel some parts of the house for you? That's so awesome!"

Gentle hands were pulling Catra closer as she turned to face Scorpia again, and Catra almost lost herself in the overwhelming scent that was always distinctly Adora's. "Yeah, it's nice having a personal handyman around," Catra teased, her grin widening as Adora pressed a kiss to her cheek. "Way cheaper than hiring someone."

She did her best to ignore the joy that was fucking sparkling in Scorpia's eyes at the sight of Adora being so aggressively affectionate with her, and poked a nail to the middle of Adora's forehead. "But she wasn't supposed to work today."

"Well I thought you'd be gone already when I got here," Adora said, pouting just slightly. "But *someone* was running late."

"Yeah, go take it up with Me."

A belly laugh and a sigh came from all three of them in almost unison, and as she let her gaze drift between her two favorite people, Catra felt so full of love she could burst. Who the fuck was she? Some sort of sap? Christ.

"I am sorry for being late though." Catra tried - although not very hard - to get out of Adora's embrace, but let out a soft grunt as she was pulled back tightly to Adora's chest. So she wasn't going anywhere yet, then. Not that she minded.

"It's all good, Wildcat! I had given us enough time to get lunch before the appointments so we're not late for anything!"

Catra's stomach growled on cue and Adora let out a soft snicker behind her.

"Plus, Adora was just so darn sweet and packed us some lunches, too!" Scorpia was all over eager gestures and excitement and pure,

unadulterated joy as she started recalling the last hour and a half of her and Adora's first meeting.

To Catra's relief it didn't sound like anything too embarrassing had come up, but you never could be too sure with Scorpia. She just got here, saw Adora making eighty trips up and down the stairs to bring the furniture down piece by piece, and couldn't bear to watch that go on any longer.

"So then, I guess you know the rest is history! W e're best buds now, right Adora?"

Adora grinned and nodded, tucking her chin over Catra's shoulder. "Oh, definitely . Though, honestly,,"her voice wavered for a second, but she laughed it off. "I was pretty sure you would hate me."

A scoff blew through Scorpia's lips before she pressed them together and sighed. "Okay , if I'm being honest I kinda thought that, too."

Catra winced.

"But only because of how much my bestie was hurting back then!" Scorpia came closer to them and wrapped her arms around both of their bodies in one bone crushing hug. "But if she loves you, then I love you!"

She winced again. They hadn't used that word yet - at least not this time around - but Scorpia could read her too well and a boiling worry came rushing through her veins that Adora would think that Catra had said something she hadn't. She could hear Adora's nervous laughter bubbling up behind her as Scorpia finally let them go.

"Plus you're just so darn nice. No wonder they call you *Adore* -a," Scorpia said, a little laugh in her words.

"Ah, never heard that one before,"Adora deadpanned, finally letting Catra out of her embrace. "Though it' s usually not that complimentary."

Scorpia gasped, her pincers rising to her cheeks. "How could it not be complimentary! Oh, people are just so rude for no reason! I mean look at what you're doing!" She gestured wildly back up towards the house. "Remodeling by yourself just to give our Wildcat the best? Only a saint would do that!"

It looked like Adora was going to protest, but Scorpia just kept going.

"And God knows she deserves it! Catra worked so hard for this house and she should have the house of her dreams!"

Catra was flushed now, completely embarrassed as a low murmur of Scorpia's name rumbled from her chest.

"All the hours worked at Raz's and the corner store and how she made out so well after leaving to be on her own!" Scorpia placed her pincers on her hips, pride radiating off of her. "Especially considering the like, what was it, Wildcat? Nine months? Of bouncing from car to motel to car to motel while she saved up money because she didn't want anyone to worry about her! Gosh."

Adora's hands loosened around Catra's hips.

Fuck.

"She's just awe—"

"Okay! Well that's enough doting on me," Catra cut in, making it a point to avoid even glancing in Adora's direction. Catra did *not* want to know how Adora was reacting to this new information. "We really need to get going."

She did her best to usher Scorpia to their cars without stopping, but god fucking damnit she couldn't leave without saying goodbye.

After Scorpia got into her car and started the engine, Catra spun around to see that Adora had turned some sort of ghostly white with

a crease between her brows as her brain was clearly trying its best to process what had just been said. "Hey, you good?"

Blue eyes snapped up to meet her gaze, and Adora frowned. "Uh, yeah. What is she talking about?"

Adora couldn't just drop anything, could she?

"We can talk about it when I get back, okay?"

"I didn't know that. Why didn't I know that?"

Reaching up to cup Adora's cheeks, Catra could feel Adora's jaw clenching beneath her fingers. "Because I didn't tell you. I promise we can talk about it tonight. Okay? It's not a big deal, and it was years ago, so please do not let this ruin your day."

After a few moments of her eyes darting back and forth across Catra's face, Adora sighed, nodded once, and smiled as she leaned down to kiss Catra softly on the lips. "Okay. I'll be here when you get back. Go have fun."

Catra couldn't help but hesitate; she knew the gravity of this. She knew how Adora would feel about her keeping it a secret. She knew Adora, and Catra was afraid that she would spend the whole day stewing on how it possibly could be her fault.

But, as if she could read Catra's mind, she wrapped her fingers around Catra's and brought their hands down and said, "Really, it's fine. Go on! You can't keep the bride waiting!" She threw a thumb over her shoulder and shrugged. "I'm just gonna keep emptying that room." She was clearly trying to keep her tone light, but there was definitely a note of underlying *something*. "All by myself. Because I'm strong."

Catra snorted, and patted her hands against Adora's upper arms. "Okay Hercules, I'll be thinking about your strong arms all day."

"God, that was what I wanted," Adora smirked. "Also I'll be doing lots of lifting from my legs too. So. You know."

With a playful roll of her eyes, Catra reached up to kiss Adora again, and her whole body relaxed as Adora started to pepper silly, sweet pecks across her lips and nose and cheeks, even as Catra grumbled feigned annoyance. "See you later," Adora said with a smile, and squeezed Catra's hands gently.

Okay. It was going to be okay. She turned and quickly hopped into the passenger seat of Scorpia's SUV, waving goodbye as they drove away.

Somehow Adora still managed to make her feel like she had butterflies in her stomach. It was ridiculous. And childish. And stupid. And Catra jumped slightly when Scorpia finally spoke.

"Okay. So," Scorpia started, biting her bottom lip. "It doesn't look like Adora knew that. I am *so* sorry if I caused any problems!"

"It's okay, Scorp." Catra reached over to pat a hand against her friend's pincer. "I should have told her anyway, really." She thought she would be more worried about this, but Adora had seemed to handle it all right.

Scorpia hummed a little noise in the back of her throat before saying "okay, if you're sure," and reached over to flip on the radio. Catra knew her best friend wanted to talk more about it, but she was grateful that their many conversations about letting Catra lead conversations about her issues had stuck.

Besides, it wasn't like she would have *never* told Adora about it. It just hadn't come up yet. And how do you drop something like that out of the blue?

Oh yeah, remember when you came back to talk after we broke up and Weaver said I was gone? Yeah I was living in a super shitty motel or my car maybe but was too proud to tell you. Surprise!

No way. Not to mention with all the extra shit Catra had learned about Adora recently, she knew Adora would one hundred percent blame herself. So, no. Catra hadn't told her that she had chosen to take a risk and potentially be homeless. She had done just fine and worked her ass off and had managed the situation just fine on her own.

This was *not* a big deal.

Catra caught sight of the corner store and frowned. Shit. How long had she been in her own head?

"So," she started, breaking the slight tension in the SUV. "What's on the agenda today for our blushing bride?"

Scorpia laughed and literally blushed as she took one glance over towards Catra. "Final dress fitting is the biggest thing. Gotta swing by Starlight to give them payment for the rehearsal dinner - you're still coming to that right? - oh! And the printer just finished all of our table cards! Would you be able to help me finalize the seating chart today, too? I think we have all the RSVPs.except actually you haven't told me if Adora is coming? I made her a table card and a favor bag just in case, but let me know! I think Per got the license on Friday.oh and we gotta get the rings! Or well, mine's a bracelet because, you know, pincers, but it's gorgeous!"

Fuck. She still hadn't asked Adora. Catra made a mental note to do that when she got home.

"Okay," she said, tucking all of the upcoming events of the day into a mental list. "One, can't wait to see your dress. Two, of course I can help with the seating chart. Third, regarding Adora." Catra paused and let out one soft laugh. "I forgot to ask her. But I'm sure she'll come."

The car slowed to a stop as they pulled into the parking lot of what looked like a print shop, and Scorpia shook her head. "You guys are like actually a couple now, right? I mean I assumed so with how

affectionate you were being but I figured I should ask so I don't make it any weirder just in case."

Catra ran her fingers through her curls and groaned. "Did I seriously not tell you that?" She blew out a breath and sighed. "God, I'm sorry . I've been a bit absent lately, huh."

A dismissive scoff burst from Scorpia's lips, but Catra knew better.

"Yeah, we had a conversation to start actually dating again a few weeks ago? So it hasn't been *that* long." Damn it, she needed to stop trying to make herself feel better, and just accept that she had been a shitty friend for a bit, and just start being *better* . "So I think she'll rise up to the role of the dutiful girlfriend and come to the wedding, no problem."

"Great!"

Scorpia was practically falling out of the car in excitement, bouncing on her toes as she looked eagerly over to Catra's side of the car. Oh. Right. Friends go in to help.

Catra shot her friend an apologetic smile before hopping out as quickly as possible and following her into the shop.

It was a cute little boutique - definitely wedding and other big events focused - and Catra was surprised she had never noticed it before. Well, she supposed she had never done anything fancy enough to have stuff printed for. Maybe she should.

"Scorpia!" a voice called from behind a curtain, before an older woman with dark mauve hair and the brightest eyes Catra had ever seen appeared. She wasn't familiar to Catra, but Scorpia greeted her with a hug. Scorpia greeted almost everyone with a hug, though, so it might not have meant much.

"Hi Marge! I'm here to get the place cards? Well, you probably know that," she babbled as she let the woman go. "I'm just so darn excited

to see them finished!"

Marge simply laughed and said "of course, of course!" before scurrying back behind the curtain and almost immediately returning with a box that seemed way too large to hold just table cards. "All three hundred, plus the extras, and some variations that you had requested."

"Three hundred?" Catra asked, wide-eyed. She hadn't had a clue that it was going to be this large of a reception. "You know that many people?"

Scorpia laughed and shook her head. "No, no. My guest list is only about fifty or so of them. Perfuma, however, has lots and lots and lots of family and friends and we gave everyone a plus one! And some had families. So it wound up being a lot!"

There was a bit of a strained expression on her face. Scorpia loved people, but she didn't really love *crowds* .

"But the more the merrier , right?" Marge offered, a hopeful smile on her face. "You can all dance the night away!"

"Yes of course!"

Catra couldn't imagine having to host that many people - god, she couldn't even imagine liking that many people. And as much as this wasn't about her, Catra couldn't help the dread that dripped down her spine knowing that she was going to have to stand in front of that many people and give a toast in front of that many people and she was just grateful that she'd most likely have Adora.

"Yeah, it's going to be so fun," Catra tried, smiling as best as she could. Scorpia could probably see the agony in her features, but at least she might appreciate that Catra was *trying* .

With a few more words of congratulations, Scorpia and Catra were back in the car and onto the next place, and the next place, and

Scorpia's excitement only continued to grow, reaching an all-time high as they pulled up in front of the dress shop;she was practically bouncing out of her skin as they pulled open the door.

From the second they stepped into the boutique, everything became a whirlwind of fabric and jewelry and overly sweet pleasantries, and before Catra could even register what had happened, she was sitting in a chair with a glass of champagne in her hand as she listened to Scorpia and the saleswomen chittering behind the changing room wall.

Suddenly a curtain flew open, and the saleswoman was wearing a smug little smirk as she held the fabric behind her back. "Are you ready to see the most beautiful bride in the whole world?"

Catra couldn't help the grin that stretched on her cheeks. "I'm dying waiting."

"Come on out, love!"

She saw a pincer first, then a sleeve that slowly faded from red up to white, as if to mimic and extend the blend of colors that existed on Scorpia's arms seamlessly into the dress. As she stepped further out, Scorpia pressed against the fabric, tracing her curves. It was sleek and fitted, with a neckline that plunged deep down on her chest. The saleswoman ushered her to the stand in the middle of the room, and Catra was truly at a loss for words.

She had never seen anyone happier.

"Wow, Scorpia." was all she could manage as her best friend turned on the platform, revealing the slit in the skirt that ran high up on her thigh, and an open back that emphasized her broad, strong physique. Scorpia always had always known how to balance classy and sexy, and this was no exception. "I mean...holy shit."

Scorpia was bright pink as she checked out her reflection. Shrugging and picking up the hem with her claws, she asked, "yeah? You think

so?"

With a smile reserved for only the most special of people, Catra stood and made her way closer to the mirrors. She watched as Scorpia rubbed at her elbow, embarrassed, and finally said "fuck yes, Scorp. Perfuma is going to lose her mind when she sees you."

"A w, jeez." Scorpia swatted a pincer through the air. "I mean… okay, yeah, maybe."

"Okay, yeah, *definitely.*" Catra laid a palm over Scorpia's shoulder and stood on her tiptoes, speaking lowly enough that the saleswomen wouldn't hear her. "Per was smart to schedule that little bit of private time before the reception." Scorpia giggled as Catra said, "you'll definitely need it."

"Oh my gosh, *Catra*."

"What! I'm only speaking the truth!"

She hopped down from the steps to the little stage and snatched up a second champagne flute, filling it and topping off her own. "Now," Catra started, handing the second glass over to the bride-to-be. "I think you deserve to have wild sex between appearances!"

"Catra!"

"To fucking in the bathroom of a reception hall!" She hollered, raising her glass high as the saleswoman who had stuck around snickered into her palm.

"Oh my *gosh*."

But Scorpia clinked her glass against Catra's anyway, smiling through the heat blooming on her face. They both took a swig, and Catra did a full circle around her friend to take in the entire dress. "So, what's the accessory situation?"

—

The crunching of Scorpia's SUV down the dirt driveway had fully faded away before Catra was able to work up the nerve to even begin to head inside. They had been gone much longer than she anticipated between finalizing Scorpia's jewelry and going to dinner and revamping parts of the seating chart, and Catra was almost worried that Adora would have gotten tired of waiting and left.

But her truck was still here, which meant Adora was still here. Good.

Catra stepped up to the porch door, and could hear the faint sound of the television from the living room across the house. Okay, it sounded like she was watching one of her nerdy little sci-fi shows, and she only did that when she was in a good mood. Also good.

With a deep breath in, Catra pulled open the screen and unlocked the bigger door, and stepped over the threshold. There was no call out of her name or acknowledgement that she had been heard, so Catra took an extra minute to adjust to the bright kitchen light. She dropped her keys, probably too loudly, and cursed slightly when her bag fell off of the counter to the ground.

Adora still hasn't said anything. Huh. There was absolutely no way that she hadn't heard all of that ruckus, so had she changed her mind to mad? That would be stupid, though, and Catra decided right then that she would shut that down in a second.

But an old, nagging part of Catra remembered this scenario - but not with Adora seething in the living room as Catra came home after her strict curfew - and the scared little girl in the back of her mind begged her just to sneak up the stairs as quietly as possible. Avoid the danger. Avoid the rage. Let her sleep it off and maybe she'll have some mercy in the morning.

But Adora wasn't Weaver, and Catra wasn't even slightly scared of Adora. There was no danger. So she pushed past the phantom itching at the back of her neck.

"Adora?" Catra asked as she stepped into the living room. "You in here?" Still no answer.

In fact, Catra couldn't even see Adora's head over the back of the couch. What if she wasn't even there; if she had just gone to the bathroom and would scare the shit out of Catra when she came back? Or maybe she was just lying there, angry and refusing to answer, like some petty child.

As Catra came around the side of the couch, she started saying, "If you're giving me the silent treatment I'm going to kick your—"

Oh.

Oh god.

Catra felt her heart catch in her chest as she caught sight of Adora, fast asleep, laying on her back and sprawled out as much as was possible on this couch, lightly snoring with each inhale, her cheek squishing against the armrest.

Her brows were relaxed and resting high on her forehead, her hair down around her shoulders and slightly damp, presumably from a shower, as Catra noticed her clothes were different, too.

The phone laying on Adora's chest started to *ding,* and, with a swiftness that came naturally to Catra, she lifted the offending object up and flicked the *silent* button before laying it face down on the coffee table. Maybe it was weird of her to want a few minutes just to enjoy Adora like this - maybe she was taking advantage of Adora, who couldn't mask her vulnerability while sleeping - but god, she looked so damn peaceful, and Catra knew how rare this could be.

Kneeling in front of Adora, Catra reached forward to tuck some loose hair back behind Adora's ear. With her nails, she couldn't stop herself from tracing featherlight lines along to curves of Adora's face. From her temple, down her cheek, across her jaw, up to her nose, then her lips. Lips. Those lips.

Adora's eyelids fluttered just slightly as Catra pulled her hand away and crossed both of them on the cushion, resting her chin on top of them as she took a moment to savor this sight. Adora was so effortlessly beautiful, and Catra didn't think she would ever stop noticing details about her - the faint freckles along her cheeks from her days spent in the sun, the wrinkles that had started showing around her eyes from years of laughter, the scar on the side of her nose from one of their competitions that had gone too far - a mixture of familiar and new, things that Catra wanted to know as well as she knew her own face.

She leaned forward and pressed the softest kiss she could manage against the corner of Adora's mouth, a smile pulling at her cheeks as a huff of air blew from Adora's nose, and a soft hum of the beginnings of consciousness vibrated in her throat.

"Hey , Adora," Catra said, low and raspy , pulling back far enough to catch those beautiful blue eyes blink open as the fog of sleep slowly cleared. "Good nap?"

"Mmmm." Another sleepy hum as Adora started to look around to gather her bearings and stretched her arms up over her head. "It' s dark out."

"Only just got dark."

Adora nodded slowly as if she were relieved that she hadn't been asleep for hours and hours, until she finally seemed to register just how close Catra was sitting. "Hi," she smiled, raising one hand up to stroke over Catra's hair, insisting he come even closer. "How was your day?"

"It was really good," Catra said. She was still practically whispering, as if talking any louder would ruin this sweet moment. "Scorpia looks beautiful in her dress."

"Oh, that' s great news." Adora started to shift, then, sitting up higher and making a motion with her hands to encourage Catra to join her .

I can't wait to see the pictures."

"Hey , about that," Catra chuckled as she crawled up onto the couch and curled her body around Adora's, weaving their knees together. "I was supposed to invite you like, weeks ago, but I totally forgot." Adora hummed, and Catra ran her fingers across Adora's collarbone. "Do you want to go?"

The rough, calloused pads of Adora's fingers had found their way effortlessly and innocently underneath the hem of Catra's shirt, and were rubbing softly against the skin of her back. "Wow, you forgot about me?" she laughed, before pressing her lips against Catra's throat. "But I'd love to go."

Adora didn't stop the soft ministrations of her mouth against Catra's skin, and Catra could feel the pull of anxiety boiling in her stomach. She wanted Adora to keep kissing her, but she knew she needed to talk about the thing. But if she talked about the thing, Adora would stop kissing her. Catra had dealt with this years ago, so what did it matter? Adora could bring it up again if she wanted to.

But Catra wanted to lay it all out there, and wanted to clear the air of this last thing that could be considered Big - and to do that, she had to talk about it.

But Adora's mouth was so warm and Catra was starting to lose the war with the less logical parts of herself, so she spoke.

"Hey , so..about what Scorpia said earlier"...

As expected, that stopped Adora in her tracks. Catra could feel Adora moving against her as Adora drew her bottom lip between her teeth before pulling away. Damn it. Catra had hoped Adora would find some way to keep kissing her while they talked about it.

"Yeah?"..

Catra sighed and pulled away to meet Adora's gaze. "Before I start, I'm going to need you to promise you're not going to somehow internalize this and blame it on yourself."

"I don't do that."

That might have been the funniest joke Catra had *ever* heard.

"Adora."

Their eyes were locked together, narrowing slightly in competition, before Adora rolled hers good naturedly and shrugged, humming some noise of defeat.

"All right, fine."

"Say it," Catra smirked, poking her finger against Adora's forehead.

Then, in one of the most mocking voices Catra thought Adora had ever produced, Adora said, "I promise I won't internalize this and blame myself."

Catra rewarded her with a smile and a kiss, and then pulled away.

"Okay," she started, tucking loose hair behind Adora's ear. "So. On my nineteenth birthday Weaver pulled me into her study for a very lovely conversation. Apparently I had aged out of the system and since I wasn't in college, she wasn't getting any more money for me." Adora frowned, and Catra shrugged. "So she told me I had to go to college, or leave - and since we both know my intelligence far exceeds that found in an academic setting, I left."

Adora gave a soft snort of a laugh, but a look of confusion was spreading across her features. "Nineteen? We were still together when you turned nineteen."

Catra nodded. "Yeah."

Adora frowned deeper. "Like, for a solid seven months after."

Catra simply nodded again. "Yes. And?"

"How did I not know? Like." Adora's fingers had spread across Catra's back, as if she were afraid that Catra might disappear if she let any part of their bodies stop touching. "I mean, you're good at keeping secrets but…"

"Yeah. I didn't want you to know. And any time you visited we stayed with Raz. So it was easy enough."

Adora was still looking on, confused. "Why didn't you want me to know?"

"I guess I didn't want you to pity me," Catra shrugged. "Or to think I was worthless. Or something."

That confusion turned into an almost hurt as Adora's brows furrowed together and her shoulders drew up to her ears. "I wouldn't have *ever* -"

"I know," Catra interjected, letting her hand lay on the side of Adora's neck, rubbing gently over the bob of her throat as she swallowed. "I mean, I didn't *then*, and Weaver made me. She wasn't quiet about being shocked at how you settled for me. Or how she wished she had fostered you instead." She let out a bitter laugh. That one still stung. Catra wasn't sure if it ever wouldn't. "But in my head not having a proper place to live was just another reason I didn't deserve you."

Before Adora could say anything that Catra was positive would be apology-adjacent, Catra placed her fingers over Adora's lips. "Remember, we agreed not to apologize about the past anymore. It's done. I'm just giving you this information about a part of my life I didn't let you in on. So don't go all savior complex on me right now."

Adora's shoulders dropped with a heavy breath, but there was a smile behind it. "Okay."

"So I slept in my car for a bit while I figured stuf f out, then bounced around motels in the area for a while longer. Most of my daylight hours were spent working anyway, so I didn't think it was worth trying to find somewhere to rent when all I needed was a place to sleep." Catra smoothed her thumb over Adora's eyebrow. "I figured once I saved enough I could get out of this town, you know?"

"Razz would have let you stay with her for free," Adora practically whispered. Catra could hear the thickening of her throat, overloaded with guilt and emotion, but she hadn't voiced it. Catra was grateful for that, at least.

Catra nodded, and nudged her nose closer to Adora's. "I'm sure she would have," she said, frowning. "But I didn't want her to know either . Pride. You know. What a bitch - but I would have died before admitting I could *maybe* have benefitted from a bit of help."

Pressing her lips together, Adora looked like she was holding something back. A laugh, or maybe an apology. Catra couldn't guess. "So how long?".

"Like Scorpia said, about nine months. I think a little shorter because it wasn't for much longer after we broke up."

Adora came closer still, tucking her forehead into the curve of Catra's nose and pressing up against her cheek. "Then?"

"Eventually Netossa figured me out, and went out of her way to catch me in the act so I couldn't deny it. I lived with her and Spinerella for a while. Picked up hours at the cafe to pay them back." Adora held on tighter. "Until I bought this place a few years ago."

Catra felt lighter. Like maybe she hadn't noticed this last little weight resting on her shoulders. Adora was quiet, likely trying to figure out what she wanted to say, but her fingers were stroking up and down Catra's spine, and Catra settled into her touch.

After what felt simultaneously like an eternity and barely half a second, Adora pulled back, just slightly. "I'm sorry that happened," she started, and then she frowned. "I wish I could have helped."

"I chose it. I didn't need help."

Adora nodded, her brows furrowing together. "I know." She frowned, and her grip tightened. "Well I at least wish fucking Weaver had told me where you were when I came here to talk to you."

Catra's lips twitched into a soft - maybe a little sad - smile as she ran her fingers down Adora's jaw. "I don't think that would have gone how you would have wanted it to go." She watched Adora's eyes flick downward. "I would have been even angrier. Probably."

Adora nodded. "Yeah."

"Anyway. Wishing doesn't change it, you know?"

Blue eyes turned up to face her.

"Wishing, and offering options, and everything else, that doesn't change it. I'm okay with what happened." Catra hooked her finger under Adora's chin, smiling. "So you have to be, too. Okay?"

Adora's lips turned into a crooked half-smile, and she nodded. "Okay."

"Good." Catra stretched her neck forward to press one chaste kiss against the corner of Adora's mouth, and started to sit up. "Now that that's over with"—

Warm hands grabbed at her, and she turned to face Adora again.

Her eyes were dancing over Catra's face, never lingering in one spot for too long. There was a glassiness to them that Catra couldn't ignore - a sadness and a fire mixing into a burning intensity that she couldn't look away from. It was one of those looks that meant Adora had decided something that you wouldn't be able to talk her out of.

She reached up so softly as she pulled herself to a sitting position, tracing the pads of her fingers down Catra's hairline, and tucked a loose curl back behind her ear. She laid her palm flat against Catra's neck, cupping her thumb and index finger around Catra's jaw. She caught her gaze, and wouldn't let Catra look away as she leaned forward, pressing her forehead firmly against Catra's.

Catra swallowed.

"Wh—"

Adora cut her off with a kiss.

A kiss like Catra had never experienced before. A kiss that was full of passion and heat but no lust - no seeking for more. Innocent. Emotional. Almost too much for Catra to bear.

Catra felt her fingers curling into the collar of Adora's shirt, suddenly afraid that this might have been a dream.

Adora kissed her like she was making up for lost time. Like it was an apology that she didn't know how to voice because she knew it wouldn't make a difference.

Her hands pulled Catra closer, her lips parted further, a soft whimper vibrated from her throat when she changed the angle she had slotted their mouths together.

Adora kissed Catra like she could never know anything better. She kissed her like she was in on something Catra hadn't quite figured out yet. She kissed her like she could never stop.

Like she *would* never stop.

Catra pulled her closer - impossibly so - and Adora whispered her name as their lips parted.

"Can I stay tonight?" Adora asked, her voice barely a whisper between breaths.

"Yes," Catra nodded, leaning into the palm at her jaw as Adora pressed another kiss against the corner of her mouth. "Duh." Another. "Dummy."

Another, another, another; until nothing else existed.

Chapter End Notes

Hiiiii I hope y'all liked this chapter because I've been fighting with it for months and tbh I'm sick of looking at it 🤣 but I think at least now I'm sort of happy with it

Thanks all for ur patience with me x it's been a very crazy like six months lol.

Anyways! As always comments make my whole day xoxo

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

> As always now that they've kissed, there's a little bit of suggestive making out at the top of this chapter. 😷

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra couldn't stop giggling. She hated it, it sounded so stupid, but Adora had her thrown over her shoulder and Catra couldn't stop *giggling* . "Put me down!"she tried, gasping a laugh when Adora simply hiked her body further up on her shoulder. "W e have to leave!"

"Not yet!"Adora hollered back as she shoved open the door to the house. "I have fifteen minutes to make out with you first."

Adora had pulled up early - as usual - to pick Catra up for the rehearsal dinner, and when Catra had come out of the house, Adora's entire face had flushed red. Catra knew she looked good, but Adora's throat bobbing as her eyes flicked up and down her form was still overwhelming and encouraging and god, no one had ever made her feel more *wanted* than Adora did.

The jumpsuit had a criss-crossing front that left part of her stomach and chest exposed, as well as an open back, and Adora had swallowed hard before stammering "you look, um, w-wow . I mean… I'm… *wow* ."

"Not so bad yourself, dummy ,"Catra had replied, stepping forward to tugl on the collar of Adora's crisp navy blue button down, before smoothing her hands down Adora's chest. The fitted slacks she was wearing had also been doing Adora's ass a *lot* of favors, and Catra wanted to sink her teeth into it.

Adora had leaned down to kiss her, and her fingers ran up the length of Catra's bare spine, and now she was here, being marched up to her bedroom, tossed on the bed, and crawled over by the hottest person in the fucking universe. Fuck. Heat pooled low in her stomach as Adora lowered her mouth to meet Catra's as her fingers dug desperately into her hip.

When they parted, Catra smirked, hooked a leg under Adora's, and flipped them so Adora was now sprawled out beneath her, shock coating her features. God.

"You were fucking up my curls," was all that Catra offered at Adora's questioning cock of her brow.

Adora blew out a laugh and nodded, mumbling a quiet "fair enough," before bringing a hand up to cup around the back of Catra's neck and pull her back down. Their lips met again, and Catra quickly dropped her body to press against Adora's wherever she could. Their kisses were deep, but slow; they savored one another through each kiss, tasting one another as fully as possible. Adora's palm dragged its way down from the base of Catra's neck to the lowest dip in her spine, before pivoting and tracing up along the hem of the top of her jumpsuit, sending a shiver right down to her core.

Catra would give anything to have Adora's face between her tits right now. Would that...would that be too much?

Catra sat up on her heels to look Adora in the eyes as she let her fingers dance across the buttons of Adora's shirt, raising her brows in question. Adora nodded, gulping down a heavy breath, and Catra got to work. Button by button, she revealed smooth alabaster skin, and the top of a…

"What's this?" Catra teased, pushing Adora's shirt wide open to reveal a much more decorative bra than she would usually wear - *and* it clasped in the front. Catra laid her palms flat against Adora's ribs, thumbs dragging along the bottom of the bra, noting the

underwire. Adora *never* wore underwire. Wow. "Did you get all dressed up for me?"

"Actually it was for Scorpia, obviously ," Adora scof fed, her thumbs now digging into the creases of Catra's thighs, trembling slightly.

Catra felt her tail whip once against the bed before she tucked a finger underneath the clasp. "Oh? Then I guess we should get going," she teased, moving as if to stand - until Adora' s hands slammed her hips back down, unintentionally (or maybe not, by the look on her face) grinding Catra against Adora's own pelvis. Fuck. A soft whine escaped her parted lips, and Adora sat up to meet her.

She kissed her, hard and deep and messy, and Adora's fingers were pulling at the tie of Catra's jumpsuit, and Catra' s finger was still under the clasp of Adora's bra, and god she knew they agreed to go slow, but..some topless kissing wouldn't be too much too soon. Definitely not.

"Do it," she panted as their lips parted, smiling as Adora mumbled back "you, too."

With a snap of her fingers, Adora's bra was open, and Catra's hands were immediately pushing the garment away as she practically moaned at the contact. Soft breasts and hard nipples pressed into her palms, and it felt so fucking *good* - she honestly didn't even need to be touched to be happy right now..but then the long, flowing fabric of her jumpsuit fell from her shoulders and Adora' s mouth was dragging down Catra's throat, leaving a hot path of teeth nipping and lips kissing, and Catra *wanted* . She wanted and she ached and Adora simply nipped the swell of her breast before pulling her forward so they were chest to chest, skin burning skin as they kissed and kissed and *kissed* .

She didn't mean to - because this was supposed to be slow, and they probably only had a few more minutes before they needed to leave, and Catra didn't want Adora to feel any pressure about it - but Catra felt her hips rock downwards, wet throbbing seeking friction,

and that was when Adora paused, her nails curling into Catra's ribs. Her lips left Catra's, dragging warm and sweet along her cheek before resting beside her ear as one hand rose to cup her breast, palm firm over her pebbled nipple.

Catra couldn't help herself;she clamped down onto Adora' s newly exposed neck, kissing and biting and sucking as Adora's strained whimpers blew against Catra's ear.

"I," Adora started, her throat thick with lust. "Even if I'm not ready to be touched"…

Oh god.

"I can touch you"…

Catra whimpered.

"If you want me to"…

Catra's mind was a hellscape of insatiable want, and she dug her fingers into Adora's hair. There wasn't enough time, and Catra wanted their first time to last and wanted their first time to be for *both* of them, but fucking hell Adora's tongue dragging up her jugular and her thumb flicking over her breast and her other hand gripping firm at her hips was *distracting* .

"No," she managed, against every instinct. "I mean, god, *yes* , I'd love that, but." She tugged softly on Adora' s hair so that their eyes could meet. "But not until *you* want it, too."

"Catra." Adora dropped her chin into the crook of Catra' s neck. "I don't. I don't know how long that'll be."

"I don't care if it' s never. I told you." Catra poked a finger against Adora's forehead, urging her back up. "I like making out with you. I like doing nothing with you. We had enough sex as teenagers to last a lifetime."

Adora laughed, biting her bottom lip. "I'm better at things now."

"I mean, me too," Catra scoffed, cupping her fingers under Adora's jaw. "Look. If you decide that you never want to be touched but still want to touch me, we can do that, for sure." She kissed her once, pulling back with a slight pop. "But while there's still uncertainty. I'd like our first time together to be reciprocal if possible." She paused and ran her thumb over Adora's bottom lip. "Okay?"

Adora's eyebrows had drawn up in the middle, and her eyes were wet as they scanned over Catra's face, and her lips had curved into a smile, and fuck. yeah, Catra was sure she had completely fallen for this dumb blonde idiot all over again. Fully. One hundred percent.

Shit.

"We should put ourselves back together, probably."

Adora glanced down between them, leaned down quickly to press a chaste kiss against Catra's breast and grinned. "I dunno, Perfuma seems like she'd be a fan of the tits out look."

The cackle that burst out of Catra's mouth was unhinged as she gripped onto the open edges of Adora's button down. "I can't say you're wrong. She is definitely. very um. earthy." Catra reached up to lay the fabric over her chest again, and almost laughed at the pout that took over Adora's face. "Don't look at me like that!"

Adora groaned and flopped back on the bed, her arms dramatically out to her sides. "Do we have to go? Can't we just stay here? Do more of this? This seems like way more fun than dinner with a bunch of people I don't know."

Catra knew she was teasing, but the drama of it all was fucking hilarious. "Unfortunately not. Being the maid of honor is a huge responsibility." Catra crawled off of Adora's lap and finished tying off her top, adjusting it to lay just right. "One that I do not take lightly."

Also you're great at making friends."Adora was still groaning in the bed, so Catra grabbed a pillow off of the floor and chucked it at her, smiling as snorty giggling bubbled up from the blankets. "Come on, dummy. We gotta go."

"Okay , okay,"Adora continued to laugh as she crawled out of the bed, shirt wide open and giving Catra a full view of Adora's breasts.

Catra whipped around to focus on *anything* else.

Using the mirror to make sure she didn't *look* as disheveled as she felt, Catra twirled a few of her frizzy ringlets between her fingers in a sad attempt to smooth them down. She couldn't help the way her eyes still caught Adora's reflection as she worked on clasping her bra and adjusting herself, with her tongue sticking out just slightly between her lips as she struggled, clearly not the most comfortable in this style of undergarment. It shouldn't have been as endearing as it was, and Catra had to force her gaze back to her own face.

Her makeup was smudged, but not in any way that wasn't fixable, so she made quick work of it before turning back to face Adora. It was then that her eyes landed on the patch of darkening bruises along Adora's throat and collarbone. Shit. She had gotten a little carried away.

"Do I look okay?"Adora asked as she buttoned up her shirt again, leaving the top few undone. She worked on tucking everything back into place as Catra walked over. "I feel like I need to brush my hair ."

Catra laid her palm over the mess of hickies as she realized it wouldn't be covered by Adora's shirt. Pressing her lips together, Catra huffed an amused breath through her nose. "You look fine, but, um.sorry ."

"Hm?"Adora looked towards the mirror and burst out laughing when she tugged Catra's hand off of her neck. "Oh my god. Catra!"

"I'm sorry!"

I'm meeting so many people for the first time!!"

I said I was sorry!"

But they were laughing and Adora was fixing her hair and shrugging. I mean, nothing I can do. Everyone is just going to know that you're a biter."Adora whipped around and pulled Catra in by her hips, pressing her lips against Catra's jaw . "Should I return the favor?"

Partially because Catra knew it would get them started up again and then they'd *really* be late, Catra pushed away from Adora with a laugh. "No way . I have to stand up in front of *three hundred people* this weekend to give a toast."

"What if it' s just a little one?"

When Catra laughed again, Adora scooped her back up. Catra was making peace with the fact that she was probably going to have to formulate some excuse for why they were late, but just as soon as she started running through the best ones she could think of, the alarm she had set for the absolute last minute to leave began to chime. Saved by the bell. Or cursed, maybe. She patted Adora's shoulders and reached for her phone the second her feet touched the ground. "W e really have to go."

Adora nodded with a playful little pout, turning to face the door.

"But maybe if you stay over tonight we can find a place that my bridesmaid getup will hide."

That stopped her in her tracks, her face blooming with color. "- oh. Um. Wow,"she started, a snorty little giggle passing through her lips. Her eyes followed as Catra stepped through the bedroom door, but she hadn't moved an inch.

Shaking her head, Catra turned back and asked, "you coming?"her hand outstretched.

Adora's face melted into that sickeningly sweet look that she reserved exclusively for Catra, and she stepped forward to lace their fingers together. "Yeah, I'm coming."

She placed a soft kiss against Catra's lips.

"Let's go make sure Scorpia isn't panicking."

—

They were greeted with a cheer of *hellos* from people who were definitely already a drink or two deep, and Catra squeezed Adora's hand in an attempt to reassure her. She could feel Adora's thumb dragging up and down hers, trembling with mild anxiety, and she took a step closer to press their shoulders together.

"Oh! Catra! I'm so glad you're here!" Perfuma came twirling through the crowd in a beautiful pink silk chiffon dress, hair flowing loose around her shoulders. "Scorpia will be so happy to see you've *finally* arrived."

Catra felt her lips turn into some sort of false smile masking a bit of annoyance. Yes, they were late - but Perfuma didn't have to be so passive aggressive about it.

"Traffic was miserable," Adora piped up, offering her hand for a shake. "And I definitely was the one who delayed our leaving - I'm really sorry about that!"

Perfuma turned her strained smile towards Adora, reaching for her hand hesitantly. "Ah, I see. We haven't had the pleasure!" The handshake was stiff at best, and Perfuma let out a sigh. "It's, um, Addison?"

"Adora," she said quickly, scrunching her nose a little. "But you were close!"

With a chuckle that was definitely forced, Perfuma threw her hands up. "Right, yes of course! So sorry , there's just so many things to do and remember!" Her laugh twisted to something slightly more deranged, and Catra was starting to think that maybe Perfuma had already lost it. "The name of Catra' s summer fling hasn't quite stuck yet!"

Catra tensed, and Adora's hand tightened around hers.

"No worries," Adora said. "W edding planning is stressful, I'm sure."

Catra knew on any other day Perfuma would have *loved* Adora, but she had turned out to be a little bit of a nightmare bride, and apparently being ten minutes late to their rehearsal dinner was crossing her line.

"Y es, well," Perfuma sighed, tucking her hair back behind her ears. "I'll let Scorpia know you're here."

And then she was gone and Adora was deflating just a little.

"I'm so sorry ," Catra groaned, rubbing her hand up and down Adora' s arm. "Y ou'd be surprised to learn she's normally like, the sweetest person ever." Catra placed one gentle kiss against Adora' s shoulder, wrinkling the fabric. "I don't think she does so great under stress."

Adora laughed and leaned closer into her. "If you say so" was all she said before they were interrupted again.

"Adora?"

Catra snapped to attention. Perfuma wasn't from around here, so it was definitely odd that one of her friends recognized Adora.

"No way!" Adora was laughing, and Catra stepped backwards when it looked like they were going in for a hug - Adora's fingers stayed interlaced with hers though, which made this just a little bit awkward.

Perfuma's bridesmaid - Mermista, Catra was pretty sure her name was - clapped her hand against Adora's shoulder as they pulled apart in a very familiar gesture. "Haven't seen you since you left for your fancy big pro soccer career," she said, the tiniest wobble of humor in her mostly monotone voice. "How's that been going?"

Adora looked sheepish as she shrugged. "Ah, you know. Taking a break right now"…

"Oh really? Soccer was, like, your *entire* life."

The fingers woven in between Catra's tensed as Adora stepped closer to her again. "Yeah, it was - but I've reintroduced myself to bigger and better things." When she turned her gaze down to Catra, so warm and full of affection, Catra couldn't stop herself from popping up onto her tiptoes to place a kiss on her lips. Her cheeks were burning with the embarrassment of being affectionate in front of someone she didn't know, but there was no way she wasn't going to kiss Adora when she looked at her like that.

"God I hope this is the girlfriend you never fucking shut up about that first year of college." Mermista was smiling as they both looked back in her direction. Her arms were crossed over her chest, but there was something sweet lingering right behind her otherwise bored features. "I don't think I've met anyone who was *that* annoying about a partner since."

Adora laughed, sheepish and embarrassed as she rubbed a hand against the back of her neck. "You got me," she said, squeezing her hand around Catra's.

They got into a conversation then about what they've been up to - one that Catra was far from involved in - and she realized she needed to go find Scorpia. She lifted Adora's hand to her lips to place a kiss against her knuckles before she let go, wordlessly explaining with just some hand movements while she backed away. As she got closer to the edge of the room, she picked up Mermista's voice one last time.

"So, uh, I hope I'm not being insensitive when I ask what the fuck rabid animal attacked your throat?"

Adora burst into laughter, and Catra snorted to herself as she shut the door to the hallway behind her.

It was much quieter back here and Catra felt like she could finally take a breath. She paused, took a few seconds to calm her nerves back down, and then started back to the office that Scorpia had said she would be in, finalizing the catering payments and schedule for Sunday.

Scorpia's voice and a few others were echoing loudly enough to guide Catra to the right room, and she knocked as she peeked her head through the doorframe.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia almost yelled, relief in her tone. "Oh I am so happy you're here."

Catra stepped into the room fully, waving politely at Starla and her brother before moving to stand beside Scorpia and pat at her shoulder. "What's going on big gal?"

"Just grateful to have your steady, calming presence around," Scorpia said with a sigh, and Catra elected to ignore the short snort of a disbelieving laugh that came from beside them.

(Starla had had a huge crush on Adora when they were in high school, and Catra wasn't sure that Starla had ever stopped disliking her because of it.)

Catra nodded and squeezed reassuringly before Scorpia spun in her chair, revealing a soft shin-length maroon gown that complimented her skin and exoskeleton perfectly. "I love my fiancé so much," she started, and Catra had a feeling she knew exactly where this was going. "And I am *so* excited to marry her. But." She glanced side to side, frowned, and dropped her head in defeat. "Well. I can't *wait* until Monday."

Biting back a smile and a laugh, Catra knelt down to the ground to get on Scorpia's eye level, hands rubbing up and down her biceps. "I think it's perfectly normal to feel this way, Scorp." Her dark eyes turned up to meet Catra', and she offered a smile. "Wedding planning is *tough.* In any relationship. You guys are going to get through it together and be so happy on the other side. And," Catra finished, clapping her hands gently against Scorpia's arms. "I'll be right by your side for the rest of the weekend."

Relief seemed to wash over Scorpia's face as she stood, nodding with triumph. "Yes! Per and I will get through this because we are soulmates!"

That.wasn't exactly what Catra had said, but sure.

She stood beside her best friend and let a little giggle slip, opening her arms to signal a hug would be acceptable at this moment, which Scorpia did not hesitate to take advantage of.

"You are, and you will," she said, rocking side to side. "And Sunday is going to be *perfect* ."

—

The rest of the rehearsal dinner had gone off without a hitch. The food was *fantastic* , the company was surprisingly tolerable, and everyone in the wedding party had taken an almost immediate liking to Adora. That part wasn't so surprising. By the end of the night everyone who had traveled into town headed over to the local bed & breakfast, while everyone who was from around here piled into their cars. Scorpia made sure to confirm everyone who was driving was sober, and Catra loved her best friend even more for it.

Adora, however, had started acting a little strange by the end of the night. Catra was definitely still a little tipsy as they climbed into Adora's truck, but she couldn't miss the tension that started in Adora's jaw and radiated down to her shoulders. Adora wordlessly started the engine, drumming her fingers on the steering wheel as

she rocked back and forth a couple times in her seat, adjusting. This was slightly worrying.

"Adora?" Catra asked, sliding her fingers across Adora's knee. "You okay?"

Shaking her head as if she was snapping out of something, Adora frowned. "Yeah, um." She lay her hand over Catra's and turned to face her. "Is it okay if we go up to the cliff for a little?" she asked, an almost undetectable waver in her words. She didn't elaborate.

Catra nodded and squeezed at her thigh. "Of course."

With a sigh, Adora reached across her chest to buckle her seatbelt before gesturing at Catra to do the same and then slowly pulled out of the parking spot they had lucked into. She didn't seem like she wanted to talk yet, so Catra just left her hand on Adora's knee, rubbing small circles with her thumb. "Okay if I put on the radio?" Catra said, turning her head to look at Adora, whose cheeks were slightly flushed and eyes were bordering on glassy. Shit.

"Uh, yeah, definitely."

Catra refused to move her hand from Adora's knee, so she stretched awkwardly with her far hand to fumble with the radio controls. She wanted something quiet and soft - their favorite station growing up usually shifted to slower, gentle music at this time of night - and she felt relief kiss her lungs as Adora's shoulders visibly relaxed when the sweet sounds of Norah Jones drifted through the speakers.

After a few minutes, Adora's fingers shifted to intertwine between Catra's, and she pulled their hands to her mouth, pressing sweet kiss after sweet kiss against Catra's knuckles. She didn't let go for the rest of the drive, and Catra felt her stomach twist into knots. Something felt wrong, but Catra was doing her absolute best to be patient.

But fuck, those thirty minutes it took to get past the homestead and out to the cliffside that overlooked the river felt like an eternity.

No one else was around, which made sense for nine pm on a Friday night, so Adora backed right up to the edge like she did when they were teenagers, and offered Catra a smile. "I've got some pillows and blankets, if you want?"

"Yeah," Catra said, shrugging. She wasn't sure what this was about, but she never turned down getting a little comfy in the bed of Adora's truck. "Whatever you'd like."

Adora let go of her hand, and Catra felt the chill reach her palm before she managed to curl it up against her chest. She watched with tired eyes as Adora bundled a bunch of things up in her arms and slid out of the cab, following as she appeared in the rearview mirror, tossing everything into the bed. Catra waited patiently, and after a minute or so Adora knocked on the passenger side door.

"My lady," Adora drawled as she pulled it open and held out her hand for Catra to take. "Stargazing in luxurious comfort awaits."

Catra couldn't help the soft laugh that passed over her lips as she stepped out of the truck, laying her fingers against Adora's palm. "You're such an idiot," she said, smiling as Adora pressed her lips against Catra's knuckles once again. Catra tugged on their joined hands as she made her way around to the bed, crawling in as elegantly as she could manage while not letting go of Adora's hand.

They settled in quickly, both sitting up against the back of the cab, Catra snuggling up against Adora's side as Adora fluffed the blanket around their hips. This was familiar - and still so comfortable - as crickets chirped and the sound of the water flowing through the bends of the river enveloped them. They sat in silence for a while, Adora playing with their fingers and pressing her lips against Catra's hairline every couple of minutes.

Catra was patient; but she wasn't *this* patient.

"Is everything all right?" she asked, catching her bottom lip between her teeth as she turned her chin up to meet Adora's gaze. "You've just got me...well, a little anxious right now..."

Blue eyes widened in surprise, and Adora pulled back with a frown. "I'm so sorry, no, everything is fine! I just, um, I..." She was twisting her lips together as if she had to force the words past them. "I talked to my manager again tonight. Well. She called me."

Oh. Well, it was going better than last time, at least? "Yeah?"

"Yeah, and um, she and the coach want me to come up tomorrow to talk with them." Adora lay her hand on Catra's knee over the blanket, stroking absentmindedly. "To, um, talk about what we're going to do going forward. You know, with me...on the team or not...or... whatever."

Catra's eyebrows raised high on her forehead. "Oh." She pressed her lips together and frowned slightly. "Are you...did you decide what you want to do?"

"Well...no, not really..." Adora breathed out a soft chuckle. "I think going and talking with them will help, maybe?" She scrunched her nose up and laughed again. "I hope so, at least. My manager seemed...in a better mood and more willing to have an actual discussion when she called today."

They sat in silence for a little, both going over their own thoughts before speaking.

"What...um," Adora started, shrugging. "What do you want me to do?"

Well Catra certainly hadn't been expecting *that.* "What?"

"I just...I...don't know what I want, so...what do *you* want me to do?"

Part of Catra was begging her to jump at the chance to say *stay here, stay home, stay with me*; but she wasn't going to be another person deciding Adora's fate for her. She refused. "Adora," she said, firmly but still gentle. "I want you to do whatever is going to make you the most happy." She could feel her heart clenching in her chest at the thought of Adora leaving again, at the thought of losing her again. But she wouldn't lose her, not this time.

"But what if I make the wrong choice?" Adora sounded so small, so afraid, and Catra couldn't stand it.

So she said, "the really cool thing is that...you can change your mind later. If you choose to go back and hate it, then you can quit again, for real." Adora sucked in a sharp breath, but let Catra finish. "And if you choose to quit and wind up missing it, you can keep in contact with your manager and coach. *And*," Catra said, trying to lighten up her tone. "No matter what you decide, I'll support you."

"...Yeah?"

"Yes. One hundred percent." She meant it. Catra was going to do everything in her power to not lose Adora again. She couldn't. Not again. "Even if you're gone again for five months at a time."

Adora leaned her cheek against the top of Catra's head. "Would you come visit me? Come see my games?"

"Probably not all of them, but yes, I'd come whenever I could."

"And I could come back and visit you, right?"

Catra sighed, a smile on her lips. "Yes. *Obviously*."

Adora swallowed loudly enough for Catra to hear it. "And if I stay here?"

"If you stay here," Catra said, her voice soft. "Then we just get to make up for lost time even faster." She paused, feeling Adora

nodding against her. "And I'd have to live in disarray for less time, since you decided to tear my house apart."

A full blown laugh burst from Adora's chest this time, and she wrapped her arms suddenly around Catra's shoulders, squeezing her close to her chest. "I promise I will get it done! And quickly! But not so quickly that I sacrifice quality. Because we don't want it collapsing."

Catra honestly hadn't even thought of that. "Oh my god. Okay," she pushed away, a smile stretching her cheeks. "You can go back, but not until *after* my house is fixed. And that's my final decision." She was joking - mostly - and was grateful that Adora seemed to catch on.

Adora raised her hand to her forehead in a salute, a more serious expression taking over her features. "Understood. I'll make sure to tell them that my girlfriend said I have to finish what I started here first."

Oh, she couldn't stop herself. Catra practically leapt forward and threw her arms around Adora's neck, knocking them both backwards with a small yelp. Adora was laughing splayed out on her back, and Catra felt so warm in her chest, and god, she never wanted this to end. She kissed her. Soft. Deep. Long and lingering.

And Adora met her in kind, her fingers cupping the back of Catra's skull as she pulled her closer. Catra didn't know how long they stayed there for, but she didn't care. When she finally pulled back, her curls falling down to hide them away, she asked, "do you have to go this weekend?" Adora looked confused. "I just. I'd really like you to be at the wedding with me."

"I will be," she said, a soft smile on her lips. "I'll leave early tomorrow morning, have my talk with them, then come back first thing Sunday morning."

That was cutting it closer than Catra would like.

"I also should like to go make sure my apartment is still standing."

That was what broke Catra into a fit of laughter. "Oh my god, somehow it didn't even occur to me that you would still have an apartment there."

"I mean I gave Glimmer my keys so hopefully she watered my plants and didn't like, let mold grow." Adora snorted and let her palm flop against her forehead. "Oh my god there are probably science experiments in my fridge."

"Gross," Catra said as she crawled up to lay more comfortably beside Adora. "I know you have an affinity for not wasting food but dear god you better not eat any of it."

Adora scoffed and rolled her eyes. "Come *on*, I'm not dumb." But she hesitated for a minute, then said, "but like what if it looks and smells fine?"

"Adora. It has been almost four *months*." Catra grimaced just *thinking* about it. "Please don't fucking eat anything that you left in your apartment."

"Okay, *mom*," Adora grunted, snorting a laugh as Catra shoved at her face.

Catra rolled her eyes and laid her entire body weight on top of Adora, her laughter shaking Catra. "Unfortunately I like you, and would rather you didn't get food poisoning and die."

"You *like* me?" Smugness had completely flooded Adora's words. "That's pretty embarrassing for you."

"Shut up," Catra said, rolling onto her side and laughing at the soft sounds of distress that Adora let out as Catra's elbows jammed into her body. "You're embarrassing."

"Sure am."Adora stretched her neck to press a kiss against Catra's cheek, smiling into it. "You should be relieved I'm not going to be at the bachelorette party tomorrow to embarrass you even more."

Catra frowned. "I wish you were coming."

"No one else's partners will be there,"Adora mumbled, still pressing kisses against Catra's cheek. "You'll be with your friends."

"I'll be with *Scorpia's* friends."

The corner of Adora's mouth tilted up into a crooked grin as she pulled back, and she ran a thumb over Catra's cheekbone. "You'll have fun, because you'll be with Scorpia."

"Yeah,"Catra sighed, pressing the bridge of her nose into Adora's throat in an almost nuzzle. "You're right."

A few minutes passed in comfortable silence, Catra's fingers twirling in Adora's hair as Adora's palms stroked warmth up and down Catra's arms. Catra didn't want to move, and it seemed like Adora didn't want to either. Moving meant going home.

Moving meant sleeping. It meant waking up and Adora leaving, and maybe deciding not to come back permanently, and Catra wasn't ready for that.

She pressed herself a little tighter against Adora's body and closed her eyes.

Just a few more minutes.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi friends ♡ thank you once again for your patience with me and this fic. It has been a slow over two years but I've been loving every minute of it and every ounce of the support you guys have given me :'))

We’re close to the end. Just one more chapter & an epilogue for these sweet farm girls 💝

(And then some extras, because I can’t leave them behind completely 💜💜)

As always, comments make my entire day. I love you all so much. Even when I fall behind on replying please know that I am reading them & they are encouraging me every step of the way!!! xx

Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

a promise (almost) broken, and a promise kept

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"tra"…

Catra snuggled deeper into the plush pillows and blew out a heavy breath through her nose.

"Catra," the soft voice tried again as a pressure came down onto her shoulders, rubbing gentle circles. "*Bby…*"

"Mmmm," she hummed, turning her face into the pillows, smiling at the warmth of the voice. "Five more minutes"…

A breathy laugh sounded from above as the bed sunk down slightly by Catra's waist and the hand on her shoulders squeezed gently. "I gotta go," it said, and Catra was finally starting to wake up. "I wanted to say bye."

Catra opened one eye against the dark room, frowning at the light coming through the crack in the doorway. How early was it? They hadn't wound up going to sleep until after midnight, but it looked like the sun wasn't even close to rising. "Can't you—" She broke off into a large yawn, and Catra flipped over to her back as her hands tugged the blanket higher up under her chin. "Can't you come back to bed for a little longer?"

Adora's face scrunched into thought before she nodded and pulled her feet up on top of the blankets and lay beside Catra, twirling her fingers into Catra's curls. "Five minutes," she whispered, her hand

cupping Catra's jaw as Catra turned back onto her side to face Adora. "Then I really have to go, okay?"

"Okay ."

A low, rumbling purr vibrated deep from Catra's chest as Adora stroked warm fingers over the bare skin of her collarbone. She remembered last night, remembered Adora cashing in on the promise that she could mark her in places no one else could see, remembered pulling on her pajama shorts just to turn and see Adora watching her with hunger in her eyes, remembered hot mouths and sharp teeth and not even being able to get a shirt on before tumbling into the bed. Adora left marks, all right. Catra loved knowing they were there.

"Y ou're definitely gonna be back in time, right?" Catra asked, her voice barely above a whisper. "I just." She shuf fled slightly closer to Adora; the blanket she was under and Adora was on top of stopped her from getting where she wanted to be.

Adora nodded and lifted a hand to tuck hair behind Catra's ear before stroking softly over her cheek. "I will."

It got stuck in her throat for a moment, but Catra smiled and forced out, "you promise?" and Adora didn't hesitate for a second before saying "I *promise* ."

Catra kissed her, her arms rising out of the cocoon of blankets to wrap around Adora's shoulders. "Good. Y ou better."

With a soft snort, Adora nodded and kissed her back, laying warm palms on her hips. It wasn't enough, and Catra started to move up to get closer—

Until Adora shoved her back down into the bed by pulling the blanket over her shoulders and pinning it against the mattress.

"What the fuck?"

"Catra," Adora huffed, struggling slightly against her wriggling for freedom. "Stop moving!" A smile was plastered on her lips which helped ease Catra's worry, but she was still confused as *fuck.* Even more so when Adora started using her hands to tuck the blankets under Catra's body, effectively rendering her unable to move. "You have to stay under the blankets."

"Um," Catra said shortly. "May I ask why?"

There was an intense concentration wrinkling the space between Adora's eyebrows as she worked the blankets all the way around Catra's body. She paused for just a second to meet Catra's gaze and say "boobs."

Well that certainly didn't clear anything up.

"Boobs."

"Yep."

"My boobs?"

"Who else's?" Adora huffed as she manhandled Catra's legs, wrapping them together so tightly that there was no way she could move. She crawled over Catra to straddle her thighs as she finished tucking the blankets around her shoulders, all the way up to her ears, forcibly shushing Catra any time she tried to talk.

Catra would be annoyed if Adora wasn't so fucking endearing.

Adora sat back with a triumphant grin and dropped her hands to her hips, admiring her work. "There. Now we're good." She nodded to herself for a moment before *finally* meeting Catra's eyes again.

"So, um, are you going to explain why you essentially just put me in a straight jacket?"

With a breath of a laugh and a shrug of her shoulders, Adora said, "If I see your boobs I won't leave," as if it were the most obvious

explanation in the world.

Catra cocked a brow as a devilish grin pulled up the corner of her mouth. "Do my tits have that much power over you?"

"Y es!"Adora let her torso fall over to lean over Catra and braced herself on her palms, resting on either side of Catra's head. "Have you seen them?"

There wasn't any way for Catra to deny that she was a little enamored by the way Adora's silky ponytail fell over her shoulder, or how the soft glow of the moon reflected off of her cheek;so she swallowed hard and met Adora's gaze in a challenge. "Y es, most days."

"Okay , then you know they're incredible."

Catra laughed at that. They *were* , but she had more tact than to say that out loud. "So why wouldn't you want one last look before you go?"

The expression that fell over Adora's face looked like she wasn't sure what exactly Catra wasn't understanding about this. "Because then I won't be *able* to go!"Adora dropped her weight directly on top of Catra, groaning with the effort of it. "And I *have* to go."

"Hmmm,"Catra shrugged as she started to wiggle her shoulders free. "In that case, I think I can get out of this in no time flat."

"No!"Adora rolled of f of the bed in what would have been an impressively fluid manner;but she hit the ground with a loud thump and a yelp, making Catra bark out a laugh as Adora scrambled back up to her feet. "I have to go!"

Catra freed one shoulder and watched Adora swallow against a lump in her throat. "Y ou better get going then,"Catra purred, popping her other shoulder up over the hem of the blanket. This was all in good

fun and Catra respected Adora's wishes, but she also couldn't *not* try to make Adora as flustered as humanly possible before she left.

"I'm going, I'm going!"Adora practically yelled as she backed up towards the door, her hands in the air in surrender and a smirk on her lips. "No need to do anything crazy!"She hit her hip against the small table that sat by the bedroom door, before smacking blindly behind her with one hand to try and find the doorknob. "We can both make it out'a here alive."

Pressing her lips together to stop from laughing, Catra pulled one arm free and held it out in a two-fingered gun, unable to stop herself from playing along with Adora's weird little goodbye. "You sure about that, Tex?"

Adora swung the door open so fast that the light from the hall blinded Catra, and as she squinted against it Adora started running down the hall - pausing to slap the light switch off before making her way down the stairs - yelling, "I ain't going back!"Then, after the porch door slammed shut and creaked back open, "see you tomorrow!"

Catra laughed, so full of joy it almost hurt, as she let her arm flop back onto the comforter. She heard Adora's truck start, and couldn't help but crawl up out of the blankets to peer out of the window. A gentle smile pulled at her cheeks as Adora flashed her headlights five times in a specific pattern that they had picked when they were in high school;their little way of saying goodbye again whenever Adora snuck out of her window before the sun came up. One Weaver never noticed because she slept with an eye mask on.

The truck backed out of the driveway and Catra sunk back into the mattress, snuggling into the residual warmth and scent of Adora that lingered between the sheets.

Her chest ached.

Satisfied and full, but with a piece of it driving away.

But not for good. She had to believe that it would never be for good again.

She had to believe in Adora.

Her phone vibrated against the nightstand.

Adora:miss u already <3

She did believe in Adora. Her chest still ached.

—

The bachelorette party wound up being more fun than Catra had thought it would be, especially considering that she had volunteered to be the mostly sober one. They drank bubbly champagne at a spa, where they got pampered to the high heavens in preparation for today, and Catra actually found herself bonding with the other girls. They asked about Adora and their relationship (Catra left out the rough middle), swapped stories of the different times they've all known Scorpia and Perfuma, and then had a really fucking delicious and decadent dinner.

Then they retired to the massive suite they had rented out, slept it all off, got a nice hearty breakfast, and started wedding preparation for the day.

Catra had only texted Adora a few times;one of which was a selfie of her with a bright green mud mask on.

Adora had replied, *will you take me with you when you return to mars?* ♡

Catra had texted her good morning and asked for an ETA, and Adora said she promised she'd be there in time, that she was jµst wrapping up a few more loose ends.

Then the day jµst got too busy .

She shot a couple other texts here and there, but didn't have much time to sit and wait for a response. Catra felt her heart clenching tighter with each hour that passed where she didn't see or hear from Adora.

Fuck. She had too much else to worry about.

Then it was time.

Everyone was ready, and Catra could feel her stomach twisting with anxiety. Everyone was ready, and Catra's texts still remained unanswered. Everyone was ready, and Adora still wasn't here. She promised.

She *promised* .

"Catra?" Entrapta asked, tapping at her shoulder . "Everyone is waiting for you."

"I-" She swallowed against the dryness of her throat and clenched her phone tighter in her hand, checking one more time before slamming it face down on the table in the dressing room. "Sorry , yeah, let's go."

There was a weird look on her friend's face - one that meant she was trying to decipher what exactly Catra was thinking - but Catra didn't have the energy for it right now. "Is everything all set? The cellist, flower girl, all the bridal party?"

Entrapta liked going down the checklists with Catra, and it distracted her enough to stop her worrying. "Yes, yes, and yes. Scorpia and Perfuma are with their parents on opposite sides of the entryway, all of the bridesmaids and groomsmen are lined up, with the exception of you and I, and..yes, everyone appears to be in their seats."

Everyone except for fucking Adora.

Who *promised.*

Catra sighed. Adora could have at least fucking *called.*

"Okay , great," she said, tucking her curls back behind her ears. She smoothed down the crisp front of her jumpsuit, checked her pocket to confirm she had Perfuma's ring for Scorpia, and took a deep breath in. "Let' s go."

They joined the rest of the wedding party and waited patiently for the music to start. As rehearsed, they all made their way down the aisle mostly together, as Scorpia and Perfuma didn't want to deal with trying to pair anyone off in a way that might be most *aesthetically* pleasing and potentially make anyone uncomfortable. Catra took up the rear, alongside Mermista, as the two maids of honor.

The music changed, everyone stood, and Scorpia and Perfuma entered from the sides, at the same time, before meeting in the middle. They both looked so beautiful, and Catra felt her throat getting tighter at the sight of them. Perfuma was keeping it together, but - as was predictable - Scorpia was an absolute blubbering mess. Catra tugged a small packet of tissues from the pocket of her jumpsuit, ready and waiting.

Scorpia came to stand beside her and took one with endless gratitude.

"Friends and family ," the of ficiant started, clapping their hands together before lowering them down to encourage everyone to sit. They were one of Perfuma's friends, and the second their speech started, Catra understood why.

She smiled through it, but had to hold back a laugh or two at some of the more.connected to nature things that she wasn't positive that she believed or understood, but she kept her eyes focused and tried to keep as much of an open mind as she possibly could.

Then the sharp sound of glass shattering - of *multiple* glasses shattering - that followed a loud bang drew Catra's attention up, along with everyone else sitting in the venue.

A hissed string of “ *shit,shit,shit* ,” escaped the of fender's lips as she looked up pathetically at all of the eyes that had turned to watch her. Catra’s heart picked up under her ribs in excitement, relief, and utter adoration as Adora glanced between the two broken glasses in her hands, the multiple others on the ground, and the crowd of attendees. “Sorry ,” she said, so fucking earnestly as she gently placed the stems of the champagne flutes that hadn’t quite survived back onto the table. “...my bad.”

She slid into the first seat she could find, sinking down into it as red burned up her chest and neck and cheeks. It took a second for everyone to regain their composure, and as the officiant coughed once before continuing, Adora lifted her gaze to meet Catra’s.

Adora’s eyes screamed an apology, but she must’ve seen no anger on Catra’s face as her own quickly softened into one of bashful humiliation. She looked so fucking pretty, and all Catra could even focus on was thank fucking *god* she was here. Adora waved up at her - just a little wiggle of her fingers beside her cheek - and Catra knew her shoulders visibly relaxed. She turned her attention back to her best friend, standing opposite the love of her life and sobbing her way through her vows, and Catra thought that maybe she had never felt more at peace.

She presented Scorpia with her ring for Perfuma as Mermista handed Perfuma the box with Scorpia’s bracelet, and before she knew it, they were kissing, they were married, and Catra managed to wipe away one tear without anyone noticing.

—

The time between the end of the ceremony and now has been chaotic . Between photos, the outfit changes for both brides, *more* photos, an intimate moment for the bridal party with a little token of appreciation and a round (or two or three) of champagne, Catra was ready to sit down with a stronger drink and some good food. She also was *dying* to kiss her beautiful girlfriend, who had been

nursing a cocktail and making small talk with some other people she must've known from college for the last hour and a half.

Just one more thing. The toast. Catra wasn't good at this kind of thing, but she had put in her best effort and practiced it, and she knew for Scorpia all that mattered was that she showed up and that she tried. It was going to be fine. Her hands were still shaking as she was handed the mic.

"Scorpia and I met just a couple weeks after I graduated high school," she started, wrinkling the paper between her fingers. "I was a hard person to get along with back then." A couple chuckles came from the crowd, and she shrugged with a fond smile. "I don't think anyone *but* Scorpia would have put in the effort to get to know me. But she did. She punched down wall after wall with aggressive affection and care, and somehow - despite all of my resisting and protesting - she got me to care about her, too."

The crowd *aww* 'd, and Catra bristled just a little, hating the attention. She tapped her finger against the glass in her hand gently, then continued. "I won't lie, it was definitely overwhelming. Anyone who knows Scorpia knows that she loves loudly and fully, and I wasn't used to that. At the time, no one but my girlfriend had ever liked me quite that much." Her eyes darted to look at Adora, smiling fondly with the straw of her drink caught between her teeth. "But despite my best efforts to deny that a genuine friendship was forming, it was, and soon enough I had found my best friend. And then just a few months after that, she met the love of her life."

Catra folded the paper down, feeling more confident. She knew what she wrote, and she also knew it was best to just speak from the heart and not drag it out too long. "Scorpia started to glow in a way I hadn't seen before. The adoration she held for Perfuma from the start was astonishing, and I knew from the first second I met Perfuma that it was reciprocated tenfold." She didn't know when she had started pacing, but she stopped abruptly to turn back to face Scorpia. "I knew right then that this day was coming, because those

two looked at each other like the sun shined out of their asses.” She paused to take a sip of her champagne.

“These two absolutely incredible women bring out the best in one another, and in every single person that has the luck and pleasure to know them.” Catra lifted her glass, and the rest of the attendees joined her. “To Scorpia and Perfuma, who never cease to amaze me. I love you both. Cheers.”

A chorus of clapping and glass clinking broke out as Catra moved swiftly over towards Scorpia, who pulled her in immediately for a hug, sobbing about how beautiful that was, and Catra simply laughed before patting at her elbow.

“Careful big gal,” Catra said. “Don’t want your makeup running before your moms speak.”

The rest of the toasts flew by, but Catra had to admit that she had barely listened to any of them. Her focus was on Adora: on the way her hair was falling down her back in perfect waves, one side combed smooth by her temple and held back carefully with a gold ornamental pin, on how the simplistic makeup she had put on made her eyes sparkle, on how the red blazer she was wearing was perfectly fitted to her broad shoulders, on the deep, plunging neckline of her soft gray blouse, on the gold necklace that fell over her sharp collarbone and between her cleavage—

The DJ started making some announcement about dinner being served, and Catra made an absolute beeline towards Adora. She was standing with someone by the appetizer trays, looking fucking ethereal as the sun started to dip below the horizon. Catra could hear some sort of conversation going on, but couldn’t possibly care less about interrupting it; she grabbed Adora’s elbow and tugged, spinning her around with a small yelp before reaching up to cup her hands around either side of Adora’s jaw.

She pulled downward and stood taller in one swift motion as she caught Adora’s lips in a kiss. It wasn’t gentle, and the whimper of

surprise from Adora quickly melted into a hum of contentment as her hands slid to circle Catra's waist, nudging her up onto her toes as Adora pulled their bodies closer together. Fuck. Catra can't believe how much she had missed her.

A cough interrupted their reunion, and Adora pulled away with a pop of their lips. "Oh, shit, um," she chuckled, not letting go of Catra. "I'm so sorry. Uh." Adora pulled one hand away from Catra's waist to gesture towards the stranger. "This is, um, this is Mermista's fiancé, Seahawk." Adora looked back towards Catra and moved her hand up and down Catra's form. "This is my very beautiful girlfriend, Catra."

A hearty laugh bellowed from Seahawk as he gave a big thumbs up. "It was quite obvious, my friend." His energy was weird and somehow already unpredictable, but Catra was ready to brush him off.

"Nice to meet you," Catra said as politely as she could. "Would you mind if I stole her for a minute?"

Seahawk blew out a breath and laughed, waving his hands in front of his face. "Oh not at all! I must go find my dearest Mermista anyway!" He held out a hand for a shake and Catra slipped her hand into his, albeit begrudgingly. "It was absolutely marvelous to meet you!" Then he turned his attention back to Adora. "And, wonderful to see you again after all these years. I'm glad to hear you're doing so well."

After giving him a short nod and a thank you with a bright smile, Adora turned her attention back towards Catra, her whole face lighting up as if there were magic inside of her. "Hi," she whispered, pressing her forehead against Catra's.

"You were late," Catra said, but there was nothing but relief in her tone as she brought her fingers up to thread into the hair at the base of Adora's skull.

"I'm sorry ." Adora kissed her once, slowly and deep, before sliding her hands down Catra's arms to grab her fingers. "I got…caught up in something."

Catra's eyes narrowed playfully before she squeezed back at Adora's hands. "Better have been something fucking incredible."

"It is."

The definitive nature of Adora's words send Catra's heart jumping up into her throat. She laced their fingers together and started to walk towards a doorway, grabbing a cocktail on the way out, grinning as Adora did the same.

"So you made *quite* the entrance," Catra started after the door banged shut behind them, muffling the overbearing noise of the reception.

Adora's face dropped and she tensed, clear frustration rising in her shoulders. "Well, who the hell puts a champagne glass pyramid behind a *door*!"

"I'm pretty sure that door had a do not enter sign on it."

"It definitely did not."

Catra's smile turned mischievous as she spun on her heel to face Adora, offering a challenge. "If it has a sign, then you owe me breakfast tomorrow. But a fancy one, in the city."

"And if it doesn't?" Adora said, squinting her eyes just slightly…. "What do I win?"

"Nothing. Because you were late."

As Adora's face dropped into a feigned offended expression, she scoffed and crossed her arms over her chest. "Well." She huffed and rolled her eyes, shoulders dropping. "Fine." She sounded almost

petulant as she stuck her tongue out. "But I'm going to beat you there!"

Then she started sprinting.

Catra followed immediately behind, grateful that the one thing Perfuma didn't care about was whether or not she was wearing shoes.

"You're going to rip down the sign and cheat!" Catra yelled as she closed the distance that Adora's head start had put between them, laughing wildly as their feet hit the grass between the two buildings.

Adora turned to see how much room she had left, but determination took over her features. "Ummmm," she hummed, picking up speed. "I'm not the cheater here!"

Willing her legs to go faster, Catra hated that she didn't want to ruin her jumpsuit by getting down on all fours. The extra speed would be *nice* , but how fucking expensive would it be to get grass stains out of whatever fancy material this damn thing was made of?

Adora skidded slightly as she turned the last corner, clearly missing the grip of her cleats, and Catra took advantage of the slip up, springing forward and launching her body into Adora's back, covering her face and eyes right as Adora's fingers gripped the bottom of the very, *very* obvious "Do Not Enter" sign.

"You set me up!" Adora laughed, twisting her head back and forth in Catra's grip as she struggled to rip the sign off of the door. "This wasn't here before!"

"It was!" Catra shouted, her voice shrill and elated. "I watched them stick it on before even setting up the table!" Adora's hands came up to grip Catra's wrists and tug her hands down to circle Adora's neck instead, clearly giving up on the sign. "Just admit you're oblivious."

Adora frowned, but her eyes still sparkled as she said "I'm sorry , I was just so focused on seeing you. Nothing else even computed."

That struck Catra deep in her chest and she sighed and leaned forward to press a kiss against Adora's cheek before she hopped off of her back. "Don't try to flatter your way out of this one."

"Pf fft."Adora rolled her eyes and turned to face Catra again. "What if it's the truth?"

"Then I think you haven't kissed me *nearly* enough for"—

Adora came down so swiftly it almost genuinely swept Catra off of her feet before she leaned Catra back into some sort of dip as she kissed her again and again;Catra was grateful there wasn't anyone really left over here as she lifted her fingers to grip tightly onto Adora's lapel.

Pulling back just far enough to press her forehead against Adora' s, Catra breathed out a dreamy sigh. "Okay , I believe you."Adora kissed her again, and Catra mumbled "you look so pretty ,"against her lips, smiling when Adora only pulled her closer.

"Y ou're one to talk."

If she were honest with herself, Catra knew she could easily be so, so satisfied just spending the rest of the night in private with Adora, kissing her and touching her and being with her in the most chaste way possible. But also…

"Okay , hotshot,"Catra sighed as she pushed on Adora' s chest to stand up straight. "W e need to get back. And"…holy fuck.

She had almost forgotten.

"And you need to tell me what the fuck happened with your coach and manager!"

The most spectacular shit-eating grin that Catra had ever seen spread over Adora's face. "What do you think happened?"

Catra's brows furrowed. "Just tell me!"

"Not even one guess?"

Adora was clearly physically vibrating with excitement and wouldn't be able to hold it in much longer - but Catra could play along for a minute. Maybe. In her own way.

"Well," she said, tapping at her chin. "Obviously you decided to run off and start your own team in your own league, right?" Catra looked over at Adora, who was giving her just the cutest confused face imaginable. "But on your way out you thought, hmmm, maybe I need to dream bigger, and then clearly left the league entirely, then went out and bought a horse so you could become the cowboy you've always dreamed of being."

Adora's nose scrunched up as she snorted, letting her head fall back to let out a loud, fake "Ha!" before she reached out to grab Catra's hands and swing them slightly. "You're not going to take a serious guess, are you?"

"Nope."

She didn't want to be wrong. She wasn't sure she could handle it.

"Well," Adora started, taking a few steps forward and pulling Catra along with her. "You were right about one thing. Sort of." She snorted slightly.

Catra knew that her ears perked up in excitement. The only thing that could have possibly been right was—

"I am leaving the league. For now," she tacked on quickly. "We, um, *I* decided that I wanted at least a bit of time off. But I might revisit it next season, or the season after."

It didn't seem like Adora was finished, so Catra held her tongue. They walked for a little longer, heading towards the outskirts of the property, fingers interlaced. Catra could still hear the muffled thumping bass of the reception, but she knew Scorpia wouldn't be missing her yet.

"Firstly I just… I want to make sure I still love it, you know? Playing." She shrugged, and Catra couldn't take her eyes off of Adora, who was absolutely glowing in the golden light of the early evening. "So I might go like… play recreationally for a bit? Just, um, just over in Elberon. So maybe weekend trips once in a while. I might also see if I can coach kids or something. But… I'll still mostly be here."

Catra gave her one nod when Adora looked over, but she knew her eyes were sparkling with delight already.

"And also I… I couldn't—" Adora paused, turning Catra to face her completely. "I don't *want* to leave yet. I want… I just want to spend time with you and… and make sure that this is… solid. And that, you know, if I do decide that I want to go back, that it's something we can…" Adora shrugged and her gaze dropped to the grass. "I don't know, discuss, and decide together, maybe? Make it, you know… um…"

Catra wanted to kiss her so badly. She wanted to let her finish more.

"I just…" Adora blew out a breath and laughed, bittersweet. "I feel like… even though I made the final decision to go to school and play soccer… Sometimes I feel like I was guided to that choice, almost? And that I didn't actually have much of a say in it." Catra felt Adora squeeze at her fingers before continuing. "I… don't know that I would have done it if I knew it meant leaving you behind."

Catra felt her heart pounding in her throat.

Adora's shoulders were a little tense, raised slightly in discomfort, but she kept going. "And I… I hope it' s okay that I want big decisions about my future to be made *with* you from now on. Because I want to

make sure you are a part of my future, too.”She looked so worried. “I want us to do this together .”

Catra didn’t say anything. She didn’t know how. Or what. She just needed a second.

Adora laughed again, seemingly full of shame, and pushed a palm against her forehead, cheeks burning with embarrassment. “I’m sorry, that’s..that’ s dumb and a *lot* and I totally understand if that’s not where you”—

The vibration of Adora’s cut off words against Catra’s lips melted into a content hum as they kissed, as Catra’s arms circled Adora’s neck, as Adora’s hold around Catra’s waist tightened. That’s all Catra needed to know - that Adora wanted a life with her. Everything else could be sorted out later.

What on earth had she been so afraid of?

“Y ou don’t get it, do you?”Catra mumbled through a smile as she pulled away. A slight worry seemed to wiggle its way onto Adora’s features, and Catra dragged her thumb over Adora’s lips. “I am so insanely head over heels in love with you, and I think I always have been. Even when I tried to convince myself that I never wanted to see you again.”

Adora’s brows knit together in that same fucking way they always have when she looked at Catra as she took in a shaky breath. “Y ou love me?”

A sigh escaped Catra’s lungs and she reached up to tuck a loose lock of hair back behind Adora’s ear. “Y ou’re such an idiot.”How could she not? “Of course I do.”

Adora didn’t have to say it back. Catra would be okay if Adora wasn’t ready to—

"I love you, too." There was no hesitation in her voice. None at all. Her hands rose up to cup Catra's jaw, thumbs dragging over her cheekbones. "I tried to tell you before. I never stopped."

"Never?"

She couldn't believe it. She wanted to.

"Not once. Not even for a second."

She did.

"So you're staying?" Catra asked, lifting her hands to wrap around Adora's wrists, begging for it to be true.

Adora nodded, a smile stretching on her cheeks as she pressed her forehead against Catra's. "I'm staying. I'm not going anywhere without you again." She pulled Catra in for another kiss, slow and deep and languid. "Besides," she said against her lips, "I *did* promise that I'd finish your house first."

A relieved laugh bubbled up from Catra's chest and she knew tears had sprung to the corners of her eyes, but she just didn't care. She didn't care that maybe it was still embarrassing to be this vulnerable. Adora was staying. And that's all she had ever wanted.

"You did, that's true."

Adora kissed her again, and held her as close as was physically possible.

Her stomach growling was what broke them apart. They had stayed pressed together for what could have been hours. It was probably just a minute or two, though. Catra leaned back with a glare at her own body as Adora chuckled brightly, lacing their fingers together again and kissing her knuckles.

"C'mon," Adora laughed as she pulled Catra back towards the reception hall. "Let's get you some food."



art by me

—

Catra was alcohol warm and god fucking damn it she was so overwhelmed with being surrounded by her favorite people in the world as they all danced like idiots and sang along to cheesy party music and Adora kept touching her and Scorpia kept looking at Adora touching her with absolute joy and Netossa kept winking every time they made eye contact and Adora's hands were on her hips and begging her to come closer and Catra just wanted to live in this moment for the rest of her life, maybe. She didn't even mind all the people she didn't know sharing the dance floor. There was nothing but wild positivity racing through her and she swore that nothing in the world could ruin this.

"I'm sorry I was late," Adora said into Catra's ear as she spun her around so that they were face to face. "I didn't mean to be late."

The music was too high energy for a slow dance, but Catra lifted her hands to Adora's shoulders anyway, swaying in some offbeat way. Catra's head rolled back as she laughed - definitely a little tipsier than she thought. "You were *sooooo* confident that you'd make it on time."

"To be fair I *was* back in time!"

"You just got *caught up* in something."

"Yep." That little mischievous smile was back on her lips. "Do you wanna know what it was?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Obviously!"

Giggles bubbled up from Adora's chest as she started swaying them back and forth with more energy, picking speed back up into their movements. "I moved all my stuff back and broke my lease."

"What?" She couldn't have heard that right. "You did what?"

Adora's face dropped slightly. "I moved all my stuff back." Panic flooded her features when Catra didn't respond. "It's I mean, I got a storage unit. I put all my stuff there. I mean. I left a *couple* things at your place in the barn but." She stopped moving, and took a step back from Catra. "Oh my god that was so presumptuous. Shit. I'm so sorry. I just have been spending most nights there so I thought maybe you wouldn't mind if"—

Catra shut her up with another kiss.

She liked shutting Adora up with kisses.

"You're there all the time anyway," Catra mumbled against her lips as Adora threaded her fingers through Catra's curls. "You should have some stuff there. I'm so okay with that." She shouldn't admit that she'd be fine with Adora moving all the way in. It was far too soon for *that* .

Plus, a broken lease meant she really, *really* was staying. Catra kissed Adora again.

"All right friends and family ," the DJ's voice cut in through the music. "The lovely brides have decided to do a double bouquet toss, everyone's invited! Let's see who's getting hitched next!"

Catra snorted a laugh. She had been surprised when Scorpia told her that she wanted to do it, since Catra personally thought it was kind of an outdated tradition; but Scorpia seemed to really love the idea of fate and true love and whatever else she had included in her lovestruck little tangent. It didn't mean she had to *participate* .

"C'mon," she heard from slightly above her , and looked up to see Adora's face laced with determination. "I think we can catch one."

Oh boy.

"You want to do it?" A hot blush only reddened Catra's cheeks further, building on the existing flush from the alcohol and physical exertion. And she had thought moving in together might be too much too soon.

But Adora was definitely teetering the line of drunk, and the glint in her eye seemed to shine more like she was ready for some spirited competition than a romantic gesture. "Uh, *duh.*" She pointed one hand to the other side of the room. "You stay here, and I'll go over there. We can increase our chances of catching one that way."

Yeah, definitely just competition. It was really fucking cute.

"Whatever you say, hot shot."

Adora hesitated for a second as the DJ called for last minute joiners, but then squeezed Catra's hand once before letting go and jogging to the other side of the room. Her ass looked fucking *amazing*. Catra swallowed that thought and turned her attention to the brides up front.

"All right, let's all remember to play fair and friendly!"

Scorpia and Perfuma gave each other a sweet kiss before turning their backs to the crowd.

Catra felt weirdly obligated to *try*. She scooted her feet a little further apart, prepared to dash for it if necessary, and kept her eyes locked on the bouquets.

"Three, two, one!"

The bouquets flew up, Catra readied herself, and she realized that one was coming directly at her. She wouldn't even have to move. If she believed in fate, she might have thought this was a sign or something.

She held her hands up to catch it before anyone around her could shove her out of the way, and jumped slightly when cheers broke out around her. Then she heard more cheering from the other side of the room, and pulled her bouquet close to her chest. Holding it evoked something childlike and giddy from deep within her and Catra felt a giggle bubble up from her chest.

"Catra!" She heard shouted through the crowd. "I got it!"

No fucking way.

If fate were real, it would be slapping her in the face.

Adora was running towards her, arms outstretched, elation radiating off of her. Her arms wrapped around Catra's waist and hoisted her off the ground in victory as Catra's hands circled Adora's neck, hanging on for dear life, the bouquet still clasped firmly in one fist.

"Put me down!" Catra laughed, kicking her feet as Adora let her slip through her arms.

The DJ broke through their bliss again. "Well what a fun ending! Looks like bouquets were caught by people who are already together! Guess we know what that means!"

Adora gasped and whipped her head around to finally see the bouquet in Catra's hand as the DJ started to prattle on about more dancing things, then stepped back far enough to hold both bouquets between them. Her eyes were shining as they found Catra's again, and Adora pulled her in by her waist. "Guess what?" Adora said, her words warm and enticing.

"What?" Catra was practically purring as Adora pressed their noses together.

"I," Adora started, hesitating for just one second before clearly deciding that she didn't care. "I am going to marry you."

Catra’s heart leapt into her throat. “You wanna marry me?”she teased, pretending like it hadn’t sparked a heavy, blossoming hope deep within her chest.

“Yep.”Adora popped the P as her hand slid up Catra’s back to spread out across her shoulder blades. “I have ever since we learned what marriage was from Weaver’s dumb soap operas.”

Catra laced her fingers into Adora’s hair as Adora spun her just far enough to dip her back, placing a soft, languid kiss on her lips. “We were like eight.”

“Yeah, and?”Adora’s voice was slightly disgruntled, making Catra feel like Adora couldn’t possibly imagine not knowing you wanted to spend the rest of your life with someone at the young age of eight. “I love you, and I promised myself almost twenty years ago that I was going to marry you one day. I’m not giving up on that.”

Catra curled her fingers under the straps of Adora’s blouse, blazer long since abandoned, and searched her eyes for any sort of confirmation;she found it, glistening in steel blue eyes that were blown out and wild like they couldn’t possibly find anything better to look at;like they couldn’t imagine wanting anything else.

Suddenly the idea of Adora moving in didn’t seem too big.

“You promise?”Catra asked, heart pounding so hard she thought it might break her ribs.

“I promise,”Adora said, and Catra believed her .

So she laughed, and pulled Adora down for their lips to meet once more.

“Then I’ll hold you to it, dummy .”

Chapter End Notes

Hi Friends :'))

We're at the end, there's just an epilogue left to wrap it up (which should be up pretty soon), and I just wanted to preemptively say thank you all so much for all your love and support of this silly little self indulgent cozy domestic fantasy of a fic :')) i've had an absolute blast writing it even if it took me over two years hahaha

I'll also toss this out there now: I plan to do some extras from Adora's POV. If there are any scenes you were wanting to see the other side of, or if you have any inquiries about Adora's perspective, please send me a message either on curiouscat or on tumblr!!

I'm a little behind on replying to reviews, but please know that I read and appreciate and love every single one of them :')) they make my whole day and really give me inspiration and excitement to write!!!

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Okay, keep your eyes closed"…

Catra blew out a laugh and gripped onto the wrists of the hands that were tightly covering her eyes from behind. "You say that as if your hands aren't death gripping my eyeballs."

She could almost hear Adora roll her eyes as she scoffed. "Well I'm *about* to let go, so keep your eyes closed!"

"*Fine*," Catra drawled out. Knowing Adora could feel her eyelashes under her hands, Catra overemphasized the squeezing of her eyes shut and waited for Adora to be satisfied that she genuinely wasn't looking. "They're closed."

Adora slowly removed her hands before shuffling quickly around Catra's body and leaning in close enough that Catra could feel her breath, as if she were checking if Catra could somehow miraculously see through her eyelids. Catra felt Adora lean back, but then she started waving her hands in front of Catra's face so hard that wind was hitting her cheeks. "Would you stop that?"

"You *can* see!" Adora yelled with a gasp, like Catra had committed the worst betrayal imaginable.

Sighing and squeezing her eyes tighter in hopes of placating Adora, Catra grumbled, "No, I can't. You're just flapping your hands around energetically enough that I can, unsurprisingly, feel it."

With a grunt of defeat, Adora very loudly slapped her hand onto a doorknob. "Okay, take my hand." She slipped her fingers into Catra's palm as the door started to creak open. "Now remember, we can

change it again, or you can stay in the other room."Catra felt her hand tense and start to shake just slightly. Adora squeezed her fingers tighter. "There's zero pressure at all, it's totally fine if you hate it."

"Adora."

"I'm just saying!"Adora huffed out a breath and swung the door open before guiding Catra in through the doorway. "I just don't want you to feel like you have to pretend to like it."

Catra couldn't help but laugh, tension in her shoulders easing just slightly. "I think you're mistaking me for someone way nicer right now."She heard a soft hum that teetered on agreement coming from beside her and started laughing harder. "Don't agree with me!"

"I didn't say anything!"

Warm hands pressed into her shoulders and jostled her around, clearly trying to make sure she was in the perfect spot. Catra's hair bounced around her ears as Adora definitely added a few extra, unnecessary shoves in there before settling her into place with a soft giggle. "Okay, wait right here."

Catra's heartbeat was thrumming through her head with excitement and nerves and a touch of anxiety because she really *hadn't* stepped foot into this room since she left at nineteen. She wasn't sure that anything could break through the dark corners of this room that still haunted her.

Sunlight kissed her cheeks as she heard curtains being shoved wide open, something slid against the wood floor, and Adora's heavy footsteps came back to stand beside her. Adora laced their hands together and sucked in a breath. "Okay,"she said, voice strained and tight. "You can open your eyes now."

Catra had to blink against the bright room a few times before her eyes adjusted, scanning slowly from one wall to the other. Oh. She

felt her face fall, and felt a slight tremble start in her hands. *Oh.*

"Oh no," Adora mumbled, squeezing her fingers tighter and stepping in front of Catra as if to try and block her view. "Shit, I'm sorry."

"What?" Catra shook her head and looked back and forth from Adora's concerned face to the fresh room that stood in front of her. It looked almost unrecognizable. It looked...perfect.

Adora wrapped her arms around Catra's shoulders, tucking Catra's face into the curve of her neck. Catra couldn't help but instinctively lift her hands to dig her nails into Adora's shoulder blades. "I'm sorry, we don't ever have to come in here again. Thank you for letting me try and it's totally okay that you still don't want to be in here."

"Wait, no," Catra breathed, pulling back and meeting Adora's gaze. It was only then that she noticed the wetness on her cheeks and Adora's shirt. Oh. No wonder Adora had been concerned. "No, Adora, it's..."

Adora's throat bobbed with a hard swallow as she continued to scan over Catra's face, searching for clarity.

"It's *perfect*, I...I love it."

"Oh."

They just stared at each other for a moment, before Adora asked, quietly, as if she might be afraid of the answer, "you do?"

Catra dragged her eyes around the room again, admiring the new additions. The difference was in the details, and Adora had nailed it. The walls were a soft, muted coral with all new baseboards. She had torn down the garish crown molding that Catra had hated so much, and instead left crisp lines of paint where the edges met. The doors and frames had even all been changed. "I..." She stepped forward and dragged her hands along the new furniture. "I do. I *really* do."

She turned back to Adora, whose face had filled with relief. "How did you afford all of this?"

"Oh, um," she started, her cheeks flushing pink. "W ell for the renovations I had some money set aside anyway, and got some good deals from old friends"…

Catra's brow raised in a question, but she chose to let it slide.

"Then, um, the furniture is, uh, the stuf f from my apartment. So that wasn't any extra money."

Huh.

"But it' s just a placeholder!" she scrambled to add on. "If you're not okay with that, we can get new stuff. I just..it was all just sitting in storage..so." Adora was digging her toes into the floor , her eyes darting all over the room, as if she were too embarrassed to look at Catra.

Catra kept moving around the room, running her fingers across everything she could easily touch. "Adora, seriously , it's perfect. And I like..that it' s yours." Her cheeks flushed at the admission, and she made her way towards the opposite side of the room.

Adora had somehow changed the biggest window into an inset seat surrounded by built-in bookshelves. At some point she apparently had also moved Catra's books in, and filled all the extra space with knick knacks from around the house and some framed photos. Catra paused in front of it, picking up some pictures she hadn't seen before.

There was a trifold of wedding photos - the whole bridal party in the middle, a candid of her and Scorpia laughing at the reception, and a photo that the photographer snapped of Adora dipping and kissing her after they had caught the bouquets. Arms wrapped around her waist from behind as she ran her fingers down the glass, tapping her

nails against it. Adora's chin hooked over her shoulder as Catra bit her lip and refused to cry.

"I made one other big change - you wanna see?"

Catra swallowed against the lump in her throat and nodded, leaning into the press of Adora's lips against her temple. A laugh bubbled up from her chest as Adora - without letting go of Catra - started walking them over towards the old office space that Weaver had in her bedroom, always hidden behind a locked door.

With a grunt, Adora let go of Catra's waist just long enough to grip the handle. "So we'll pretend I didn't have to break the lock to get in here, but." She swung the door open to reveal a bright, sunny room, with windows on two walls that were almost floor to ceiling, and…

"Ta-daaaa!"

Adora had installed shelving on the walls that were full of canvases and paints and brushes and Catra felt her whole heart swell behind her ribs.

"I thought you might like a little studio space. I found all of this out in the shed, so I hope it's okay that I brought it inside?" Adora's voice lilted into an almost question, seeking confirmation.

Catra hadn't painted much in the last few years, but the itch had been there for a while now.

She didn't know what to say.

Instead, she turned around in Adora's arms so that they were face to face, lifted her hands up to cup Adora's jaw, and kissed her. Softly. Sweetly. Hopefully it was enough to convey all of the love she was feeling.

"I love you," Catra whispered when they parted, pressing another chaste kiss to Adora's lips. "I love everything you've done. I… I just love you."

Adora gave her that crooked smile and upturned eyebrows look that had become so frequent on her face again, and stroked her hands up Catra's back. "I love you, too. And I have *one* more thing."

Catra wasn't sure she could physically take anything else.

Adora let her go and took quick steps over towards the closet, sliding open the mirrored door. She fussed around for a few seconds before she whipped out her old letterman jacket from high school, shaking it a couple times as if to air it out. "I found it, um, in the shed as well. I'm… honestly surprised you still had it."

"Wait, what?" Catra blinked a few times before stepping closer and pinching the sleeve between her fingers. "No, you took it back to school with you, didn't you?"

Confusion was etched across Adora's features. "No. I… left it here because you wore it all the time? And I just assumed you like, trashed it or something after we broke up."

"No, I remember distinctly," Catra said, pulling it from Adora's hands and squeezing the fabric between her fingers. It was exactly like she remembered it. "We got into that fight right before you left. And I… when I went to wear it later, it was gone. I assumed you took it on your way out… and then when you never brought it back I… it…"

It was just another thing that made Catra believe that they were doomed.

Adora furrowed her brows together, looking all over the room as if trying to think. "No, I… left it here on purpose after that. Because… I thought maybe you'd be less mad if you had a good reminder of me… and—and when I was leaving, Weaver asked me if it was mine"—

"Oh, are you fucking kidding me?" Catra knew her voice was full of anger. She took a deep breath when Adora looked concerned. "She probably fucking hid it."

"Oh," Adora gasped, smacking the heel of her hand against her forehead. "Shit, you're so right!"

"I wore it all the time!" Catra practically yelled, mild rage still simmering just below the surface. "She knew it was yours, and I bet she knew it'd make me upset to think you took it back!"

Catra shook it with a little more force than was probably necessary before sliding it over her arms. It enveloped her like a warm hug, safe and comforting. Her embers of fury melted in its embrace.

"Fuck her," Adora said as she stepped closer, her hands rising up to squeeze at Catra's arms through the leather, worn and softened with age. "She doesn't deserve another thought."

She didn't. Not one more fucking thought.

"Is anything of hers left here, or did you get rid of everything?" Catra asked, eyes looking around the room.

Adora scrunched her face up in thought and hummed. "There's some stuff left in the barn that I hadn't gotten rid of yet - just some paperwork and some pictures from the office, I think."

With a nod, Catra grabbed Adora's hand and started heading towards the stairs. "Okay. I want to burn it."

"You do?" Adora laughed, a little nervously.

"Yes. I want absolutely nothing of her left in this fucking house."

Catra paused as they reached the bottom of the stairs, hesitating for just a minute. "It's just... it's *mine* now. My home. And you've done so much and it's fucking amazing. I just... I need the rest of it gone, too. And I think... doing it myself might help."

Adora kissed her, soft and deep, and said, "then let' s do it. Every last piece."

Every last piece.

Chapter End Notes

> Aaaand that's officially a wrap :') I know I said most of what I wanted to say at the end of the last chapter, but seriously, thank you guys all so much for the support over the last couple years. This fic means so much to me and it warms my heart that it meant so much to some of you, too ♡
>
> I've got plenty more catradora fics in the works, dont you worry, and a few extras in mind for this guy as well ♡ Please make sure to subscribe to the series this is a part of in order to get notified for those!! :)
>
> As always, comments literally mean the whole world to me, and I'd love to hear your thoughts and feelings 🥹 please also come hang out with me on twitter & tumblr!!!

Works inspired by this one: Take Me Home, Make Me Come by DandyVela, sapphwriter

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!